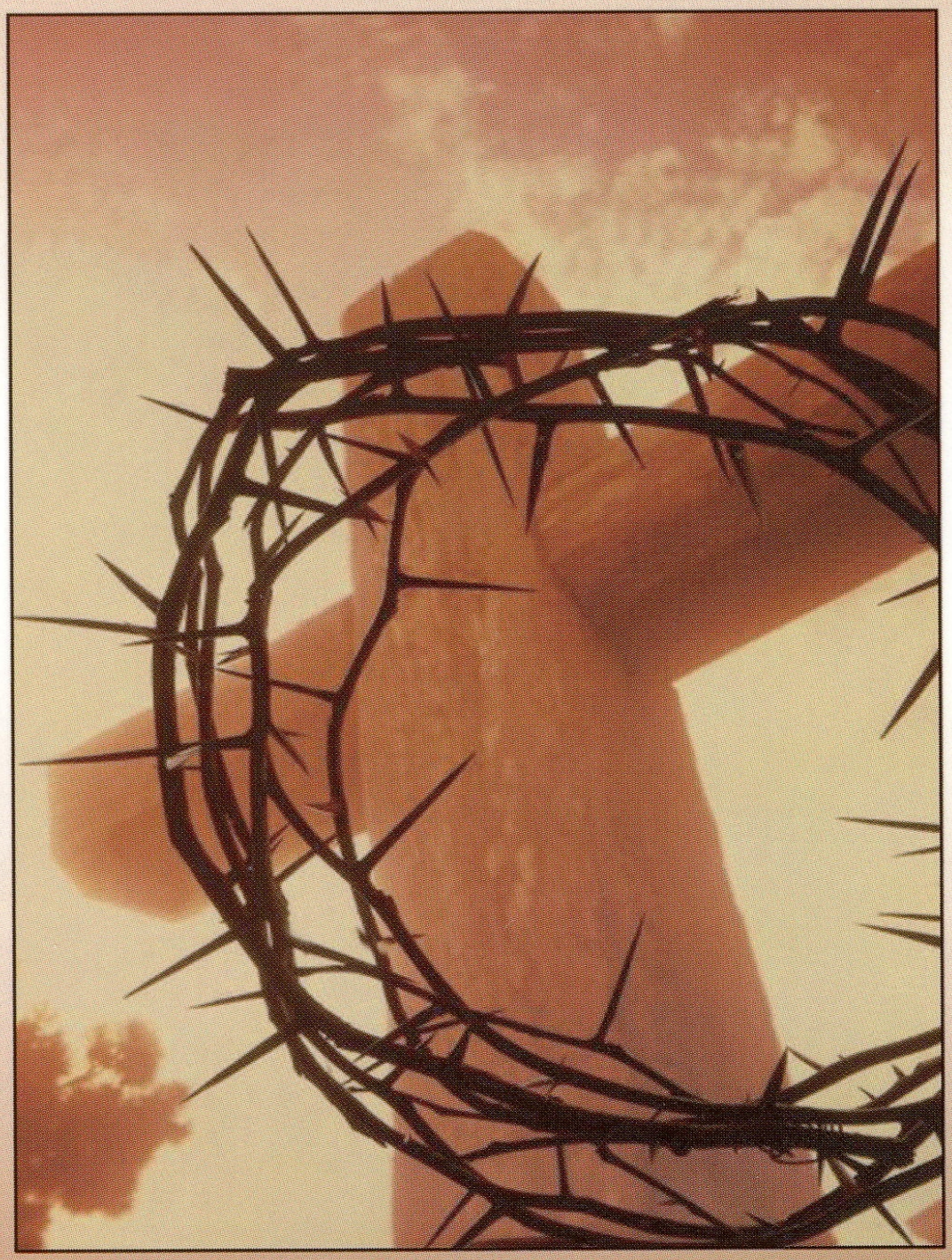
COLOSSIANS

The Preeminence of Christ



C.R. STAM

COMMENTARY

on

COLOSSIANS

By

Cornelius R. Stam

Founder of the *Berean Bible Society*
and
Author of over Thirty Bible Study Books,
Including the Classic Work: *Things That Differ*

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Dedication

This volume is dedicated to all those who acknowledge the preeminence of Christ.

IN GRATEFUL ACKNOWLEDGMENT

We gratefully acknowledge the many friends who helped in the preparation of this volume.

To RoseAnn Kees who transcribed the audio tapes of Pastor Stam's messages on Colossians, which originally aired over our *Bible Time* radio broadcast. If you look up the word "patience" in the dictionary you will find a picture of RoseAnn.

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To Kevin Sadler who methodically typeset the entire volume. So what you see on the page before you is a result of Kevin's careful layout and alignment. This is no small task with the complex typesetting programs we use these days.

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Most of all, we owe heartfelt thanks to God who upheld us and guided us through the entire project. May this work be to the praise of His glory in Christ Jesus.

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PREFACE

Some families are blessed with longevity, and this is certainly true of the Stam family. Most of Pastor Stam's siblings lived well into their nineties. In fact, his sister, Clazina, was called home to be with the Lord a few years ago at the age of 103. Amazingly, she was still faithfully writing 100 letters per month to missionaries, family, and friends around the world until shortly before her home going.

Brother Stam shared with me when he was in his late eighties, that his older brothers and sisters at the time called him "the kid" of the family. I can still hear him laughing and exclaiming in that deep booming voice of his, "*Ho, ho, ho,* but I feel as old as they do!" At the time of this writing Pastor Stam is now 94 years old and unable to do the work of the ministry any longer due to failing health. Desiring to continue his legacy, we have transcribed and edited the messages that he preached over our *Bible Time* radio broadcast so everyone can enjoy the wonderful truth of Paul's epistle to the Colossians.

For over 60 years Pastor Stam has faithfully defended Paul's apostleship and message. Of course it is the Book of Colossians where the Apostle Paul brings us into the very pinnacle of Grace truth, especially in regard to the preeminence of Christ. As the Head of the Body, Christ holds the preeminent position in the Church. This wonderful truth was a special revelation solely committed to Paul. With the skill of a master conductor, Pastor Stam effectively brings forth a symphony of light on this subject and others.

As we know, the Apostle Paul was an able defender of the faith. Perhaps one of the most insidious attacks

he encountered was the false teaching of *Gnosticism*. Pastor Stam exposes the danger of this heresy and cautions us to beware of those who promote this unsound doctrine today. Like Paul, may we also fight the good fight of the faith.

It is our prayer that this volume will help you grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. "Now unto Him that is able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that worketh in us. Unto Him be glory in the Church by Christ Jesus throughout all ages, world without end. Amen."

Paul M. Sadler
President

Milwaukee, Wisconsin
May 27, 2002

INTRODUCTION TO COLOSSIANS

GRACE BROUGHT OUR LORD FROM ALL HIS GLORY IN HEAVEN

Now of all Paul's wonderful epistles, perhaps the most wonderful of all are those he wrote that are called the Ephesian, the Philippian, and the Colossian epistles. One of them, at least, was a circular letter, but these are the names they bear.

These three epistles belong together as a group because they all have particularly to do with Christ and the Church, which is His Body.

Ephesians has as its basic theme the "*Body*," and its relation to the *Head*, Christ. *Colossians* has to do with *Christ*, the Head and *His relation* to the Body. No other epistle is as "Christ-full" as this letter of Paul, the Apostle to the Colossians. Finally, Philippians deals with the *members* of the Body of Christ in their relation to *each other*.

Colossians, of course, was written or dictated by Paul. However, in his introduction he associates Timothy with himself as he does in five of his other letters: II Corinthians, Philippians, I Thessalonians, II Thessalonians and Philemon. He writes to the Colossians as "*an apostle of Jesus Christ by the will of God*" (1:1). Colossians is another of his great *doctrinal* epistles.

So these three epistles—Ephesians, Philippians, and Colossians—are connected together and the great theme of Colossians is *Christ*; not as He was when on earth, but as He is today, now, glorified in heaven as the Head of the Church, a spiritual Body whose members are found in and out of every religious denomination, and all over the world.

As we read on, it soon becomes evident that the Apostle had been used only indirectly to found this church. He personally had never seen the Colossians (1:4,5; 2:1). How touching is the Apostle's love and concern for even unknown souls lately won to Christ! He had not even seen these brethren, yet he continually prayed for them, and with much thanksgiving (1:3).

Paul was never satisfied with signatures on dotted lines. In Acts 15:36,41, we find him traveling back to numerous cities, to small churches he had founded, to "*see how they do*." His epistles bear witness to his genuine and continuing concern for those whom he had been used, directly or indirectly, to win to Christ. In some cases he had stayed on the scene for considerable periods of time, to make sure that the congregations were well established. He had stayed at Corinth for a year and a half and at Ephesus for three years.

The Epistle to the Colossians is basically about the Lord Jesus Christ, including *what Christ has done for us*. In Colossians 1:5 he begins by referring to "*the hope which is laid up for you in heaven*," reminding them how they had heard about this hope "in the word of *the truth of the gospel*." This hope is vastly different from that which Christ and the twelve proclaimed while our Lord was on earth. Israel's hope has always been *earthly* in sphere. Daniel prophesied that after other kingdoms had risen and fallen, the "God of heaven" would set up a kingdom on earth which would never be destroyed (Dan. 2:44). John the Baptist, our Lord, and the twelve proclaimed this "kingdom of [not *in*] Heaven" (Matt. 3:1,2; 4:17; 10:5-7). The Lord promised the twelve that at His return to earth they would sit with Him on twelve

thrones, *"judging the twelve tribes of Israel"* (Matt. 19:28). Even in the gospel according to John, much of which has been so grossly misread, it is the establishment of the kingdom of God on earth that is in view.[1] Even at Pentecost, Peter did not tell his hearers: "Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and He will take you up there." Rather he said, "Repent, and God will send Jesus down here" (Acts 3:19-21).

It is not until we reach Paul's epistles that we find a message about salvation by grace through faith *alone*, based on the all-sufficient, *finished* work of Christ at Calvary. It is not until we come to these epistles that we learn of *"the hope which is laid up for you in heaven"* (Col. 1:5) and our *present* position and blessings in the heavenlies, in Christ (Eph. 1:3; 2:4-7). This message is powerful, and has brought forth much precious spiritual fruit, as the Apostle says in Verse 6:

"Which is come unto you, as it is in all the world; and bringeth forth fruit, as it doth also in you, since the day ye heard of it, and knew the grace of God in truth" (Col. 1:6).

Is this message less effective today? Has it lost its power? Is it irrelevant to the difficult times in which we live? By no means! There is abundant evidence on every hand of the power of the gospel of the grace of God in the lives of those who open their hearts to it. How we wish that we could induce some pastors—yes, some "grace pastors"—to stop preaching on all kinds of peripheral subjects, while neglecting the great truths contained in that blessed message of grace which Paul calls "my gospel." Let us never forget that this message is *our message* too. Let us never apologize for proclaiming Jesus Christ *"according to the revelation of the Mystery"*—for this IS *our gospel* (Rom. 16:25).

Some have charged us with riding a hobby horse because we have made this *our* message through the years, and have related everything in the Bible to it. To these criticisms we respond: "Was Ezra riding a hobby horse when he read only the Law from morning to midday, and bound its precepts upon the hearts of his hearers (Neh. 8:2,3,8)? Of course not. He lived under the dispensation of the Law. That was his God-given message to Israel. Were the twelve apostles riding a hobby when they went everywhere, during our Lord's earthly ministry, preaching "the gospel of the kingdom"? They were not. This was the message they were *sent* to proclaim (Matt. 10:5-7). Nor are we riding a hobby when we consistently, faithfully proclaim the unadulterated "gospel of the grace of God," and the blessed truths of the Mystery revealed through Paul. Rather we would prove to be unfaithful if we began to change our message or water it down by preaching largely on current events, political problems, family living, or by spending undue time denouncing abortion, sexual perversion, violence, etc. When we make these things our theme we are at best cutting bad fruit from a bad tree rather than laying the ax to the *root* of the tree.

We pray that God will use these words to bring some pastors back to that blessed message which ought to be their theme: "the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the Mystery" (Rom. 16:25). When they do get back to this message they will never have enough time to preach it all. The scope is so vast and broad, the necessity for preaching so urgent, that they will soon have a backlog of messages they have never had the time to bring.

—Pastor Cornelius R. Stam

Chapter 1 — Colossians 1:1-8

PAUL, AND THE COLOSSIAN CHURCH

THE OPENING SALUTATION

An Apostle of Jesus Christ by the Will of God

"Paul, an apostle of Jesus Christ by the will of God, and Timotheus our brother,

"To the saints and faithful brethren in Christ which are at Colosse: Grace be unto you, and peace, from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ" (Col. 1:1,2).

"AND TIMOTHEUS OUR BROTHER"

Timothy as you recall was Paul's "own son in the faith" (I Tim. 1:2). He had been won to Christ through Paul's ministry and had become a very faithful partner in the work of the Lord. But Paul doesn't always link Timothy's name with his own in the same way. For example, when he writes to the Philippians, he opens his letter with the words, "Paul and Timotheus, the *servants* of Jesus Christ." This is because the Philippian letter is *not* basically doctrinal or theological in character. It was written to patch up a quarrel in the Philippian church and, if possible, to restore unity. Paul wanted them to feel that the plea came from simple servants of Christ, and that the plea came from both Timothy and himself as he appealed to them to work and worship together in unity.

The Colossian letter, however, is entirely different. It is basically doctrinal, basically theological in character. It has to do with the great revelation

committed to Paul by the glorified Lord in heaven. So he takes the responsibility for everything he says upon himself, and he calls himself—not a servant of Jesus Christ as in Philippians (1:1)—but *"an apostle of Jesus Christ"*, and he links Timothy with himself simply as a *brother*, both theirs and his.

In fact, the original doesn't really say "Paul an apostle of Jesus Christ," because there is no indefinite article in the Greek. Actually, it would read more like this: "Paul—apostle of Jesus Christ" or "Paul, Jesus Christ's apostle, and Timothy, our brother."

PAUL, NOT ONE OF THE TWELVE APOSTLES

Now this may seem like a very little thing but in reality it is very important, because Paul was not just one of the apostles as so many people seem to think, and as so many preachers still make him. His apostleship was absolutely separate and distinct from that of the twelve. That doesn't mean he had nothing ever to do with the twelve, but it does mean that he was raised up later as *another* apostle with *another* message which *superceded* theirs.

As you'll remember, they were sent to preach the gospel of the kingdom, and our Lord promised them twelve thrones in that kingdom:

"And Jesus said unto them, Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed Me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of His glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matt. 19:28).

Under the so-called Great Commission—under *their* great commission—the twelve were sent to make disciples of all nations, beginning at Jerusalem:

"Ye shall be witnesses unto Me both in Jerusalem, and all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth" (Acts 1:8).

And you remember how Peter at Pentecost declared that God had raised the Lord Jesus from the dead to sit on the throne of David. These are the very words he said:

"Men and brethren, let me freely speak unto you of the patriarch David, that he is both dead and buried, and his sepulchre is with us unto this day.

"Therefore being a prophet, and knowing that God had sworn with an oath to him, that of the fruit of his loins, according to the flesh, *He would raise up Christ to sit on his throne*;

"He seeing this before spake of the resurrection of Christ" (Acts 2:29-31).

In other words, Peter says here that according to prophecy God had raised up Christ to sit on David's throne. Peter then called upon the people to repent so that Christ would come back, that is, to repent of having crucified Him so that He would return and the long-promised times of refreshing would still come. Here is *Peter*, not Paul, but Peter speaking to the house of Israel:

"Repent ye therefore, and be converted, that your sins may be blotted out, [that so] the times of refreshing [may] come from the presence of the Lord;

"And He shall send Jesus Christ, which before was preached unto you:

"Whom the heaven must receive until the times of restitution [or, the setting right] of all things, which God hath spoken by the mouth of all His holy prophets since the world began" (Acts 3:19-21).

AN APOSTLE BY THE WILL OF GOD

But as you know the favored nation did not repent and Christ did not—indeed, has not yet—returned.

And the wonderful times of refreshing did not come, and have not yet come. Now how could these twelve apostles go and make disciples of the other nations when their own nation had not yet received Messiah? According to prophecy, Christ is to reign—not in Washington or London or Paris—but at Jerusalem. So when Jerusalem and the chosen nation did not receive Christ, God interrupted the Prophetic Program and sent forth *another* apostle to usher in *another* dispensation. Not that God was taken by surprise. Not at all. He knew all about this.

In fact, He had another program called "the Mystery" in mind all the while, and He says that this Mystery was "kept secret since the world began." It was planned and purposed by God "before the world began," but not until "now" was it "made known" to and through the Apostle Paul. So when Jerusalem and the chosen nation did not receive Christ, God interrupted the Prophetic Program and sent forth another apostle, the Apostle Paul, to usher in *"the dispensation of the grace of God,"* under which we now live. And this explains why, at the great Jerusalem council held eighteen years after Pentecost, the apostles there shook hands with Paul and Barnabas in a solemn, official, public agreement, that from then on, *he*, not they, should be the Apostle of the Nations:

"And when James, [Peter], and John, who seemed to be pillars, *perceived* the grace that was given unto me, they gave to me and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship; that we should go unto the [Gentiles], and they unto the circumcision" (Gal. 2:9).

So here the leaders of the twelve, and the elders at Jerusalem among the believers there, actually agreed publicly and officially that *not they* but Paul should now be the Apostle to *all* nations. This is

why in Colossians 1:1 and elsewhere, Paul calls himself *"AN APOSTLE OF JESUS CHRIST BY THE WILL OF GOD."*

"THE APOSTLE OF THE GENTILES"

Now this is very clear. It was not men that chose Paul, or made him an apostle. Men were not even used of God to do it. It was not even by man, but by Jesus Christ, and God the Father, who raised Christ from the dead, that Paul was made an Apostle of Jesus Christ.

"But I certify you, brethren, that the gospel which was preached of me is not after man. For I neither received it of man, neither was I taught it, but by the revelation of Jesus Christ" (Gal. 1:11,12).

Thus we must recognize that the Apostle Paul had a very different status than the twelve apostles and that his ministry superceded theirs. This is why Paul writes to the Romans:

***"For I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as I am the Apostle of the Gentiles, I magnify mine office"* (Rom. 11:13).**

Now then, with this in mind, so that we may fully recognize that Paul's epistle to the Colossians is related to us, and to our times, let us proceed.

THE BRETHREN AT COLOSSE

"To the *saints* and *faithful brethren* in Christ which are at Colosse: Grace be unto you, and peace, from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ" (Col. 1:2).

Interestingly all the Colossian believers were called saints. Notice carefully that they were brethren, and *saints*. They were not canonized as saints some hundreds of years after their death. They were

saints—God's own special people set apart to Himself right then *by faith* in Christ. And allow me to emphasize this, my friend, if you don't become a saint in this life you'll never become one in the next. It is *believers* in this life whom God calls *saints*. There is not one word in the Bible about the canonization of saints by miracles hundreds of years after their death. It is the believers in the here and now whom God calls saints. This has nothing to do with good works or miracles or piety. In effect, it has to do with belonging to God as His own children, as His own special people. Paul declared of believers at Galatia:

"Ye are all the children of God *by faith* in Christ Jesus" (Gal. 3:26).

That is why, whether he writes to the Romans whom he had never seen, or the Colossians whom he had never seen; or whether he writes to the believers at Corinth who certainly were not all that they should be as far as their behavior and conduct was concerned, he nevertheless addresses them *all* as *saints*, saints in Christ. Notice that in Colossians 1:2, he calls them "saints and faithful brethren."

In the original, the word *faithful* simply means, "*full of faith*." It is used all through the Scriptures, both subjectively and objectively. If it's used *subjectively*, it simply means that they were the kind of people that could be trusted. They were "faithful" in the sense that we use the word trustworthy.

But if it is used *objectively*, it means simply that they trusted Christ as Savior. You see, even the word faith can be used both subjectively and objectively. I might say, "If I have faith *in* you, you had better *keep* faith with me." Now the former is objective—it goes from me to you, I have faith in you. But you had

better be trustworthy; you had better "keep faith" with me, or you will not be trusted for very long. Here the former is probably the correct use. They were trustworthy.

He writes to "the *saints* and faithful *brethren* in Christ." The word "saints" shows their relationship to God; the word "brethren," their relationship to each other. Notice, also, that he addresses these saints and believing brethren in their beautiful two-fold location—*"IN Christ"* and *"AT Colosse."*

"Therefore if any man be *in Christ*, [there is] a new [creation]" (II Cor. 5:17).

Paul says that believers are "accepted in the Beloved [One]" (Eph. 1:6), and pronounced "complete in Him" (Col. 2:10). God looks at us no more in our poor selves, but *in Christ*. That was their spiritual location.

The second phrase, "at Colosse", denotes their physical location—that doesn't matter much. That is not important; but our spiritual location does matter.

Let me ask you, my dear friend, how does God view you? How does He look at you? In yourself, or in Christ? Remember, at Calvary, Christ took *your* place and He hung there as a guilty criminal, not only for us, but as us. But now, thank God, *by faith* we may take our place "in Him", and God will look upon us *"in Christ"* because He is the one who paid for our sins and put them away by the sacrifice of Himself.

GRACE AND PEACE

Notice what he says with regard to the saints and faithful brethren in Christ which were at Colosse:

***"Grace be unto you, and peace, from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ"* (Col. 1:2).**

Now this "*grace*" and "*peace*" is the very theme of Paul's message. This is something of the background and the reason why. God had always predicted in the Old Testament that when men rejected Christ He would judge them. This prediction is still to be carried out, for even though God has interrupted the Prophetic Program, the Lord Jesus Christ is coming back again. Revelation 19:11 states that He is coming to "judge and make war." *Judgment* and *war* are the very opposite of *grace* and *peace*. Christ was rejected long ago. The favored nation Israel and the world turned against Him, and sent Him out as an exile from His own world, the world that He Himself had created. And for that reason they were to be judged. But God said, Not yet!

When sin had risen to its height, He saved Saul of Tarsus, the chief of sinners, and made him the apostle of grace, to usher in the present dispensation of Grace in which any poor sinner, judged and condemned to die, may find salvation and justification through faith in the finished work of Christ at Calvary. And so the very theme of Paul's message to saints and sinners alike is not judgment and war today, but "*grace* be unto you, and *peace*," the salutation he uses in every one of his letters.

And this "grace" and "peace" is "*from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ*." Why just those two members of the Trinity? Why not all three? Again, a reminder of that prophetic Scripture where, in Psalm 110:1, the Father says to the Son:

"Sit Thou at My right hand, until I make Thine enemies Thy footstool."

But the Psalmist speaks about man's rejection of Christ too, and how God will speak unto them in His wrath:

"Why do the heathen [nations] rage, and the people imagine a vain thing?

"The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the Lord, and against His anointed, saying,

"Let us break their bands asunder, and cast away their cords from us.

"He that sitteth in the heavens shall laugh: The Lord shall have them in derision.

"Then shall He speak unto them in His wrath, and vex them in His sore displeasure" (Psa. 2:1-5).

The Father will judge this world because of its rejection of His Son—but not yet. For now He offers "*grace*" and "*peace*" from God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

Oh, what a blessed, wonderful truth for a world doomed to judgment! Listen to the radio and TV and see how this world is headed to judgment. They can't run the ship of state right, and it won't run right, until Christ, *the Prince of Peace*, reigns (Isa. 9:6). But in the meantime, God is still sending out His wonderful offer of "*grace*" and "*peace*" to a world of lost sinners.

THE TRUTH OF THE GOSPEL

"We give thanks to God and the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, praying always for you,

"Since we heard of your faith in Christ Jesus, and of the love which ye have to all the saints,

"For the hope which is laid up for you in heaven, whereof ye heard before in the word of the truth of the gospel" (Col. 1:3-5).

Salvation was of vital importance to the Apostle Paul. The great Greek philosophers had all contributed their ideas about how to achieve happiness, or

at least serenity, in this hectic world. But Paul was not one of them. He had faced the *fact* of man's fallen and guilty state and had come to know the Lord Jesus Christ, God the Son, as the One who in mercy and love had *died* to pay for man's sin, and to redeem him from the judgment to come.

Hence, as others came to trust Christ as Savior, Paul didn't merely rejoice that they had come to see his viewpoint. It wasn't merely a case of two, or six, or twelve more for our side. By no means. He saw them rather as sinners saved from terrible judgment and made saints, and justified, and glorified, in Christ. And he gave thanks to God for them every day, praying without ceasing that they might grow in grace and be used of God, too, for the salvation of others.

THE ABIDING TRINITY

But how could the Apostle tell that they were truly saved? Man can't look on the heart and in that sense we can never tell. But what did he consider the true evidences of salvation? Were they baptism and the ability to work miracles or some such thing of that kind? What were these evidences of salvation? Well, he tells us quite clearly in this very passage. Notice there are three things that he emphasizes here. He had heard of their "*faith*," their "*hope*," and their "*love*."

***"Since we heard of your faith in Christ Jesus, and of the love which ye have to all the saints"* (Col. 1:4).**

YOUR FAITH AND LOVE

Faith and love are two of the evidences of genuine conversion to Christ. Whatever you do, my dear friends, never get these transposed. Some think that

salvation depends on their love to Christ or their dependence on the saints. Our love to Christ!? Do you want to know what love is? Why, the greatest sacrifice that man has ever made for God, has never even begun to equal the great sacrifice He made for us, because He loved us so.

"But God commendeth His love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us" **(Rom. 5:8).**

"Herein is love, not that we loved God, but that He loved us, and sent His Son to be the propitiation [payment] for our sins" (I John 4:10).

"We love Him, because He first loved us" **(I John 4:19).**

"BUT GOD, WHO IS RICH IN MERCY, FOR HIS GREAT LOVE WHEREWITH HE LOVED US, EVEN WHEN WE WERE DEAD IN SINS" **(Eph. 2:4,5).**

Are you aware that Paul never exhorts us to love Christ or to love God? Rather he is always telling us about Christ's love to us. And love begets love.

Some preachers are always exhorting their people to love God more and to love Christ more. That's like saying to a young lady, "You ought to try and love that man." Well, she just can't command love and make herself love him. You would do much better telling her *about* him, everything wonderful about him, and especially what *he* thinks of her. How he loves her—then you're going to get somewhere.

And as to faith in the saints, you had better *not* place your faith in the saints. You will surely be deeply disappointed if you do. Somebody has said that the very best of men are only men at the very best, and that is so true. No, it's not your love for Christ or your faith in the saints, but rather your *faith in Christ* and your *love* to the saints that proves the genuineness of salvation.

THE HOPE LAID UP FOR YOU IN HEAVEN

The third evidence in this little passage has to do with the hope that these Colossians had. Paul thanked God for "*the hope, which is laid up for [them] in heaven*." The implication, of course, is that they were rejoicing in that *hope*. They were eagerly anticipating heaven, and the blessings that awaited them there. And so there were three indications that convinced the Apostle Paul that these Colossians were genuine converts to Christ, that they had been born again, that they had been regenerated and made new creations in the Lord Jesus Christ. It was their *faith*, their *hope*, and their *love*.

FROM CHILDHOOD TO MATURITY

Now from Paul's own letters, he clearly is not willing that believers should wait until heaven to pass from childhood to maturity. Spiritual maturity should not be just a future destiny. Paul chided the Corinthians for their failure to *grow* in the truth, and he called them *carnal* and *babes*:

"And I, brethren, could not speak unto you as unto spiritual, but as unto carnal, even as unto babes in Christ.

"I have fed you with milk, and not with meat: for hitherto ye were not able to bear it, neither yet now are ye able.

"For ye are yet carnal: for whereas there is among you envying, and strife, and divisions, are ye not carnal, and walk as men?" (I Cor. 3:1-3).

And in Ephesians 4:14,15 he exhorts us:

"That we henceforth be no more children, tossed to and fro, and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the sleight of men, and cunning craftiness, whereby they lie in wait to deceive;

"But speaking the truth in love, may grow up into Him in all things, which is the Head, even Christ."

And again in Colossians he speaks of his intense efforts to "present every man perfect [*full-grown*] in Christ" (Col. 1:28). He tells how Epaphras joined him "in prayers, that ye may stand perfect and complete [mature] in all the will of God" (4:12).

FAITH, HOPE, AND LOVE

In I Corinthians 13, Paul punctuates his discussion regarding the passing of the sign gifts with the following statement:

***"And now abideth faith, hope, charity [love]; these three; but the greatest of these is charity"* (I Cor. 13:13).**

The word "now" is used here in a logical rather than a temporal sense. It could be rendered, "and so these three remain, the others are done away, so these three remain." It's the next logical step in his argument that while some things will pass away to be replaced by others, there are certain basic factors which will abide and remain. These are *faith*, *hope*, and *love*. And with the passing of the sign gifts, these give full and sufficient evidence of a normal, healthy, Christian experience.

Let those of *that day* possess the sign gifts, Paul said, and they'll grow in grace, and they'll pass from a natural infancy to maturity; from that which is "in part," to "that which is perfect [fully developed, or full-grown]." But let the believer *today* possess "faith, hope and love," and in that measure, they will be kept from spiritual decline.

Now these three are a trinity. You may speak of one, two, or three of them, but every one affects the other. Each is equally important in its own way but love is the *greatest*. It is the crowning virtue and is of paramount importance.

Yet we have to agree that faith is of *primary* importance. Faith must come first—"without faith it is impossible to please Him" (Heb. 11:6).

And hope, or expectancy, that is of *perpetual* importance. It lies at the very center of our daily Christian experience.

Ah, there's so very much to say about these. It was these three graces that the apostle looked for in each one of the churches. He judged the genuineness of their profession by measuring the absence or presence of their *faith*, *hope*, and *love*.

Faith in Christ, *love* to the brethren, and *hope* for heaven and the coming of Christ, and the blessings that will be ours when we see Him.

Thus in the Colossian epistle we find this trio again, for the Apostle says:

"We give *thanks* to God and the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, praying always for you,
"Since we heard of your *faith* in Christ Jesus, and of the *love* which ye have to all the saints,
"For the *hope* which is laid up for you in heaven…" (Col. 1:3-5).

From all this it is evident that, notwithstanding the claims of many dear Christian people, the Great Commission and the program of Pentecost with the sign gifts *cannot* be carried out today. God has rendered these signs invalid. These demonstrations of the Spirit have been done away. They have ceased. The attempts now to recover them are not of God, but of Satan, who would use even the Scriptures to rob God's people of the most precious blessings and possessions. Satan used the Word of God itself to tempt Christ. He used it again to cause the Galatians to fall from grace into the bondage of the Law. And he uses

it in our day, pointing to the Scriptures themselves to draw sincere believers away from a full appreciation of all spiritual blessings in heavenly places to the lesser blessings of earth that went with a former dispensation.

I tell you our adversary, the devil, is well pleased when untaught Christians say, "If it's in the Bible, that's enough for me." There are two verses that Satan will never show such people:

II Timothy 2:15, where we're told to "rightly divide the Word of Truth;" and Romans 11:13, where Paul says:

"For *I* speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as *I* am the apostle of the Gentiles, *I* magnify mine office."

If Satan didn't cause them to ignore these verses the confusion and division in the Church would soon be dispelled.

One other thing we should notice is that the attempted recovery of the sign gifts today is a distinct sign of *immaturity*. The Corinthians abounded with these signs. Read it in I Corinthians 1:7 and Chapters 12 to 14, where Paul has a great deal to say about that. They had all the sign gifts. The Corinthians boasted of them. And yet Paul let them know in no uncertain terms that they were "babes" spiritually (I Cor. 3:1); that they were unable to digest solid spiritual food (I Cor. 3:2); and that their "envying" and "strife" and "division" proved this (I Cor. 3:3). So in the light of this let no one suppose that the so-called modern gifts of Pentecost—healing and prophecy and tongues—are signs of spirituality and maturity.

The Corinthians, who had an exaggerated estimate of the value of the sign gifts, had them all, and

genuinely had them when they were at least in order. Yet they were pronounced *carnal* rather than spiritual, and *childish* rather than mature. Supernatural gifts in themselves were never an indication of spirituality. They were simply temporary signs associated with the Messiahship of Christ. What shall we say of those who make so much of them after God has suspended them and made them to cease. The surging waves of emotionalism; the confusion in their meetings; the constant emphasis on the miraculous; the self-deceit and deception of others; the failure to recognize Paul as the God-appointed apostle of this present dispensation—all this is not of God, it is of Satan.

THE GOSPEL BRINGS FORTH FRUIT IN ALL THE WORLD

"Which is come unto you, as it is in all the world; and bringeth forth fruit, as it doth also in you, since the day ye heard of it, and knew the grace of God in truth:

"As ye also learned of Epaphras our dear fellowservant, who is for you a faithful minister of Christ;

"Who also declared unto us your love in the Spirit" (Col. 1:6-8).

A DEAR FELLOW SERVANT

Epaphras was evidently the evangelist whom Paul had sent to Colosse to proclaim the gospel of the grace of God, and who had now returned to tell Paul the wonderful results. Actually Paul was not surprised that a church had already been established there with a group of believers rejoicing in Christ, for the gospel produces "fruit" wherever it goes.

All this brings up a very interesting and a very hotly debated point. Did Paul's gospel of the grace of God actually get to "all the world," as he says here?

THE PROFESSING CHURCH

To the Apostle Paul was committed the greatest revelation of all time. It is called "the Mystery," or "secret," and it was made known by "the revelation of Jesus Christ." It is God's great "eternal purpose," and to Paul was entrusted, in connection with this *sacred secret*, "the dispensation of the grace of God." His ministry superceded that of Peter and the eleven. Solemn recognition was given to this very fact by the leaders of the Twelve, including Peter himself, as they gave to Paul and Barnabas "the right hands of fellowship," acknowledging Paul's divine commission to go to the Gentiles. They agreed that since the favored nation had not yet received their message, they would confine their ministry to their own nation (See Galatians 2:2-9).

Now in connection with this commission, Paul was also the divinely appointed "minister" of the Church of this present dispensation, called in Colossians 1:18,24, *the Body of Christ*. No other Bible writer has a single word to say about the Church which is Christ's Body. None of the other apostles mention it. Not only would we seek in vain for such phraseology in their writings, but we'd seek in vain for any discussion of the subject, for they do not discuss the Church of which believers today are members. But Paul, who wrote more books of the Bible than any other writer, deals consistently with those truths which concern the Church which is His Body. It is sad to say that this great revelation and the glorious truths associated with it have been largely lost to the professing Church.

The largest segment of this Church ignores these facts, though they are clearly set forth in her own Bible. She insists that the true Church of today is

the perpetuation of that which was founded by Christ while He was on earth. And consistent with this she holds that she is laboring to fulfill the so-called Great Commission given to Peter and the eleven, requiring water baptism for the remission of sins, and claiming to possess miraculous powers.

The Protestant Church, while boasting freedom from clerical or religious tyranny, has by no means emerged entirely from the shadows of the dark ages. She also still clings to the traditional teaching that the Church today is the perpetuation of that to which our Lord referred in Matthew 16 when He said, "Upon this Rock I will build My Church" (Matt. 16:18).

The Protestant Church in general believes that the Church is God's kingdom on earth. She, too, seeks to carry out the so-called Great Commission, the commission given to Peter and the eleven—though half-heartedly, for she can't make up her mind whether water baptism is, or is not, necessary for the remission of sins, and she's also confused and disagreed as to whether or not she possesses the miraculous powers of the so-called Great Commission.

EVERY CREATURE UNDER HEAVEN

Rather than recognizing the distinctive character of Paul's position as *our* apostle, most Protestants think of him as simply *one* of the apostles, along with Peter and the eleven. In this the Protestant Church has assumed a very weak position. For if Paul is to be considered one of the twelve, it can easily be proven that Peter, and not Paul, was appointed their chief. Just read Matthew 16:19, and several other passages, especially in the book of Acts. Since Christendom has strayed so far and so long from the great Pauline

revelation, she has lost sight almost completely of the vastness of his ministry, and his influence, and the extent to which she once became known in the world.

An example of this is found in what Bible scholars in general have done with Titus 2:11. It is correctly agreed that "epiphany," the original word for "appeared" in this verse, means a conspicuous or an illustrious "shining forth." And that the phrase "all men" doesn't mean each individual, singly, but all men collectively, all mankind. But few can believe that even under Paul's ministry the gospel of the grace of God shone forth to all mankind, or that it's proclamation ever became worldwide. They conclude that Paul couldn't have meant that. And so they change this verse to read, that the grace of God bringing salvation for all has appeared, when that is not actually what it says. It says what the Authorized Version renders it to say:

***"For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men"* (Titus 2:11).**

Now apart from Paul's statement in Titus 2:11, there is a great deal of Scriptural evidence that this message did shine forth to all the known world.

ALL NATIONS, ALL THE WORLD, AND ALL CREATION

Before we go into that evidence, there are three phrases used in the so-called Great Commission given to the eleven, later made twelve, that indicate a *worldwide* scope in ministry.

Matthew 28:19: "Go ye therefore, and teach [make disciples of] *all nations*...."

Mark 16:15: "Go ye into *all the world*, and preach the gospel to every creature [Greek, *all creation*]."

Three important phrases: *all nations, all the world, all creation*. Remember them, because we're going to come back to them.

The Twelve apostles were sent to all nations with their gospel of the kingdom. The blessing was to go to "all the world" through Israel with Christ as King, and when this was completed, here is what Matthew 24:14 says would happen:

"And this gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in *all the world* for a witness unto *all nations*; and then shall *the end* come."

Now we know that the "end" of that administration has not even yet come. That dispensation was interrupted by God because the favored nation rejected the King and His kingdom. Therefore, God concluded all mankind now in unbelief, to raise up another apostle, Paul, sending him forth with "the gospel of the grace of God" (Acts 20:24).

"MADE KNOWN TO ALL NATIONS"

Surely no one even superficially acquainted with the Book of Acts, or the epistles of Paul, would question the fact that some time *after* our Lord's commission to Peter and the eleven, Paul was sent forth as an apostle of Christ to proclaim the gospel to all mankind.

It is very significant that the three terms—*all nations, all the world, all creation*—employed in the commission to Peter and the eleven, indicating its worldwide scope; these same terms are also used in Paul's epistles in connection with his ministry. Only,

whereas the twelve *never* got to all nations, all the world, and all creation with their message, Paul *did* with his. In closing his epistle to the Romans, he says:

"Now to Him that is of power to stablish you according to my gospel, and the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the Mystery, which was kept secret since the world began,

"But now is made manifest, and by [the prophetic Scriptures], according to the commandment of the everlasting God, *MADE KNOWN TO ALL NATIONS* for the obedience of faith" (Rom. 16:25,26).

There you have it. It is now *made manifest* and *made known* to *all nations*. In Colossians 1:6 Paul speaks as we have seen to these Colossians about "the truth of the gospel":

Verse 6: "Which is come unto you, as it is in *ALL THE WORLD*; and bringeth forth fruit."

Verse 23: "Which ye have heard, and which was preached to *every creature* [*ALL CREATION*] which is under heaven; whereof I Paul am made a minister."

There you have those three phrases again: all nations, all the world, all creation. Arguments may be advanced to prove that the gospel of the grace of God didn't actually reach all the world or all creation. We do not deny that to those addressed "all the world" would doubtless mean all the *known* world and "all creation" would likewise mean, all creation *as they knew it*. But the point is—now get this carefully—that whatever these terms mean in the so-called Great Commission to Peter and the eleven, they must also mean in these statements by Paul, for the terms are exactly identical in the original. And as we have seen, Peter and the Twelve *did not* get their message to all the world, all nations, and all creation, *but Paul did*.

THE AMAZING ENERGY OF THE APOSTLE PAUL

There is so very much to be said about the *amazing* energy with which Paul proclaimed the gospel of the grace of God. In Romans 1:5 he speaks of his God-given authority:

"By whom we have received grace and apostleship, for obedience to the faith among *all nations*, for His name."

In Ephesians 3:9, notice that his great desire extended to all men:

"And to make all men see what is the fellowship* [*dispensation*] *of the Mystery, which from the beginning of the world hath been hid in God, who created all things by Jesus Christ."

We could go into so many passages in Acts where Paul goes from one riot to another, from one uproar to another, from one situation where his very life was in danger to another.

At Lystra, for example, where he had been "stoned" and left for "dead"; perhaps he was dead and raised, it is impossible to tell from the actual wording there. In any case, they left him for dead, and it's only a little while later that he goes back, "confirming the souls of the disciples, exhorting them to continue in the faith" (Acts 14:22).

And you'll remember when the legalizers came down to Antioch in Syria and wanted to bring the Gentile believers under the law of Moses.

"When therefore Paul and Barnabas had *no small dissension* and *disputation* with them…" (Acts 15:2).

And when they went up to Jerusalem to settle this matter, and he took Titus with him as a test case

(Gal. 2:3), and concerning those who would have had it so, he says:

"To whom we gave place by subjection, no, not for an hour, that the truth of the gospel might continue with you" (Gal. 2:5).

At Philippi, he was beaten with "many stripes" and imprisoned (Acts 16:23). At Thessalonica, those who didn't believe "set all the city on an uproar," and things became so dangerous that "the brethren immediately sent away Paul and Silas by night unto Berea" (Acts 17:5-10). However, unbelievers from Thessalonica followed him there, and they "stirred up the people," and again "the brethren sent away Paul to go as it were to the sea" (Verses 13,14).

Then at Athens, he got the cold shoulder and "departed" from them to Corinth where he was able to remain "a year and six months," but not without tasting a great deal of opposition and persecution (Acts 18:1-11).

***"And I was with you in weakness, and in fear, and in much trembling"* (I Cor. 2:3).**

At Ephesus, he went to the synagogue "and spake boldly for the space of three months," but opposition and persecution did not prevent him from "*disputing* daily in the school of one Tyrannus":

"AND THIS CONTINUED BY *THE SPACE OF TWO YEARS*; SO THAT ALL THEY THAT DWELT IN ASIA [Asia Minor] HEARD THE WORD OF THE LORD JESUS, BOTH JEWS AND GREEKS" (Acts 19:8-10).

Indeed, before Paul left Ephesus so much had been accomplished that a public bonfire was held in which those who had been won to Christ burned their heathen books, "...and they counted the price of them, *and*

found it fifty thousand pieces of silver. So *mightily* grew the Word of God and prevailed" (Acts 19:19,20).

In writing to the Corinthians the Apostle says, "For we would not, brethren, have you ignorant of our trouble which came to us in Asia, that we were pressed out of measure, above strength, insomuch that we despaired even of life" (II Cor. 1:8).

At Troas, Paul preached "until midnight." Then an accident happened, and he took part in making it right. Then it says they "talked a long while, even till [the] break of day" (Acts 20:6-12). You would think he'd want to get some rest, but it says he departed to continue his journey unto Jerusalem. Ah, the energy with which Paul preached the gospel is amazing!

THE MIGHTY WORKING OF GOD'S GRACE

In Acts 20:17-38 Paul issued a warning to the Ephesian elders, concerning evil men and seducers, that should be taken very seriously by our brethren in Christ today:

"Therefore watch, and remember, that *by the space of three years* I ceased not to *warn* every one *night and day* with tears" (Acts 20:31).

At Rome, even while he is in bonds (Acts 28:16-24) he starts a church in this Roman prison.

"But I would ye should understand, brethren, that the things which have happened unto me have fallen out rather unto the furtherance the gospel;
***"So that my bonds in Christ are manifest in all the palace, and in all other places"* (Phil. 1:12,13).**

And thus his greetings in Philippians 4:21,22,23 confirm the fact that God was mightily working, not only at Philippi, but throughout the known world:

"Salute every saint in Christ Jesus. The brethren which are with me greet you.

"All the saints salute you, chiefly they that are of Caesar's household.

"The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. Amen."

Think of it. A church had begun, if you please, a group of believers right in Caesar's court. This, of course, was only because Paul was divinely empowered. He says in I Corinthians 4:11, "Even unto this present hour we both hunger, and thirst, and are naked, and are buffeted, and have no certain dwellingplace." How could one man endure all this? The answer can only be, divine empowerment.

"For I will not dare to speak of any of those things *which Christ hath not wrought by me*, to make the Gentiles obedient, by word and deed" (Rom. 15:18).

"But by the grace of God I am what I am: and His grace which was bestowed upon me was not in vain; but I laboured more abundantly than they all: *yet not I, but the grace of God which was with me*" (I Cor. 15:10).

And in Colossians 1:29 he speaks of God's working in him,

"Whereunto I also labour, striving according to *His* working, which worketh in me *mightily*."

THE LIGHT OF THE GOSPEL DARKENED

Sad to say, the light of the gospel has been dimmed. The dark ages came, the Church backslid—the Galatians were "so soon removed from Him that called you into the grace of Christ unto another gospel" (Gal. 1:6).

The Apostle had to write about those in Asia who had come to rejoice in Christ:

"This thou knowest, that all they which are in Asia be turned away from me; of whom are Phygellus and Hermogenes" (II Tim. 1:15).

From the writings of the early first century fathers which still exist, it is evident that rather than recognizing the distinctive character of Paul's message and apostleship, they already had it all confused with the kingdom message proclaimed by John the Baptist, Christ, and the Twelve. This declension went on apace until the dark ages, when mere *political* clericalism held sway for a thousand years. They had departed from Paul's gospel!

THE GLORIOUS LIGHT OF THE GOSPEL REKINDLED

Thank God the light has broken forth again, and God would have us to re-light this torch. Beloved, in these critical times, *we* should make it our *one passion* to know God's Word "rightly divided," and to make it known to others, until the wonderful grace of God shines forth again as a blazing torch that poor sinners, *wandering* and *lost*, can see, believe and cling to. Shall we not, must we not, put aside every other consideration, and say with Paul,

***"But as we were allowed of God to be put in trust with the gospel, even so we speak; not as pleasing men, but God, which trieth our hearts"* (I Thes. 2:4).**

Soon enough our Lord will appear in glory and our work will be done, beloved. Now He would have us, by his grace, shine to the world as lights proclaiming this wonderful message. Whatever the opposition of Satan then, and however deceitful his character, let us say with the Apostle Paul:

"But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might *finish* my course with joy, and the ministry, which I received of the Lord Jesus, to *testify* the gospel of the grace of God" (Acts 20:24).

If we do this, we will also be able to say with him when we come to the end of the way:

"I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith. Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous Judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love His appearing" (II Tim. 4:7,8).

Chapter 2 — Colossians 1:9-14

THE KNOWLEDGE OF HIS WILL

"For this cause we also, since the day we heard it, do not cease to pray for you, and to desire that ye might be filled with the knowledge of His will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding" (Col. 1:9).

GOD'S WILL FOR TODAY

Now beloved, we must have this clearly in mind as we study this passage in the first chapter of the Colossian letter. Every true spiritual believer will heartily desire to know, and do, the will of God. It is my earnest prayer that you may indeed "be filled with the knowledge of His will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding." Sad to say, however, the vast majority of believers, reading this passage in Colossians, think only in terms of God's will for *their* lives in *their* particular circumstances.

For example, a young Christian asks: "What is God's will for my life? Should I go into the ministry or become a missionary? And if a missionary, should I go to China, Africa or India? Or would God have me stay in business and help to finance His work?" But while the young man is so concerned about God's will for the details of *his life*, he is woefully ignorant of *God's will*, i.e., *what it is God wants done.* The emphasis is put upon *himself*, rather than upon God and His great plan for the present dispensation.

So, I beg of you my dear friend, don't misunderstand this passage, when Paul prays for the Colossians, and

he certainly would pray for us, "that [we] might be filled with the *knowledge* of His will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding."

Colossians 1:9 does not refer to God's will then in *a given situation*, but to His long hidden purpose and program as revealed in the Pauline Epistles. He rightly holds us responsible to learn what this is:

"Having made known unto us THE MYSTERY OF HIS WILL, *according to His good pleasure* which *He hath purposed in Himself*" (Eph. 1:9).

"See then that ye walk circumspectly, not as fools, but as wise,

"Redeeming [buying up] the time, because the days are evil.

"Wherefore be ye not unwise, *but understanding what the will of the Lord is*" (Eph. 5:15-17).

Sadly, the majority of God's people seem to think that His will should accommodate itself to their fluctuating experiences. When they are in the depths of despair and do not know where to turn, they cry to the Lord to show them His will. When on the mountaintop, maybe called upon to choose between two attractive alternatives, they ask the Lord again to show them His will. And if you draw a line to illustrate it, part of it would be way down and then the graph would go way up, of course. But all the while they neglect to inquire about *His* objective, or to learn how *they* may fit into *His* plan and purpose. This purpose is clearly defined for us in the Epistles of Paul. It runs straight as an arrow and *we* should conform ourselves to *it*.

Now God is interested—I don't want you to misunderstand me—He is very interested in whatever concerns us. And He would have us look to Him for guidance in every detail of our lives. But let us put

the *emphasis* where it belongs. If a man is ignorant of the will and purpose of God, what good is it to inquire whether he should enter the ministry or go to Africa or China? He will do as much harm as good wherever he goes. On the other hand, one who does have an intelligent understanding of the will of God and has been gripped by it will have little danger of remaining unused in the Lord's service.

If we would be in the center of God's will, then, we must come to a knowledge and an appreciation of the great *secret* revealed through Paul for us today. This alone can give us a true sense of our place in God's program, broadening and balancing our spiritual experience.

Let us then labor fervently in prayer, as Epaphras did for the saints at Colosse, that we might *"stand perfect and complete in all the will of God"* (Col. 4:12).

Now in seeking to determine God's will in the particular circumstances of life, the truly spiritual believer will take little heed to the very things that others think are so decisive. He will never depend on "getting the mind of God through prayer"; hoping for "inner promptings"—as one writer put it, "Not a voice, but an impression." Nor will he go to the "promise" box and flip his Bible open at random to learn God's will. If for no other reason, simply because he does limit God to the promises, the particular promises in the box.

No, *no*, such an one will look for guidance in answer to prayer, to be sure, but he'll do this by prayerfully using his God-given faculties in the light of the written Word, "*rightly divided*."

Beloved, God has given us *hands* to work with, *hearts* to love with, and *minds* to think with, and He

expects us to use them all to His glory. Hence, in any given situation we should use the common sense that He has given us in the light of His Word.

Naturally, this affects our wills, too, and our prayer lives, but here again a knowledge of the Mystery broadens us and establishes us, as we lose our wills in His.

We no longer confuse "this present evil age" with the kingdom which our Lord proclaimed and in connection with which He said: *"And all things, whatsoever ye shall ask in prayer, believing, ye shall receive"* (Matt. 21:22). Under the present circumstances it is a good thing that we do not receive "whatsoever" we ask, even in faith, for we read in Romans 8:26 that *"we know not what we should pray for as we ought."* The same passage, however, goes on to tell us what we *do* know:

"And we know that all things work [Lit. "are being worked"] together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to His purpose" (Rom. 8:28).

When we exercise the deepest, most implicit faith in God, we will not insist that He grant our desires, but will place ourselves unreservedly in His care and keeping, fully assured that he will work all out for our good. Thus the apostle exhorts us:

"Be careful [anxious] for nothing: but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known unto God" (Phil. 4:6).

"And...." And *what? "And you will receive what you ask for?"* No! Be anxious for *nothing*, but in *everything*, whatever the circumstances, with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God,

"AND THE PEACE OF GOD, WHICH PASSETH ALL UNDERSTANDING, SHALL KEEP YOUR HEARTS AND MINDS THROUGH CHRIST JESUS" (Phil. 4:7).

It may be necessary for your own good that He withhold what you have asked for, but sustained by a sense of His love and grace you will not crack or go to pieces, for having talked to Him about it and left it with him, His peace—the peace that passes human understanding—will keep, or garrison, your *heart* and *mind* through Christ Jesus.

There is something more blessed, then, than merely getting what we ask for in prayer. It is spoken of again by the Apostle Paul, in Ephesians 3:20,21.

"Now unto Him that is able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that worketh in us,

"Unto Him be glory in the Church by Christ Jesus throughout all ages, world without end. Amen."

GOD'S WILL FOR YOU

Now this holds good even with regard to calls to special service for Christ; whether to the pastorate, the mission field, or any other branch of the work. The truly spiritual child of God will not look for, or depend upon, some overwhelming emotional experience as an indication that God has called him to the ministry.

Much less will he expect what so many have called *a Macedonian vision*, for he will have learned that Paul's call to Macedonia in Acts 16:9,10 is the last such call recorded in Scripture and that it belongs with the signs of a past dispensation.

First, *all* believers are called to make known what Paul calls "*the preaching of Jesus Christ, according to the revelation of the Mystery*" (Rom. 16:25). The written Word of God, together with the appalling need all about us, constitutes an urgent call to this ministry.

Now, all are not meant to minister in the same capacity. Some may accomplish much more for Christ in business than they could as pastors or missionaries. So here the particular qualifications of the individual and the particular ministry to which he is best suited are involved.

There is no room for superstition in such matters, beloved. These things are too important. It is rather for each individual to ask God for light from the Word and for wisdom to consider the need, the circumstances, and his own talents objectively, praying for an open door to that field of service where he can accomplish most for his Lord.

The infinite importance of understanding God's will can be better appreciated if we consider that we are now living in the tense moments between man's declaration of war on God, and God's counter-declaration of war on man, so that there is no time to lose in winning men to Christ. True, man made his declaration of war long ago, but still these moments are just added one after another. God has given us no promise that He won't close the day of grace at any time.

So the apostle "begs" the unsaved: "receive not the grace of God in vain." He says, "Behold, *now* is the accepted time, behold, *now* is the day of salvation" (II Cor. 6:1,2).

In the light of this, how we should pray for ourselves and for our fellow believers, "*That [we] may stand perfect and complete in all the will of God*" (Col. 4:12).

I hope this has helped you to understand what the apostle means when he says,

"[I] do not cease to pray for you, and to desire that ye might be filled with the knowledge of [God's] will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding" **(Col. 1:9).**

WALKING WORTHY OF THE LORD

"That ye might walk worthy of the Lord unto all pleasing, being fruitful in every good work, and increasing in the knowledge of God;

"Strengthened with all might, according to His glorious power, unto all patience and longsuffering with joyfulness;

"Giving thanks unto the Father, which hath made us meet to be partakers of the inheritance of the saints in light:

"Who hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of His dear Son:

"In whom we have redemption through His blood, even the forgiveness of sins" (Col. 1:10-14).

OUR CALLING IS A HEAVENLY CALLING

We dealt with the apostle's impassioned prayer that believers might be filled with the knowledge of God's will. We saw that he was referring not to God's will for particular individuals in particular circumstances, but to God's plan, His purpose, His program for this present dispensation. How important that we know His will, that we know what *He* is doing.

Perhaps you've heard the story of the sailor who was trying his best to get a case through a hatchway on a ship. He lifted and he struggled and he pushed and pulled but all in vain until one of his mates jumped to his aid. Together they lifted and strained and pushed and pulled and again in vain. Finally, the second man said, "You'll never get this in." And the first man said, "In! I wanted it out!"

Well, just think of that illustration and ask yourself how we can serve God acceptably if we do not

have an intelligent understanding of what it is He wants done. That's why it is so all-important that every believer should study and practice II Timothy 2:15:

"Study to show thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the Word of Truth."

Paul now turns from knowing God's will to *walking worthy* of the will of God. He tells us why we should have a clear understanding of God's purpose and program:

***"That ye might walk worthy of the Lord unto all pleasing, being fruitful in every good work, and increasing in the knowledge of God"* (Col. 1:10).**

Now you'll notice this is again associated with God's purpose, His plan, for today. In Ephesians 4:1 the apostle bids us to "walk worthy of the vocation [really, the calling] wherewith ye are called" and prays that God will increase your understanding of Himself:

"That the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give unto you the spirit of wisdom and revelation in the knowledge of Him;

"The eyes of your understanding being enlightened; that ye may know what is the hope of His calling, and what the riches of the glory of His inheritance [is] in the saints,

***"And what is the exceeding greatness of His power to us-ward who believe, according to the working of His mighty power"* (Eph. 1:17-19).**

What does the Apostle mean by this? Well, he makes it clear elsewhere. Our calling is a heavenly calling. This was not so with the nation Israel. Israel was God's earthly people and will again be. Israel was promised a land "on earth" and promised that she would dwell in peace in that land, and she someday

will, along with the twelve apostles. They were, of course, associated with the "twelve tribes" of Israel and they were promised "twelve thrones" in the kingdom to come when Israel dwells in the land of Palestine (Matt. 19:28). But this is not so today. God has interrupted His Prophetic Program, and has brought in another which He calls *"the Mystery,"* never prophesied, because it was *"kept secret,"* until God made it known by revelation from the glorified Lord Himself to the Apostle Paul.

We have a heavenly calling, a heavenly position, and heavenly blessings because, he says, we are blessed "with all spiritual blessings *in the heavenlies* in Christ." We are promised nothing on earth, nothing of the earth, we are not a kingdom on earth. We belong to "the Body of Christ" with a position in heaven. This is why he says in Galatians 1:4 that "[Christ] gave Himself for our sins that He might deliver us *from* this present evil [age]." And he would have us by faith accept God's Word as to our calling, rise above the troubles and sorrows of this world, occupy our position "in the heavenlies" and appropriate our blessings there.

So here, in Colossians, the Apostle says that we should "be filled with the knowledge of [God's] will in all wisdom and spiritual understanding":

"That ye might walk worthy of the Lord unto all pleasing, being fruitful in every good work, and increasing in the knowledge of God" (Col. 1:10).

Now it would be impossible to be fruitful in every work that we do for God if we do not have an intelligent understanding of *what it is* He is doing.

We must see that God raised up Paul to bring in a new message and a new program. The kingdom was

rejected. It is not now being set up on earth. Someone has well said that if the Church on earth is the kingdom of Christ or the kingdom of God or the kingdom of heaven, then certainly it will not stand, it will be overthrown, because the Lord Himself said that a "kingdom divided against itself...shall not stand" (Matt. 12:25). And do you know of anything that's more *divided* today than the professing Church?

So we must have the knowledge of God's program, and we must see that He's *not* establishing the kingdom on earth today. He's forming the Body of Christ, made up of believers in and out of all denominations whom He has "baptized into one Body" (I Cor. 12:13). Blessed fellowship! Wonderful unity! Wonderful truth to know, that believers all over the world are "one" *in Christ* and that I am one with them in Christ because we are *one* with Him. So don't you see, we must "be filled with the knowledge of His will" to "be fruitful in every good work" (Col. 1:9,10)? We must be filled with the knowledge of His will so that we're not like that second sailor who was going to help the first one but didn't know what he was doing, and was working at cross purposes with him.

And as you are more and more filled with the knowledge of His will you'll get to know Him better. But here you've come out to an ocean of fulness. For who can *fully* know God, or *fully* know the Lord Jesus Christ? Ah, but as you come to know His program and His plan for this present evil age, it will make you know Him the better. And you'll see what a great God of love and mercy He is. How slow to anger. How He delights in mercy. You will be *increasing* in the knowledge of God.

II Peter, the third chapter, has something to say about this. The Apostle Peter speaks of the *longsuffering* of

God in having delayed the judgment that was due shortly after the ascension of Christ at Pentecost. Then it was that God was ready, prophetically speaking, to pour out the bowls of His wrath, the bowls of His judgment. But He didn't do it. And Peter says about His promise to send Christ to set up His kingdom here:

***"The Lord is not slack concerning His promise, as some men count slackness; but is long-suffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance"* (II Pet. 3:9).**

His argument is very clear that to set up His kingdom here, Christ would have to come back in judgment and put down the rebellion here against Himself. Well, he says, don't count it slackness, but count it longsuffering:

"And account that the longsuffering of our Lord is salvation; even as our beloved brother Paul also according to the wisdom given unto him hath written unto you;

***"As also in all his epistles, speaking in them of these things..."* (II Pet. 3:15,16).**

What things? Ah, the reason for the delay in Christ's return to judge and reign is not *slackness* or *laxity* on His part to fulfill His promise. Not at all. The reason for His delay is *longsuffering* and *mercy* and *love* to a doomed race. And that's why Peter, having acknowledged Paul as the one who gave him this further light and made this further truth known; Peter, as well as Paul, begs us in his very last words:

"But grow in grace, and in the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ."

As you get to know more about His great purpose of grace in Christ the better you get to know Him.

"That ye might walk worthy of the Lord unto all pleasing, being fruitful in every good work, and increasing in the knowledge of God.

***"Strengthened with all might, according to His glorious power, unto all patience and longsuffering with joyfulness"* (Col. 1:10,11).**

This is a beautiful verse. There are three words for power or strength here. He says as we get to know Him better, we'll be "strengthened" with all "might"—with His might—according to His glorious "power."

Why do we need to be "strengthened with all might according to His glorious power"? Well, he goes on: "Unto all *patience* and *longsuffering* with joyfulness." We must partake of His nature and His attitude. As we just saw from II Peter, God has been patient and longsuffering. It is not laxity that makes Him wait and wait and wait and wait before He finally sends Christ back to judge this wicked world for its rebellion and its godlessness and Christlessness. Ah no, it is not laxness on His part, it is "*patience*" and "*longsuffering.*" He is not willing that men should perish. He is slow to anger, plenteous in mercy, and so He wants us, too, to be "*strengthened with all might, according to His glorious power,*" that we might also exercise "patience and longsuffering" in this world of sin. And He goes on, "with joyfulness"—Oh how beautiful!

Why is it that God can be so patient? Saint Augustine said, "God is patient because God is Almighty." You see, God is omnipotent. He is Almighty, and that is why He can be patient. The onslaught of the enemy does not bother Him; He has no question as to the outcome. He is only sorry for those who engage in it. To illustrate:

Here, let's say, is a father with his little babe in his lap. And the baby pulls his nose and slaps his

arm and slaps his chest and the father smiles indulgently at the babe. It doesn't hurt him. He's so big and that baby is so small.

Well, so with us, He would have us only in greater degree, "strengthened with all might according to His glorious power," that we might exercise "all *patience* and *longsuffering* with *joyfulness*." That is beautiful indeed.

We have the same general idea in Ephesians 3 where Paul has so much to say about our coming to know God, coming to know Christ better, in speaking of his own tribulations:

"Wherefore I desire that ye faint not at my tribulations for you, which is your glory.
"For this cause I bow my knees unto the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ,
"Of whom the whole family in heaven and earth is named,
"That He would grant you, according to the riches of His glory, to be strengthened with might by His Spirit in the inner man" **(Eph. 3:13-16).**

Then in Verse 20:

"Now unto Him that is able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that worketh in us."

And in Colossians 1:12, the next reason why He wants us to "be filled with the knowledge of His will" that we may be always:

"Giving thanks unto the Father, which hath made us meet [fit] to be partakers of the inheritance of the saints in light."

As Ephesians 1:6 says, "He hath made us accepted in the Beloved [One]." Meet, or fit, for God's presence. How wonderful!

***"Who hath delivered us from the power of darkness, and hath translated us into the kingdom of His dear Son"* (Col. 1:13).**

Oh, what power darkness has! We see it again and again. Remember the history of the Egyptians and how on that terrible night of stygian darkness no one dared rise from his seat, the darkness bound them there. Darkness does have a binding effect. We read in Ephesians 6:12 that Satan and his hosts are "*the rulers of the darkness of this world [age].*" As we try to witness for Christ we see minds so often bound with chains of darkness, and somehow they are not released. Ah, but God can release them from it. If you want to be saved, God can deliver you from the power of darkness, and translate you into the kingdom of His dear Son.

And this shows that the Kingdom of Heaven is *not* being established on earth today. It's vested in Christ in heaven during this time of His exile.

***"In Whom we have redemption through His blood, even the forgiveness of sins"* (Col. 1:14).**

Oh my dear friend, God wants you to know the joy of sins forgiven, *redemption* through the blood[1] of Christ, and the *inheritance* of the saints *in light*. Do you know it? He died for your sins as well as mine. Why don't you trust Him as I did, and as millions have, and experience that joy and peace of sins forgiven?

***"Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved"* (Acts 16:31).**

Chapter 3 — Colossians 1:15-19

THE IMAGE OF THE INVISIBLE GOD

"Who is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of every creature.

"For by Him were all things created, that are in heaven, and that are in earth, visible and invisible, whether they be thrones, or dominions, or principalities, or powers: all things were created by Him, and for Him.

"And He is before all things, and by Him all things consist.

"And He is the Head of the Body, the Church: who is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead; that in all things He might have the preeminence.

"For it pleased the Father that in Him should all fulness dwell" (Col. 1:15-19).

THE DEITY OF CHRIST

Colossians was written to refute and rebuke the Gnostics, the know-it-alls of Paul's day, who were beginning to convince some of the Colossians as to their *theories*. The Greek word "gnosis," of course, simply means *knowledge*, so the Gnostics actually called themselves "those who know."

How modest!

It wasn't strange that they denied the Deity of Christ and said He was merely like other people, a created being. It is only a short step, beloved, from exalting self, to dishonoring Christ.

Hardly a generation ago we had a striking example of this as the theory of evolution gained ground. It

was not at all unusual to read in the writings of our *modern* know-it-alls phrases like:

"Modern scholarship is agreed"...."All intelligent people know"...."No intelligent person would believe"—and so on.

And so they went from evolution to a denial of the supernatural—including the Deity of Christ. They talked as though their theories were a foregone conclusion. "All intelligent people," of course, agreed with them.

But there were some very intelligent people, some very great men, who *did not agree* with them, who *denied* the theory of evolution and believed *wholeheartedly* in the *Deity* of Christ.

There was Dr. Howard Kelly, the great surgeon. There was Sir Robert Anderson, Scotland Yard's great detective. And there were other great lawyers and great scientists and great educators, too. So let us not listen too readily, beloved, to those who say, "We all know," or, "Everybody agrees," with their theories.

Paul answers the Gnostics by showing Christ's relationship first to God, second, to creation, and third, to the Church which is His Body. And remember Paul could give firsthand testimony about this. He had once considered Messiah an imposter, but had since *seen* Him, as he says, exalted "*far above all.*" He had heard "the voice of His mouth" (Acts 22:14) speaking in the tenderest tones, "Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou Me?" (Acts 22:7). The sight had blinded him and the experience was never erased from his mind. We have three considerable accounts of his conversion in the Book of Acts alone, and again and again in his epistles, he speaks of it and refers to it.

CHRIST'S RELATION TO THE FATHER

"Who is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of every creature" (Col. 1:15).

In this fifteenth verse Paul speaks of Christ as "the image of the invisible God." Christ IS *the image of God*. What does that mean? Does that mean He is actually the embodiment of God? or a derived likeness? What does the word *image*, the English word image, mean here? What does the original word from which it is taken mean? The answer is not hard to find, because we have the same word used in Hebrews 10:1, where we read:

"For the law having a shadow of good things to come, and not the very image of the things, can never with those sacrifices which they offered year by year continually make the comers thereunto perfect."

Here is a distinction drawn between shadow and substance. The law had a *shadow* of good things to come but *not* the very image. Very clearly, the "image" here is the thing itself and the distinction is drawn between *shadow* and *substance*. This is what it must mean here in Colossians also. Not only because the same word is used, but also because we read that He is "*the image of the invisible God*."

Now if God is invisible, as such He surely could not have any physical likeness. There can be no likeness of something that cannot be seen. So then, the word evidently is, and the parallelism brings it out, that *He is the image, or the substance, of the invisible God*. The conclusion is that Christ is God in bodily form (Col. 2:9).

The only *true* representation of God is *Christ* (John 1:18; Col. 1:15; 2:9; Heb. 1:3), and when unregenerate

man makes images to represent *his* conception of God, he invariably belittles and degrades Him. And the surest way to self-degradation is to degrade the object of one's worship.

Does the reader object that all this has little relevance today? We reply that it has profound relevance. Nearly half of the world's population today is steeped in pagan idol worship and bound by superstition and fear. Add to these the millions who bow down to images in the name of Christianity—who are also bound by superstition and fear—and the number is greatly increased. Moreover, paganism is growing here in America at an alarming rate, with so-called "Christians" giving Buddhism, Hinduism, and a dozen other pagan religions favorable consideration.

Make no mistake about it: Idolatry is the devil's masterpiece. The so-called "Christian" cults are nothing compared to pagan idolatry, demon worship, much of which is morally vile and all of which is spiritually degrading.

In Colossians 2:9 we read, "For in Him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily," and in Hebrews 1:3, these words are written about Christ:

"Who being the brightness of [God's] glory, and the express image [substance] of His person, and upholding all things by the Word of His power, when He had by Himself purged our sins, sat down on the right hand of the Majesty on high."

The Lord Jesus Christ is called *"the Word"* in John 1:1, or the *"logos,"* because He is the *"expression"* of the Father:

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1).

"And the Word [became] flesh and dwelt among us, (and we beheld His glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth" (John 1:14).

In fact, God is invisible *except* in Christ. This is why John 1:18 says, "*No man hath seen God at any time*; the only begotten Son, which is in the bosom of the Father, He hath declared Him." God is invisible except in the Son, for the Son, "the only begotten of the Father" it says in the original, "hath led Him forth." The idea is, "shown Him." "God is a Spirit," John says, "and they that worship Him must worship Him in Spirit and in truth" (John 4:24). So the conclusion is that Christ *IS* God, He is the *embodiment* of the Godhead.

CHRIST'S RELATION TO CREATION

"Who is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of every creature:

"For by Him were all things created, that are in heaven, and that are in earth, visible and invisible, whether they be thrones, or dominions, or principalities, or powers: all things were created by Him, and for Him" (Col. 1:15,16).

"THE FIRSTBORN"

Next the apostle shows Christ as "the firstborn of all creation" in this same 15th verse. "[He] is the image of the invisible God, the *firstborn* of [all creation]...."

Now I must pause here to explain that the term "firstborn" in the Bible does not necessarily indicate that one was born first. It is rather a *title*, which was usually bestowed on the one born first, but not always. It was generally the son born first that took the father's place at his death, got all his wealth, and also took upon him all the father's responsibility. But the firstborn was not necessarily the one born first.

Of Ishmael and Isaac, you remember, Ishmael was *born first*, but Isaac was the *firstborn*. The same is true with Esau and Jacob. Esau was born first but he wasn't the firstborn. The same is true with Reuben and Joseph. Reuben was born first, but he was not the firstborn. And Manasseh was born first, of Manasseh and Ephraim. But Manasseh was *not* the firstborn, *Ephraim* was the firstborn, and so was Jacob, and Isaac, in their particular couples, and Joseph from among the twelve.[1]

THE FIRSTBORN OF ALL CREATION

Neither does the title, "firstborn of [all creation]," mean that He was a created being or the first one to be created—by no means. It means that Christ is the *Head* of all creation. For Paul goes on to say here:

"[He] is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of [all creation]: FOR *BY HIM* WERE ALL THINGS CREATED, that are in heaven, and that are in earth, visible and invisible, whether they be thrones, or dominions, or principalities, or powers: ALL THINGS WERE CREATED *BY HIM*, AND *FOR* HIM."

In John 1:3 we read that "All things were made by Him; and without Him was not anything made that was made." No one could create but God. Man cannot create. An angel cannot create. Angels and men are themselves created beings. Only God can create.

In Ephesians 3:9, we read that God "created all things *by* Jesus Christ," which implies in itself that Christ was eternally coexistent with the Father. Then in the Book of Revelation and the fourth chapter, we have this very beautiful passage. There those gathered around the throne are saying to Christ:

"Thou art worthy, O Lord, to receive glory and honour and power: for *Thou* hast created all things, and for *Thy* pleasure they are and were created" (Rev. 4:11).

That is exactly what Paul says here in the letter to the Colossians. "All things were created *by* Him," and all things were created "*for* Him" (Col. 1:16).

There is another indication, when it says Christ is the firstborn of all creation, that He is the *Head* of creation, for in Colossians 1:17, Paul says that Christ is the Head of eternity:

"And He is before all things, and by Him all things consist."

Granted the word "before" in the original Greek, may or may not have to do with time, except in this case it certainly does have to do with *time* because it says, "by Him all things consist," or are held together. That would mean that He had to be *before* them in time in order to hold them together. So the Lord Jesus Christ is the *Head* of all eternity.

AND BY HIM ALL THINGS CONSIST

"And He is before all things, and by Him all things consist" (Col. 1:17).

The word "consist" here, in the original, means to "hold together" or to "cling together."

I shall never forget the day that we first heard that the atom bomb had been exploded. They had learned to split even the atom. Would nothing hold together? Was everything apt to fall apart? And I thought of this verse, and I thought of my wonderful Savior as the Head of all creation, who is before all things, not only historically, but also as far as rank is concerned too, for we read, "*and by Him all things consist*." We have this added thought in Hebrews One:

"Who being the brightness of [God's] glory, and the [very substance] of His person, and UPHOLDING all things by the Word of His power" (Heb. 1:3).

How often in the Psalms we read of His creative power, "By *the word of the Lord* were the *heavens* made; and all the host of them by the *breath* of His mouth" (Psa. 33:6). Isn't that amazing. "For He *spake*, and it was done; He *commanded*, and it stood fast" (Psa. 33:9). He could spin worlds into space *by a word*.

As Nathan R. Wood has said, "Space is nothing less than the creative power of God all about us."[2] If it were not for our Lord Jesus Christ the universe would fall apart. Have you ever sat in a planetarium and watched how the worlds revolve around each other in endless succession, and their orbits are so different, and they all have to mesh? One cannot collide with the other, nor *does* one collide with the other. And so,

***"The heavens declare the glory of God; and the firmament sheweth His handiwork"* (Psa. 19:1).**

And to be more specific, the heavens declare the glory of *God the Son* and the firmament showeth *His* handiwork.

Have you ever thought as you sat there in the planetarium or as you just considered these worlds as they spin endlessly through space, what keeps it all running? Why doesn't it just stop? Why doesn't it just scatter and fall apart or whatever? What keeps it all running so smoothly like a beautiful machine? Ah, that did not just happen. No theory of evolution could really explain this.

This is God, and here in Colossians, and in Hebrews, and in the Gospel according to John, we read

that it is *God the Son*, our Lord Jesus Christ, who came into this world after He had shown how He could "*uphold*" the whole universe. He came to bear on His shoulders your sins and mine and to die on Calvary, in order that we might be "justified" and made "accepted" in Him.

So we have seen Christ's relation to the Father, and Christ's relation to creation, but what about His relation to the Church?

CHRIST'S RELATION TO THE CHURCH

"And He is the Head of the Body, the Church: who is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead; that in all things He might have the preeminence" (Col. 1:18).

Now let us consider just for a moment, this relationship to the Church which is His Body, for it is a most beautiful truth to contemplate.

In the letter to the Corinthians, and twice in the Epistle to the Ephesians, and here in Colossians, in connection with the Body of Christ, we read that Christ is "*the Head*." He is the One who controls the Body, the One who certainly should control the Body. If any member of the Body is not controlled by the Head, things are not as they should be. They are not normal. But He controls the Body, if for no other reason, that He overrules our many mistakes and failures. Now it says here that He is "the Head of the Body" or as Ephesians One puts it:

"And [God] hath put all things under His feet, and gave Him to be the Head over all things to the Church,
***"Which is His Body, the fulness of Him that filleth all in all"* (Eph. 1:22,23).**

The Body recognizes Him as the One who in all things must have the *preeminence*, so He is called,

again and again, "the Head of the Church which is His Body."

Now I do hope that all our readers will clearly understand what this Body is. It is *not* a denomination. It is not an organization with any earthly, ecclesiastical Head. Ah no, the true Church[3] is called *the Body of Christ*. In Ephesians 2:16 Paul says that it is God's purpose "to reconcile both [Jews and Gentiles] unto God *in one Body* by the Cross, having slain the enmity thereby." In I Corinthians 12:13, he says about believers:

"For by one Spirit are we all baptized into one Body, whether we be Jews or Gentiles, whether we be bond or free; and have been all made to drink into one Spirit."

So this has nothing whatever to do with church roles or acceptance into some earthly organization, not at all. The true Church is invisible. The true Church is made up of true believers all over the world, in and out of every denomination, and God recognizes *only* that Church. He does not recognize the 400 some denominations in the United States, most of them mutually exclusive. He wishes as we wish that those walls would topple and break down and that true believers would recognize each other and enjoy the fellowship which they have as one Body in Christ. Never until we recognize the basis for our unity, *our baptism into Christ by the Holy Spirit*, will we enjoy true unity. There can be no true unity in mere organizations. There might be union, but not unity. But thank God as we saw Christ there baptized into our death at Calvary, and recognized that that death was not His—He had no death to die—that was *our* death. When we recognize this, and accept that death as ours by an act of our own will,

our own faith, as He became *one* with us at Calvary, so we then become *one* with Him also at Calvary. Calvary is always the meeting place:

"Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into His death?" (Rom. 6:3).

This is the only way you can be baptized into Christ. This is the only way we can be baptized into one another. Did you know the only way to come to know God is *in Christ*? But also, the only way to come to really know each other is *in Christ*. There is no unity apart from Him. All of Adam's children are divided, even his two first born were divided. One killed the other (Gen. 4:6-13), and as the race has multiplied, we now have over 6 billion individual personal wills. Ah, but as men are divided in Adam, so they can be united *in Christ*.

Do you know why human beings apart from Christ never really get to know each other? The human ego always stands in the way. They must always put up that front, that show window, if you please. With the Christian it is no longer so. The Christian has acknowledged that he is a poor undone sinner, hopelessly on the way to the lake of fire except that the Lord Jesus in His love and grace paid for our sins on Calvary's Cross. And since that ego has been deflated, believers, and believers alone, can know true unity in Christ.

Now then, that's what the Body of Christ is. The one Body into which all believers have been baptized as they were baptized into Christ.

"THE FIRSTBORN FROM THE DEAD"

In Colossians 1:18, we have that phrase again, "the firstborn," for it says here:

"And He is the Head of the Body, the Church: Who is the beginning, *the firstborn from the dead;* that in all things He might have the preeminence" (Col. 1:18).

The idea is not that He was the first One to be raised. Ah no! He is the first One who *arose by His own power*, arose from the dead, and became the master of death; pushed death back through death itself. Grappled with it, and overcame it, and came forth, and said:

***"I AM HE THAT LIVETH, AND WAS DEAD; AND, BEHOLD, I AM ALIVE FOR EVERMORE, AMEN; AND HAVE THE KEYS OF HELL [HADES] AND OF DEATH"* (Rev. 1:18).**

The "keys" of "death" and of "hell." The Master of death. In Ephesians 1:20-23, we read about the "mighty power" of God:

"Which He wrought in Christ, when He raised Him from the dead, and set Him at His own right hand in the heavenly places,

"Far above all principality, and power, and might, and dominion, and every name that is named, not only in this [age], but also in that which is to come:

"And hath put all things under His feet, and gave Him to be the Head over all things to the Church,

"Which is His Body, the fulness of Him that filleth all in all."

THAT HE MIGHT HAVE THE PREEMINENCE

This is why it says "*that in all things He [must] have the preeminence*" (Col. 1:18). He is the "Head." He is the "Head" of creation. He is "the Head of the Body" and the Master of death; surely then, as believers, we want Him to have the *preeminence*. Now then, the Apostle closes this passage of the first chapter by saying:

***"For it pleased the Father that in Him should all fulness dwell"* (Col. 1:19).**

Again, in Ephesians, Paul speaks of the great message that he had been proclaiming, and prays that we may comprehend it in order that we may know "*the love of Christ*" and be "filled with all the fulness of God":

"That Christ may dwell in your hearts by faith; that ye, being rooted and grounded in love,

"*May be able to comprehend with all saints* what is the *breadth*, and *length*, and *depth*, and *height;*

"And *to know the love of Christ*, which passeth knowledge, *that ye might be filled with all the fulness of God"* (Eph. 3:17-19).

My beloved friend, God wants you to have a rich, full life, and you may enjoy that fulness, if you will acknowledge Christ as your Savior, and your Head, and your Lord.

He wants you "to know the love of Christ, that passeth knowledge, that ye might be filled with all the fulness of God."

THE PERSON OF CHRIST

Do We Belittle Christ?

Again, as with the crucifixion and resurrection, the Old Testament presents Christ, the Son of God, only in veiled phraseology and in types. The Trinity is only hinted at. This is one reason why the Jew insists there is but one God and that He did not, and will not, have a Son. True, Psalm 40:7 says: "*In the volume of the book it is written of Me*" but, again, who is the "ME"? We do not find out until some time after the Son of God has appeared incarnate.

The glory of His person is not revealed even in His ministry on earth, for from birth to death He suffers humiliation. The stable, the swaddling bands, the

weariness, hunger and thirst. He has no place to lay His head, the multitudes throng Him, the leaders plot against Him, Martha rebukes Him, Peter denies Him, Judas betrays Him. His Deity is veiled by His humanity, His glory is buried under poverty and shame.

After His baptism by water He spoke of another baptism; that of the Cross:

"But I have a baptism to be baptized with, and how am I straitened till it be accomplished" (Luke 12:50).

Thank God we know Him no longer after the flesh (II Cor. 5:16) for, as one has said, how could a Christ in straitened circumstances mean so much to us as the Lord of glory, dispensing the riches of His grace and the merits of Calvary?

Even in resurrection His glory was still veiled, else His disciples could not have beheld Him. Probably the greatest display of His glory, while on earth, took place at the transfiguration when, appearing with Moses and Elias, His face shone as the sun and His raiment was white as the light. Yet Peter could say: "Lord it is *good for us to be here..., let us make here three tabernacles; one for Thee, and one for Moses, and one for Elias"* (Matt. 17:4).

Compare this with that light above the brightness of the noonday sun, which blinded Paul as the glorified Lord appeared to him (Acts 26:13-16).

Once more it is Paul—and no one until Paul—who says:

"Yea, though we have known Christ after the flesh, yet now henceforth know we Him no more" (II Cor. 5:16).

In this one letter to the Colossians alone he presents Christ in His glory as all the other Bible writers together do not present it.

There he presents Christ as the Head of all creation—not the material creation alone but also things "*visible and invisible, whether they be thrones, or dominions, or principalities or powers; all things were created by Him and for Him*" (Col. 1:15,16).

There he presents Him also as the Sustainer of all, for "by *Him all things consist* [*cling together*]" (1:17).

There he presents Him as *the Head of the Body* and *the Master of death* (1:18).

There he declares that *in all things Christ must have the preeminence* and that "*it pleased the Father that in Him should all fulness dwell,*" that *He* should be the Fount of every blessing, the Source of all supply (1:18,19).

There he presents Christ as *the sole Medium of reconciliation to God* (1:20) and unfolds "*the riches of the glory of this Mystery among the Gentiles, which is* CHRIST IN YOU [GENTILES], THE HOPE OF GLORY" (1:27).

There he shows Him as the One "*in Whom are hid all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge*" (2:3), as the One in whom dwells "*all the fulness of the Godhead bodily,*" and in whom the believer stands gloriously "complete" (2:9,10).

Little wonder he warns us lest any man "rob" us, "*judge*" us, or "*beguile*" us (Col. 2:8,16,18) of the *appropriation* and *enjoyment* of our position and blessings in Christ.

And we have but *begun* with the Colossian Epistle. Delve more deeply into all the chapters and then read all that Paul says in his other great epistles as to the glory of Christ, and see if we belittle Christ

by insisting upon the distinctive character of Paul's apostleship.

To those who foolishly suppose that the words of Christ are found only in the so-called Gospel records and that the so-called Great Commission contains His last words, we say: look again and learn that His most important words were spoken from Heaven to and through the Apostle Paul.

It is with regard to his First Epistle to Timothy that the apostle says, by inspiration:

"If any man teach OTHERWISE, and consent not to wholesome words, EVEN THE WORDS OF OUR LORD JESUS CHRIST....He is proud, knowing nothing" (I Tim. 6:3,4).

And in even sterner tone the apostle speaks to the Corinthians:

"if I come again, I will not spare:

"Since ye seek a proof of Christ speaking in me" (II Cor. 13:2,3).

No, we do *not* belittle our blessed Lord by recognizing the distinctive character of Paul's ministry, but we *do* belittle Him by failing to recognize it, since Paul was the chosen vessel to and through whom His heavenly glory is revealed. And if we turn a deaf ear to his words we shall have to give an account to Him who instructed Paul to say:

"I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as I am the apostle of the Gentiles, I magnify mine office" (Rom. 11:13).

Perhaps our brethren who have been minimizing Paul's office and the glorious truths he was sent to proclaim, will yet reconsider their position and join us in preaching the Lord Jesus Christ *"according to the revelation of the Mystery."* God grant it!

Chapter 4 — Colossians 1:20-23

THE FINISHED WORK OF CHRIST

"And, having made peace through the blood of His Cross, by Him to reconcile all things unto Himself; by Him, I say, whether they be things in earth, or things in heaven.

"And you, that were sometime alienated and enemies in your mind by wicked works, yet now hath He reconciled

"In the body of His flesh through death, to present you holy and unblameable and unreproveable in His sight" (Col. 1:20-22).

PEACE AND RECONCILIATION

My unsaved friend, if you want those things that are most worthwhile, you'll find them only in Christ. If you want eternal life, John 3:35,36 reads this way,

"The Father loveth the Son, and hath given all things into His hand. He that believeth on the Son hath everlasting life: and he that believeth not the Son shall not see life; but the wrath of God abideth on him."

Or is it satisfaction you want? Remember what the Lord Jesus said to the Samaritan woman in the fourth chapter of John? He spoke of Jacob's well of course, but He was drawing a figure of her poor life:

"Whosoever drinketh of this water shall thirst again:

"But whosoever drinketh of the water that *I* shall give him *shall never thirst;* but the water that I shall give him shall be in him a well [fountain] of water, springing up into everlasting life" (John 4:13,14).

Oh, and you can go beyond that. Think of the wonders of Paul's great message of grace, grace that gives

us "redemption through [Christ's] blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of His grace" (Eph. 1:7). And then raises us up together with Christ and gives us life, and puts us in the heavenlies, and gives us a position at God's right hand, the place of favor and honor and blessing and privilege. And there we read we are "blessed with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ."

About this great message, Paul says, Oh, I want you to "comprehend" it, "that ye might be filled with all the fulness of God" (Eph. 3:18,19) and to the Colossians, he wrote:

"For it pleased the Father that in Him should all fulness dwell" (Col. 1:19).

"For in Him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily. And ye are complete [made full] in Him" (Col. 2:9,10).

Ah, how much God has for us. How He would enrich our spiritual lives and make life worthwhile. He can for you, my unsaved friend, and He wants to do it for you, if you'll only believe what God says about Christ. He is God. He is all that He claimed to be. And He gave Himself on Calvary's Cross for you.

THE VICARIOUS DEATH OF CHRIST

Now then, as Paul answers the modernists or the liberals about the person of Christ, he goes on to deal with the work of Christ.

The modernist denies the vicarious death of Christ. He says that the doctrine of salvation through the blood[1] is loathsome to the finer senses.

Now let's see, "It pleased the Father that in Him should all fulness dwell" (Col. 1:19).

And in Colossians 1:20 we read, "And, having made *peace* through the blood of His Cross," it pleased the

Father, "by Him to *reconcile* all things unto Himself; by Him, I say, whether they be things in earth, or things in heaven." There are several things about this twentieth verse that we should understand very clearly. First of all, God has already made peace for the sinner by *the blood of the Cross* of Christ. As we read in II Corinthians 5:19:

"To wit, that God was in Christ, reconciling the world unto Himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them...."

His part in reconciliation is done. He is not counting their trespasses to them. The question is, will they be friends with Him? And that's why Paul goes on in II Corinthians:

"Now then we are ambassadors for Christ,[2] as though God did beseech you by us: we pray [beg] you in Christ's stead, be ye reconciled to God.

"For He hath made Him to be sin for us, [Christ] who knew no sin, that we might be made the righteousness of God in Him" (II Cor. 5:20,21).

JEWS AND GENTILES RECONCILED TO GOD

"And that He might reconcile both unto God in one Body by the Cross, having slain the enmity thereby" (Eph. 2:16).

That's a marvelous thing. Men took Christ, and they spit in His face, and they pulled His hair and His beard, and they smote Him with rods. They scourged Him. They buffeted Him. They crowned Him with thorns; they put a robe on Him and a reed in His hand for a sceptre and mocked Him, and made fun of Him. And then they actually nailed Him to a tree. As the Psalmist says, "...they pierced My hands and My feet" (Psa. 22:16). You would think that would enrage the Father. And in one sense it did. This is what, prophetically speaking, has made the enmity,

and God is still going to have things "out" with this world and with His own favored nation. The prophetic Scriptures are full of that. The Great Tribulation, the time of the outpouring of God's wrath is still to come for this world.

Ah, but it is this great Mystery, the great *secret* revealed through Paul, the chief of sinners saved by grace, that has intervened. Consequently, for the present, God has counted Christ's death as the payment for our sins. He died your death, and mine. And so God in infinite grace has "*made peace through the blood of His Cross.*"

God has done it so that "by Him" He might "reconcile all things to Himself, *by Him*, I say, whether they be things in earth or things in heaven."

UNIVERSALISM

Now, let's be very careful here.

Here comes the Universalist, who says, Oh, finally, everybody will be reconciled. Doesn't it say here, that by Him He's going to reconcile all to Himself?

No, it does not say that. In the first place, the Universalist puts the emphasis in the wrong place. The Universalist reads the verse this way, "By Him to reconcile all things unto Himself, all things, I say"—but the Apostle Paul does not say that here. He says,

"By Him to reconcile all things to Himself; *by Him*, I say, whether they be things in earth, or things in heaven" (Col. 1:20).

The thought here is that the only one through whom men can possibly be reconciled to God is the Lord Jesus Christ. And you'll notice that those who

were reconciled occupy earth and heaven, not hades or the lake of fire. This is very important, for in Philippians Chapter Two we have another subject, not universal reconciliation, but universal subjugation, and more than heaven and earth is involved here:

"Wherefore God also hath highly exalted Him, and given Him a name which is above every name:

"That at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, *AND THINGS UNDER THE EARTH*."

Here the *celestial*, the *terrestrial* and the *infernal* are included.

***"And that every tongue should [will] confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of the Father"* (Phil. 2:9-11).**

But this is universal subjugation, not universal reconciliation. There is quite a difference in the Apostle's words for our faith today:

"That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised Him from the dead, thou shalt be saved.

"For with the heart man believeth unto righteousness; and with the mouth confession is made unto salvation" (Rom. 10:9,10).

GOD WANTS TO SAVE YOU

The whole idea of this passage in Colossians is that God has "made peace through the blood of [Christ's] Cross," and it pleased Him, having done this, "to reconcile all things unto Himself, by Him, I say, whether they be things in earth, or things in heaven." And then in Verse 21, those beautiful words, *"And you"*—ah, my beloved Christian friend, what a demonstration of the reconciling power of God and the reconciling grace of God.

"[God] will have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth" (I Tim. 2:4).

He could write to these Colossians, *"And you,"* to reconcile all, *"and you."* It is His desire to reconcile all, He pleads, Oh, be reconciled to God.

"*And you*, that were [once] alienated and enemies in your mind by wicked works, yet now hath He reconciled

"In the body of His flesh through death, to [that He might] present you holy and unblameable and unreproveable in His sight" (Col. 1:21,22).

Surely it was true as the apostle proved in the introduction to this epistle, that this gospel is gone into all the world and brings forth fruit as it doth also in you. *And you*, once alienated and enemies in your mind by wicked works, are now reconciled. How? Oh, I wonder how the Modernists or the Universalist will ever answer this. Paul has already said that Christ made peace through the *blood* of His Cross. Now he emphasizes this in Verse 22:

"[Reconciled] in the body of His flesh through death, to present you holy and unblameable and unreproveable in His sight."

Oh, you might say that you don't believe this. That's up to you. But then don't say that you believe in the Bible. Don't say you believe in the Bible and deny the vicarious death of our Lord Jesus Christ or the need of the sinner to be saved through that death as his only hope. Ah, as I say, there is nothing modern about this *denial of God's Word*.

We can go way, way back to the Book of Genesis, only the fourth chapter, to the story of Cain and Abel, the two that were first born into the world.

Remember God had told them both what kind of sacrifice they should bring, because in Hebrews

Chapter 11 we read that Abel brought his *by faith* (Rom. 10:17).

God told them to bring a blood sacrifice for the atonement of their souls. And Abel brought of the firstlings of his flock. But Cain, Oh, he had a better idea. He dressed up a beautiful looking thing of the fruit of the ground, you see, and the fruit of his own toil. In disobedience he brought *that* to God instead. And we read,

"And the Lord had respect unto Abel and to his offering: But to Cain and his offering He had not respect" (Gen. 4:4,5).

What was the result? The record goes on to say,

"And Cain was very wroth [angry], and his countenance fell. And the Lord said unto Cain, Why art thou wroth? and why is thy countenance fallen? If thou doest well, shalt thou not be accepted? and if thou doest not well, [a sin offering] lieth at the door" (Gen. 4:5-7).

Why don't you come the way I have told you to?

Well, that is what God says to all of us today. There are men who don't want to think that somebody had to die, or that *Christ* had to die to save them, but this is the only way you can be saved. You'll strive in vain from now until doomsday and what's worse, God requires that which is past, and you have already sinned, so you must trust the Lord Jesus Christ as Savior.

This is so beautiful. On the one side of the Cross you have the words, *enemies*, *alienated*, "by wicked works." On the other side the words, *holy*, *unblameable*, and *unreproveable* "in His sight." This is what God wants for you. This is the difference that the Cross can make, so my dear unsaved friend, why don't you turn to the Lord Jesus Christ right now, and accept Him as your own personal Savior?

"IF YE CONTINUE IN THE FAITH"

"If ye continue in the faith grounded and settled, and be not moved away from the hope of the gospel, which ye have heard, and which was preached to every creation under heaven; whereof I Paul am made a minister" (Col. 1:23).

THE BIG LITTLE WORD, "IF"

I would like to deal with just one verse here, Colossians 1:23. In fact, just one little word in that verse, which really is a very big word. The big little word, "if."

Paul writes that Christ died for you, that God might present you holy, unblameable, and unreproveable in His sight, "if ye continue in the faith…and be not moved away." Ah, that little word, "if," can loom very large, can it not, depending, of course, on how it is used.

Remember that little word "if" in the Law of Moses, that Covenant of the Law that God made with Israel in Exodus 19:5, when He spoke these words:

"If ye will obey My voice indeed, and keep My covenant, then ye shall be a peculiar treasure unto Me among all people [nations]: for all the earth is Mine. And ye shall be unto Me a kingdom of priests" (Ex. 19:5,6).

In other words, *if* you obey Me, I'll bless you. That was the very core of the Mosaic covenant, the Covenant of the Law.

Do you remember their reply? They raised their hands and shouted, "All that the Lord hath spoken we will do" (Ex. 19:8), but they didn't do it. Before Moses was even down the mountain with the Ten Commandments, they were dancing naked like heathen about a golden calf (Ex. 32:1-35). And from

that day on, when they began to break the Law of Moses, they were never able to keep it, though they tried, and neither have we succeeded in keeping that Law:

"Now we know that what things soever the law saith, it saith to them who are under the law: that every mouth may be stopped, and all the world may [might] become [be brought in] guilty before God.

"Therefore by the deeds of the law there shall no flesh be justified in [God's] sight: for by the law is the knowledge of sin" (Rom. 3:19,20).

Oh, but thank God for the next verse, where the Apostle Paul, the chief of sinners saved by grace, declares:

"But now the righteousness of God *without the law* is manifested…" (Rom. 3:21).

Thank God for that.

Here in Colossians One we find that word "if" used in a setting that has made many people conclude that those who have once trusted Christ as their Savior are saved, but they might be lost again "if" they're not faithful to Him, and "if" they don't continue in the faith, grounded and settled, and so on.

Now let's see if this is what this passage teaches. But before we deal with this passage itself, let's first consider the teachings of the Bible as a whole about salvation.

THE ETERNAL SECURITY OF THE BELIEVER

When one trusts Christ as Savior, is he safe forever? Is it a once-for-all transaction? or must he strive to keep saved? Now I think it would be well if we just set aside Colossians for a moment.

It is better always to find the general teaching of Scripture on any subject, and then go to the particular. And I might say here that this is not a dispensational matter. It does not matter in what dispensation men were saved, they were either saved eternally or they had to try to keep themselves saved. Dispensations don't change that at all, as we'll see.

Now it seems to me that nothing could be clearer or more emphatic than that the Word of God teaches that men once saved are saved for all eternity. So, please consider what we have to say in case you've been taught that the doctrine of *eternal security* is of the devil or something like that. Please listen to what the Word of God has to say about this.

CHOSEN IN CHRIST

In Ephesians 1:4 we read that the believer "was chosen in Christ *before* the world began." God chose us in Christ before the world began, that is, before we ever did or did not sin.

In II Thessalonians 2:13, note what Paul says about the believers at Thessalonica:

"But we are bound to give thanks alway to God for you, brethren beloved of the Lord, because God hath from the beginning chosen you to salvation through sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the truth."

So even when you believed the truth, when you trusted Christ as your Savior it was only because God was good to you, isn't that true? He caused somebody to testify to you, or He laid the burden of sin upon your heart and made you start seeking. Well, that's what the Bible says, we are chosen unto salvation through sanctification of the Spirit, the setting apart of the Spirit, and belief of the truth.

BORN OF GOD

We read in several passages that the believer has been born, or begotten, of God (John 1:12,13; 3:3; I Pet. 1:23). We have been "born" or "begotten" of seed that cannot die. Paul speaks of this too, in Titus 3:5:

"Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to His mercy He saved us, by the washing of regeneration [get it? *of regeneration*, not the washing of water, not the washing of baptism, the washing of regeneration], and renewing of the Holy Ghost."

Now if we have been born of God, certainly He will not now disown us; we are His own born children. Paul has a special word for that, *teknon*, born ones. We are, as the Scotch would call it, the "bairn." A Scottish mother will talk about "my own bairn," my own born one. We are the born ones of God. Surely He will not disown us, even though we may often fail.

GOD'S WORKMANSHIP

Then in Ephesians 2:10, the Apostle says, "we are [God's] workmanship." Not our own, it wasn't because we were good enough, or tried hard enough, or kept trying hard enough.

"For we are *His* workmanship, *created* in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath *before* ordained that we should walk in them" (Eph. 2:10).

So we are not only God's children, as Paul often says, but we have a right now to call Him our Father for we are His children. But we are more than children of God, we are His creation. He has made us "a new creation" in Christ Jesus (II Cor. 5:17; Gal. 6:15; Eph. 2:15). Now surely, that must mean that we are eternally His.

SALVATION—BY GRACE WITHOUT WORKS

In Ephesians 2:8,9 there is a fourth argument. There he says, "For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: *Not of works*, lest any man should boast."

And in Romans 4:5 he goes farther, "But to him that *worketh not*, but believeth on Him that *justifieth* the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness."

Now my dear friend, if God takes the sinner and saves him, if He will take the most ungodly, if He will take the drunkard, and the murderer, the thief and the liar, and save him by grace through faith, do you mean to tell me that He would not look in the same degree of grace on His own children? Even though they may fail Him? Why, of course He would. We are His and His forever.

ACCEPTED IN THE BELOVED

In Ephesians 1:6 Paul says:

"To the praise of the glory of His grace, wherein *HE* hath made us accepted in the Beloved."

That's beautiful. You remember when the Lord Jesus came up from His baptism[3] that He was numbered with the transgressors. God broke through the heavens, as it were, and men heard His voice from heaven saying:

***"THIS IS MY BELOVED SON, IN WHOM I AM WELL PLEASED"* (Matt. 3:17).**

The same phrase, really, the Son of His love, is used in Ephesians 1:6, "He hath made us to be accepted in the *Beloved* [One]," or the Son of His love. And then it goes on:

"In whom we have redemption through His blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of His grace" (Eph. 1:7).

So God sees us no longer in our poor selves, He sees us "in Christ."

Now, the Bible is very strong on this subject, and especially the epistles of Paul, as to the glorious truth of the eternal security[4] of the believer in Christ.

COLOSSIANS 1:23

So when you come to Colossians 1:23 wait for further light if you do not understand it. But don't immediately overlook, or ignore, or forget, all that God says to assure you that salvation is His work, and, as Solomon said, He does it *forever*:

"I know that, whatsoever God doeth, it shall be for ever: nothing can be put to it, nor anything taken from it..." (Eccl. 3:14). The Eternal God has done it.

Well you ask, "What is the answer, then, to that *if* in Colossians 1:23?"

Some say that the word should be translated *since*; He is going "to present you holy, unblameable, unreproveable in God's sight *since* you continue in the faith, grounded and settled" and so on.

But I rather doubt that, because the apostle was not with them, and he was not taking that for granted as far as his observation was concerned; he couldn't see that.

Somebody says well, "You'll be presented holy and unblameable, unreproveable, if ye continue in the faith." You're saved, but you'll be presented before God holy and unblameable and unreproveable only if you continue in the faith grounded and settled," and so on.

Well, that can hardly be so either, because in this passage here, Paul is telling us about *the finished work of Christ*. He says we were "reconciled in the body of His flesh through death," and He did this "to present you holy, unblameable, and unreproveable in His sight."

THE REAL EXPLANATION

There are two words translated "if" in the New Testament, but even the grammar is involved. The idea of one is, *if haply, if so be*; but the other is, *if indeed*. It is Paul's familiar challenge; you have the negative side in I Corinthians 15:13: "If there be no resurrection"—he knows there is a resurrection, but he is challenging them:

Verse 14, "if Christ be not risen," then there is no resurrection. Verse 16, "if the dead rise not." Verse 17, "if Christ be not raised"—now, he had no question about the resurrection, he knew that resurrection was a fact, but he was challenging the Corinthians.

Now that's on the negative side. But right here in Colossians we have the positive side, for example, in Colossians 2:20, he says, "If ye be dead with Christ... why, as though living in the world, are ye subject to ordinances?" Now he didn't question that they had been *raised with Christ*, they had been. But it's a challenge:

***"If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth on the right hand of God"* (Col. 3:1).**

I might illustrate it in this way. Here's a mother, and her son has turned to be 21, and he's bragging: "I'm 21 now, you know, and I can do what I want"

and so on. And the mother says, "Well, if you're 2l, act it." Now she didn't have any doubt that he was 21, and yet she used the word *if*. She was challenging him, and Paul used it in this very same way here in Colossians One. Christ died to reconcile you:

"And, having made peace through the blood of His Cross, by Him to reconcile all things unto Himself; by Him, I say, whether they be things in earth, or things in heaven.

"And you, that were sometime alienated and enemies in your mind by wicked works, yet now hath he reconciled

***"IN THE BODY OF HIS FLESH THROUGH DEATH, TO PRESENT YOU HOLY AND UNBLAMEABLE AND UNREPROVEABLE IN HIS SIGHT"* (Col. 1:20-22).**

Assuming is the way he uses, *"IF INDEED,"* "assuming that you are still as you were when I saw you." If they had not been, if they had departed from the faith, it would have meant only one thing: that they had never been saved in the first place, because God keeps His own.

Chapter 5 — Colossians 1:24-29

THE KNOWLEDGE OF THE MYSTERY

"Who now rejoice in my sufferings for you, and fill up that which is behind of the afflictions of Christ in my flesh for His Body's sake, which is the Church:

"Whereof I am made a minister, according to the dispensation of God which is given to me for you, to fulfil the Word of God;

"Even the Mystery which hath been hid from ages and from generations, but now is made manifest to His saints:

"To whom God would make known what is the riches of the glory of this Mystery among the Gentiles; which is Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Col. 1:24-27).

HOW THE MYSTERY AFFECTS OUR LIVES

It should be evident, even from a superficial reading of the epistles of Paul, that his great message was nothing less than the revelation of a secret "hid in God" all through the preceding dispensations; that what he ushered in was not a fulfillment of the prophetic plan but an *interruption* of it.

Had Israel accepted Messiah at Pentecost and become the channel of blessing to the nations, men would have witnessed the fulfillment of *prophecy* among the Gentiles, but the present blessing of the Gentiles by grace, through Israel's *fall,* is called a "*Mystery,*" an unprophesied work "among the Gentiles," and the passage quoted above declares that God would have His saints know "*what is the riches of the glory of this Mystery among the Gentiles.*" God

hasten the day when greatly increased numbers will come into the knowledge and blessing of this wonderful truth!

HOW IT AFFECTS US IN THE REALM OF THE PHYSICAL

Outside the Pauline Epistles the Word of God declares:

"They shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover" (Mark 16:18).

"And the prayer of faith shall save the sick"(Jas. 5:15).

How many are claiming these promises in the "healing" meetings of our day! On the surface there seems to be little doubt that at least some of these "healings" are genuine. Yet many of the "healed" must keep telling themselves that they are restored, while still others know full well that they have *not* been restored. Meanwhile the death rate remains unchanged as Pentecostalists, Roman Catholics and Christian Scientists, all of whom base their claims for healing on the above and kindred passages and all of whom can muster similar "evidence," pass out of this life, one by one, along with the rest. Their claims *all* fail in the *final* test.

How the knowledge of the Mystery establishes us here and delivers us from the inevitable disillusionment which comes to those who claim promises not made to them.

Mark 16:18, from which we quote above, is part of the Great Commission given by our Lord to His eleven apostles. Had the kingdom they proclaimed been accepted, those who were healed would have gone right on living in perfect health. But the kingdom was *not*

accepted. Hence God interrupted the Prophetic Program and raised up Paul, that *other* apostle, to offer *reconciliation,* by grace through faith, to His enemies.

In connection with this interruption of the Prophetic Program with its healing demonstrations, our apostle makes an inspired declaration which we would all do well to consider thoughtfully:

"For we know that the WHOLE creation groaneth and travaileth in pain together UNTIL NOW.

"And not only they, but ourselves also, which have the firstfruits of the Spirit, even we ourselves groan within ourselves, WAITING for the adoption, to wit, the redemption of our body" (Rom. 8:22,23).

As to the promise: "*The prayer of faith shall save the sick,*" it is evident that this was not made to us, for it was written by James, not Paul, and was addressed "*to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad*" (Jas. 1:1). Surely such a promise is not applicable to the Israelites of our day in their unbelief, and it is not even addressed to Gentiles or to the Body of Christ.

But Paul, "the apostle of the Gentiles" (Rom. 11:13) and the minister of the Body (Col. 1:24,25) makes it unmistakably clear that while in the present dispensation God does frequently spare the sick for a time in answer to prayer, "the outward man" still perishes (II Cor. 4:16) and "we that are in this tabernacle do groan" (II Cor. 5:4). Indeed, in view of the wickedness of "this present evil age" (Gal. 1:4) and the corresponding revelation of God's over-abounding grace (Rom. 5:20) it is for our good that we are thus "burdened" physically.

Paul himself was "*given*...a thorn in the flesh," lest he should be "exalted above measure" by the "abundance of the revelations" made to him, and thus lose

his usefulness and his rewards (II Cor. 12:7). Thrice he besought the Lord to remove the affliction (Ver. 8) but was told:

"MY GRACE IS SUFFICIENT FOR THEE; FOR MY STRENGTH IS MADE PERFECT IN WEAKNESS" (Ver. 9).

How true we have found this to be in our experience! Our infirmities have made us lean the harder on God and pray the more. They have served to make us humble and bring us closer to Him in whose presence is "fulness of joy." Under the present circumstances spiritual *victory in sickness* is generally a far greater blessing than *deliverance from sickness.* It is seldom that we can be trusted with "the best of health," so prone are we to forget Him who loved us.

May our readers see this, and may we be enabled to say with all our hearts what the Apostle Paul said in this connection:

"Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me.
"Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities...for when I am weak, then am I strong" (II Cor. 12:9,10).

HOW IT AFFECTS US IN THE REALM OF THE MATERIAL

But the knowledge of the Mystery also has a profound effect upon the management of our material interests, whether large or small.

Apart from this knowledge how can God's people *but* be faced with commands impossible to carry out?

During His earthly ministry our Lord told *one* prospective follower:

"One thing thou lackest: go thy way, sell whatsoever thou hast, and give to the poor, and thou shalt have treasure in

heaven: and come, take up the cross, and follow Me" (Mark 10:21).

Twelve men who had already forsaken all to follow Him (Matt. 19:27 cf. Matt. 4:18-22; Luke 5:27,28, etc.) were later sent out as His apostles, with the instructions:

"Provide neither gold, nor silver, nor brass in your purses" (Matt. 10:9).

And to the "little flock" of His followers He said:

"Fear not...for it is your Father's good pleasure to give you the kingdom.
"Sell that ye have, and give alms"(Luke 12:32,33).

In His great Sermon on the Mount He said:

"Give to him that asketh thee, and from him that would borrow of thee turn not thou away" (Matt. 5:42).

From these and other Scriptures it is evident that those who would follow our Lord were expected to part with their earthly possessions.

Is this still a requirement? Those who have come to recognize the distinctive ministry of Paul for the present dispensation know that it is not, for *our* God-appointed apostle says, by inspiration:

"But if any provide not for his own, and specially for those of his own house, he hath denied the faith, and is worse than an infidel [Lit., unbeliever]" (I Tim. 5:8).

But what about those who do *not* recognize Paul as the apostle of the present dispensation, nor understand the great Mystery he was sent to proclaim; who suppose that his ministry was but a perpetuation of that of the twelve: how can they sidestep these plain commands of our Lord?

Some such remind us that in view of Israel's rejection of their King the Lord rescinded these kingdom requirements just before the Cross (Luke 22:35-38) but we remind *them* that *on* the Cross the Lord prayed for the forgiveness of His enemies, and that the program was thenceforth resumed among Christ's followers with greater earnestness than ever. It was at Pentecost, after the "Great Commission" and the pouring out of the Holy Spirit, that *"ALL that believed were together and had all things common; and sold their possessions and goods*[1] *and parted them to all men, as every man had need"* (Acts 2:44,45). *"Neither said any of them that ought of the things which he possessed was his own....Neither was there any among them that lacked"* (Acts 4:32-34).

Those who hold that the Sermon on the Mount and our Lord's earthly teachings belong to the present dispensation, or who call us "back to Pentecost," surely fail to demonstrate their beliefs. They do not give their possessions for the common good. Instead they water down the plain commands of our Lord, suggesting that we ought to be *willing* to give up all; that this ought to be our attitude of heart.

Attitude of heart—without any expression or evidence of it? The Pentecostal believers did not deal so with the instructions of their Master. They took seriously the solemn words with which He had closed His Sermon on the Mount:

"Therefore whosoever heareth these sayings of Mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock:

"And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell not: for it was founded upon a rock.

"And every one that heareth these sayings of Mine, and doeth them not, shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the sand:

"And the rain descended, and the floods came, and the winds blew, and beat upon that house; and it fell: and great was the fall of it" (Matt. 7:24-27).

Yet we can well understand why the brethren referred to, do *not* sell what they have and give to the poor. They *could* not do this without getting into financial difficulty and dishonoring their Lord. Even at Jerusalem this order of things broke down as the offer of the kingdom was rejected by Israel and withdrawn. Nor could the believers there have practiced it at all except that their natures were *all* supernaturally controlled by the Holy Spirit (Acts 2:4).

How reassuring, then, to find that such commands are *not* given for *our* obedience in "this present evil age," and that the instructions given to *us* fit so perfectly the circumstances in which we find ourselves.

We are instructed to provide for our own, and "especially for those of [our] own house" (I Tim. 5:8), yet we are cautioned that *"they that will be rich fall into temptation and a snare, and into many foolish and hurtful lusts, which drown men in destruction and perdition. For the love of money is [a] root [which is] all evil"* (I Tim. 6:9,10). Likewise those who "*are* rich in this world" are exhorted *"that they be not high-minded, nor trust in uncertain riches, but in the living God, who giveth us richly all things to enjoy; that they do good, that they be rich in good works, ready to distribute, willing to communicate"*[2] (I Tim. 6:17,18).

In the teachings of Paul for us no one is told to dispose of all his goods for distribution among his brethren. Yet we are all reminded that we should abound

in the grace of sacrificial giving (II Cor. 8:3-7) to prove the sincerity of our love (Ver. 8) remembering "the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that, though He was rich, yet for [our] sakes He became poor, that [we] through His poverty might be rich" (Ver. 9). We are instructed to give *systematically* (I Cor. 16:1,2), *sensibly* (Ver. 2), *joyfully* (II Cor. 9:7), remembering that "it *is* more blessed to give than to receive" (Acts 20:35) and that "*He which soweth sparingly shall reap also sparingly,*" while "*he which soweth bountifully shall reap also bountifully*" (II Cor. 9:6).

Most important of all: We should *first* give *ourselves* to the Lord and to His work (II Cor. 8:5) knowing that we have nothing that we did not first receive from God (I Cor. 4:7); that we are not even our own, but have been bought with a price—and *such* a price! (I Cor. 6:19,20). How the work of God would go on apace if these things were remembered and obeyed!

HOW IT AFFECTS US IN THE REALM OF THE SPIRITUAL

While the knowledge of the Mystery revealed through Paul has a profound practical effect upon our lives where physical and material matters are concerned, it has the greatest effect of all in the realm of the *spiritual*.

How It Affects Our Study of the Word

How the knowledge of the Mystery unravels the perplexing tangle which theologians have left us with respect to God's message and program for *today!* How the teachings of Scripture regarding *other* dispensations fall into their proper places and assume their proper proportions when viewed in the light of this

sacred secret! To how many problems it is the one solution; to how many doors the only key!

After our Lord's resurrection He appeared to His apostles and *"opened…their understanding, that they might understand the Scriptures"*—that is, the Old Testament Scriptures, which were all they had at that time. This statement from Luke 24:45 does not imply that the apostles now understood every detail and had no more to learn, for our Lord continued teaching them for forty days more. It implies rather that they now understood the prophetic *plan* and had in their hands the *key* to the events which were transpiring about them.

So it is with the Mystery revealed by the ascended Lord through Paul. An understanding of it does not imply a mastery of every detail of Scripture or even of all those Scriptures relating to the present dispensation. It implies rather an understanding of the long-hidden *plan* which is the secret of God's dealings with men of every age, but especially with men of "this present evil age."

In the interpretation of the Scripture there is really only one alternative to the understanding and acknowledgment of the truth of the Mystery; that is the so-called "spiritualization" of the Old Testament promises and prophecies.

The whole "spiritualization" theory came about by a failure to recognize "the Mystery" proclaimed by Paul. Theologians observed that the prophecies about Christ and Israel in the Old Testament *began* to be fulfilled in the New. Exactly as predicted, our Lord was born of a virgin, in the town of Bethlehem; was brought up in Nazareth and later went about preaching "the gospel" and "doing good." But in spite

of this and in spite of the fact that both physically and legally He was of David's royal line, He was hated, plotted against and delivered to death. He was crucified, buried, raised; ascended to heaven and sent the Holy Spirit—all in literal fulfillment of Old Testament prophecy.

But at this point the *further* literal fulfillment of prophecy—as to Christ's return to reign as King on the throne of David over the house of Jacob in the land of Canaan—seemed to cease. Thus it was that the theologians concluded that the Spirit could not have meant exactly what He said in this latter list of prophecies. They concluded that by "the throne of David" He must have meant the throne which He now occupies at the Father's right hand, that by Canaan He must have meant heaven, that the Church today is "spiritual Israel" and that predictions of His exaltation as King of Israel really refer to His present position as Head of the Church.

The Mother of Heresies

But such arbitrary altering of the plain Word of God to make it fit a preconceived plan should never be called "the *spiritualization* of the Scriptures." There is nothing spiritual about failing to take God at His Word, and surely it is not spiritual but carnal and presumptuous to change the written Word to what God has *not* said.

Actually, the so-called "spiritualization" of the Scriptures is the mother of heresies. The evil of this system of interpretation lies in the following facts:

1. *It leaves us at the mercy of theologians.*

If Old Testament prophecies do not mean what they obviously, naturally seem to mean, who has

the authority to decide what they do mean? If some theologian can make "the land of Canaan," "the throne of David" and "the house of Jacob" all mean something else, he can interpret practically any Scripture to mean something else—and *theologians have done so.*

Then how can we be sure of any doctrine, however vital? How can we be sure that Romans 4:5 and Ephesians 2:8,9 cannot be altered in the same "spiritual" way? Then perhaps salvation, after all, is *not* by grace. Perhaps it *is* by works. Perhaps these Scriptures too really mean something else. And just as *we* are supposed to be spiritual Israel, who knows whether some other group may not be spiritual "*us*"*!*

Thus by the so-called "spiritualization" of the Scriptures the theologians of tomorrow might wrest from us what today's theologians have agreed to allow us. And like Romanists, it will do us no good to turn to the Scriptures themselves for light, for the Scriptures do not mean what they say and only trained theologians can interpret them for us.

2. *It affects the veracity of God.*

It is a thrust at His very honor.

Consider, for example, the Abrahamic Covenant. Now it is only *just* that the *promisee* be given a fair understanding of the promise, or at least that the promise does not mislead him into expecting what he will not receive, for he will have the right to claim exactly what he has been promised.

Now Moses *did* claim the promise which God had made to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob concerning their seed. In Deuteronomy 1:8 we find him saying to Israel:

"Go in and possess the land which the Lord sware unto your fathers, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, to give unto them and to their seed after them."

But if this promise cannot be taken at its face value; if God did not mean what He said; if He led Abraham's seed to expect what He did not intend to give, was He honest? How then can we depend upon any of His promises?

Peter writes to the believers of the dispersion:

"We have also a more sure word of prophecy; whereunto ye do well that ye take heed" (II Pet. 1:19).

But no prophecy is sure if another idea is intended than the one it conveys. Indeed such a practice would be nothing short of deliberate deception. Thus, while man's arbitrary altering of the plain Word of God may be called the "spiritualization" of the Scriptures, it actually casts reflections on the integrity of God. To this there can be but one reply:

"What if some did not believe? shall their unbelief make the faith [fidelity] of God without effect?
"God forbid: yea, let God be true, but every man a liar" (Rom. 3:3,4).

3. *It endorses apostasy.*

When Luke 1:32,33, for example, is "spiritualized" the Liberal says: "Fine! the throne of David and the house of Jacob must be viewed in a spiritual sense—*and so must the context!* Christ was not *really* born of a virgin. This picture is drawn merely to impress us with His purity of character."

And the Liberal denies the resurrection in the same way. Agreeing with the spiritualizer that Christ will not really occupy the throne of David, he goes on to argue: *Neither was He really raised from the*

dead! The Scriptures which say so must be interpreted otherwise.

And here come the members of the various cults claiming to comprise the 144,000 Israelites of the Book of Revelation. Ask one which tribe he is from and he will explain that not physical but spiritual Israelites are referred to!

And Rome employs the same reasoning. She seeks to establish the Kingdom of Christ on earth. It may seem at first that in this she leans to a literal rather than a "spiritual" interpretation of prophecy, but this is not so, for Christ is not now occupying David's literal throne, nor is the Church of Rome literal Israel.

Heresies, one after another, have risen and gained headway, not through denial, but through *perversion* of the written Word of God, through failing to take God at His Word, and changing it to harmonize with human theories.

The Only Alternative

But why have sincere, godly theologians, down through the centuries altered the plain Word of God as to the kingdom reign of Christ? Was it their intention to pervert the Scriptures? We do not believe so. Their course was the only alternative to a recognition of "*the Mystery...hid from ages and from generations*" but made known in the Pauline Epistles.

Had these men of God listened to the Spirit's Word through Paul they would *not* have found it necessary to alter the Old Testament prophecies to make them harmonize with the present dispensation. They would have learned that when prophetically all was ready for the outpouring of God's wrath and Christ's return to "break" the nations and "dash them in pieces" with

"a rod of iron;" when prophetically all was ready for His return to judge and reign, God *interrupted* the Prophetic Program to do something He had *never* predicted, saving Saul of Tarsus, the leader of the world's rebellion and using him to usher in the *"dispensation of the grace of God"* (Eph. 3:1-3) with its *"gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24), by which Jews and Gentiles are *reconciled* to God in *one Body* (Eph. 2:16) with *Christ* as their living Head (Col. 1:18) and their position and prospect *in the heavenlies* at God's right hand (Eph. 1:3; 2:6; Col. 3:1-4).

As to those among Fundamentalists who repudiate the "spiritualization" method, yet do not see or acknowledge the Mystery and Paul's distinctive ministry, these are in a constant state of consternation. To maintain their confused positions as to the "Great Commission" and water baptism they are forced to alter plain Scriptures in a manner which they themselves would not dare to call spiritualization (e.g., Mark 16:15-18; Acts 2:38, etc.). So the great alternative remains the same: Take God at His word, recognizing that the prophetic plan was interrupted (a *planned* interruption, of course) by the dispensation of Grace, or pervert the Scriptures and dishonor God.

As the so-called "spiritualization" of the Scriptures is the mother of heresies, so "the Mystery," the sacred secret revealed through Paul, is the answer to every heresy and the explanation of God's plans and purposes which can make Bible study such a delight.

When the truth of justification by grace through faith alone was recovered in Luther's day, those who received it exclaimed: *"How it opens the Scriptures!"* Later, when under John Darby and others the truth of the Lord's imminent return began to be recovered,

those who received it again exclaimed: "*How it opens the Scriptures!*" And today, as the truth of the Mystery is recovered, those who receive it exclaim once more, and with greater reason than ever: "*How it opens the Scriptures!*"

Never before has Bible study proved such a delight to those willing to go on in the truth. Never before did it present such a challenge. Oh, that God's people had a passion only to know God's Word and to make it known! If they did they would find the Mystery revealed through Paul *the answer* to our times. But the ignorance of the Bible among Christians, and even Christian leaders, yea, their *indifference* toward it, is appalling. May God yet grant a *true* spiritual revival among us; a renewed interest in what *He* has said, a renewed desire to *understand* and *carry out* His Word, before the golden opportunity is snatched away from us.

HOW THE MYSTERY AFFECTS OUR PRAYER LIFE

What makes sincere believers claim such passages as Matthew 21:22; Matthew 18:19 and James 5:15, with their unqualified promises of answered prayer? Ask them, and invariably they will answer that they claim them because they are "in the Bible," failing to rightly divide the Word of truth; failing to see that the prophetic purpose in view in each of these cases has been suspended for the present because of Israel's rejection of Christ and the bringing in of the dispensation of Grace.

In all honesty such must admit that even believing prayer is not *always* answered in the affirmative *today*, that the agreement of two believers on earth

does *not* guarantee an answer to *anything* they may ask, that the prayer of faith does *not* always save the sick—indeed, that to this very day men go on dying one by one, seldom living to be even 100 years old, an age which would have been, and will be, considered childhood during the reign of Christ (Isa. 65:20).

Except for the credulous, the inevitable result of claiming such promises[3] must be disillusionment and shaken faith.

How the knowledge of the Mystery revealed through Paul changes all this! The teachings of the Pauline Epistles exactly fit the situation in which we find ourselves today, and as we study them we praise God that He does not grant all we ask, even in faith, and gladly leave the ordering of our lives entirely to Him.

In the darkness of "this present evil age" we *recognize* Romans 8:26, that we do not know what to pray for as we ought; we *acknowledge* Romans 8:28, that God is working all out for our good; we *practice* Philippians 4:6, putting aside anxiety and making our requests known to God with thanksgiving, and we *experience* Philippians 4:7, the peace of God, which passes understanding, keeping our hearts and minds, through Christ Jesus.

HOW IT AFFECTS OUR CONDUCT

As we have said, "the Mystery" is not merely a secret hid from those who lived before Paul. It is also the secret of God's good news and His dealings with men down through the ages.

In the revelation of the Mystery we learn of Christ's identification with us and ours with Him; how He actually became one with us and died *our*

death so that we might become one with Him and share *His life*. Thus with Paul we can say:

"I am [have been] crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith [fidelity] of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave Himself for me" (Gal. 2:20).

How all this makes for objective living! How blessed to live in the realization that we have been baptized by the Spirit into the death, burial and resurrection of Christ; that we may consider the "old man" dead indeed and *forget* him; that God considers us *already in heaven* (Romans 6; Ephesians 2). How this knowledge should affect our conduct and cause us to live for God out of *sheer gratitude*.

Believers under the law also had much to be grateful for, but compare their circumstances with ours. They could not *forget* the past, or reckon the old nature to be dead and buried. In their sacrificial system there was the great Day of Atonement when there was "a *remembrance* again made of sins every year" (Heb. 10:3). On that day they were to do no work, but spend the time afflicting their souls for the sins they had committed, while the high priest offered a sacrifice for their atonement and confessed "all the iniquities of the children of Israel, and all their transgressions in all their sins, putting them upon the head of the [scape] goat" (Lev. 16:9,21,29-31). But it is evident that these sacrifices could not "make the comers thereunto perfect, for then would they not have ceased to be offered?" (Heb. 10:1,2).

Ah, but *we today* are not to indulge in introspection at all. In the knowledge that our sins, from cradle to coffin, have been accounted for, we may and should forget "those things which are behind" and "press

toward the mark [goal] for the prize"—the enjoyment of our high and holy calling in Christ (Phil. 3:13,14).

How this lends, or should lend, stature to our conduct! All here is based on *grace* and *gratitude*. There is no room for introspection or self-occupation. Hence the Apostle Paul says:

"I BESEECH you therefore, brethren, BY THE MERCIES OF GOD, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service" (Rom. 12:1).

"I therefore, the prisoner of the Lord, BESEECH YOU THAT YE WALK WORTHY OF THE VOCATION WHEREWITH YE ARE CALLED" (Eph. 4:1).

HOW IT AFFECTS OUR TESTIMONY

As we recognize the Mystery and God's plan for the present dispensation, we no longer have as our goal the establishment of Christ's kingdom on earth, in which repentance and water baptism had so large a place. We know this is being held in abeyance until the return of Christ. Much less do we preach the law, for *"now the righteousness of God without the law is manifested"* (Rom. 3:21).

Nor are we seeking to save the world. We know that the world has been given up to judgment, but that God has given a period of grace in which individual Jews and Gentiles may be reconciled to God in one Body by grace through faith, on the basis of the finished work of Christ.

Seeking, not to save the wreck, but to save souls in peril from the wreck, we carry out *our* "great commission" by beseeching men, in Christ's stead, to be reconciled to God, since God has made Christ to be sin for us, that we might be made the righteousness of God in Him (II Cor. 5:18-21).

HOW IT AFFECTS OUR FELLOWSHIP

The knowledge of the Mystery affects our fellowship as believers too, for it teaches that "by one Spirit are we *all baptized into ONE BODY"* (I Cor. 12:13), that denominational creeds notwithstanding, "*There is ONE BODY,...ONE LORD, ONE FAITH, ONE BAPTISM"* (Eph. 4:4,5).

Thus we have the freedom, yea, the *desire* to enjoy fellowship with *all* God's people. Our denominational brethren often wonder why we do not leave them alone, why we continue forever to call their attention to the teachings of the Mystery, with its "one Body" and "one baptism." The reason is that while they generally do not consider us one with them, we *do* consider them one with us as fellow members of the Body of Christ, the one true Church of the present dispensation.

We look forward to the day when, in God's grace, denominational walls will fall and we can all enjoy our oneness in Christ. Meantime we seek what fellowship we can find with those who love and trust our Lord in truth, whatever their denominational affiliations.

But there is indeed a more intimate fellowship among those who have come, or have begun to come, into a knowledge of the Mystery—a fellowship with which none on earth can compare.

How Paul labored and strove and prayed for the saints, "*that their hearts might be...knit together in love*" as they attained to "*the full assurance of understanding*" by "*the acknowledgment* [Gr. *epignosis*, full knowledge] *of the Mystery"* (Col. 2:1,2). And how this knowledge does indeed bind hearts together! No Bible writer has so much to say about fellowship and

the enjoyment of one another's company as Paul. Those who have come into this most blessed of all fellowships lose it only in the measure that they depart from the teachings of Paul and the glorious truths of the Mystery.

HOW IT AFFECTS OUR SUFFERING FOR CHRIST

Even our sufferings for Christ are sanctified by a knowledge of the Mystery, though to be sure, few of us here in America have really suffered much for the One who died for us. Perhaps if we were more faithful we would experience this privilege to a greater degree. At any rate we must remember the Spirit-inspired words of Paul:

"For unto you it is given in the behalf of Christ, not only to believe on Him, but also to suffer for His sake" (Phil. 1:29).

But what have our sufferings, great or small, to do with the Mystery revealed to Paul? Let us see. Paul wrote to the Colossian believers:

"[I] now rejoice in my sufferings for you, and fill up that which is behind [or, still remains] of the afflictions of Christ in my flesh for His Body's sake, which is the Church" (Col. 1:24).

Surely the apostle did not mean to imply here that the redemptive work of Christ had not been completed. This passage can only be explained by the Mystery—which indeed is the subject here (See Verses 25-27).

It was when the stage was all set, as it were, for the return of Christ to judge and reign, that the rejected Lord revealed to Paul the secret of His eternal purpose and grace. According to this purpose the

Lord would remain away for a time, in grace offering reconciliation to His enemies.

Thus He remains to this day a Royal Exile, still despised and blasphemed in every city. But who bears the sufferings of His continued rejection? *He* is now forever blessed. *His* sufferings are over. It is *we* who, like Paul, stand before the world *"in Christ's stead,"* bearing His reproach, yet offering men grace and peace through His finished work. *We* fill up that which still remains of His afflictions as the rejected Son of God.

Little wonder the apostle says it is *given* to us, as a *privilege,* to suffer for Him. It was, of course, also a privilege for the Messianic believers to suffer for their rejected King, and they counted it so (Acts 5:41), but ours is in a special sense *His* suffering and the spiritual believer in this dispensation of Grace will pray with Paul:

"That I may know Him, and the power of His resurrection, and the fellowship of His sufferings, being made conformable unto His death" (Phil. 3:10).

THE CAPSTONE OF DIVINE REVELATION

Now there is one more very precious truth connected with this great sacred secret of which we read *nothing* in the Old Testament Scriptures. And that is the blessed truth that the Lord Jesus Himself is coming to take the believers, the Body of Christ, those who have died and those who live, to heaven physically, bodily, to be with Himself.

THAT BLESSED HOPE

"Looking for that blessed hope, and the glorious appearing of the great God and our Saviour Jesus Christ" (Titus 2:13).

A RECOVERED TRUTH
Will It Be Lost Again?

A rich harvest of blessing was reaped for the Church in those years before and after the turn of the 20th century when the great truth of the Lord's coming *for us* was recovered by men of God, and the expectancy of His appearing became once more the "blessed hope" to multitudes of believers.

There was, however, one flaw in the argument for the imminent Rapture. Most of those who taught this truth failed to see clearly that, as part of the great revelation to Paul, it is exclusively the hope of the Body of Christ, the Church of *this present* dispensation.

Soon enough the old error of confusing other parts of Scripture with the Pauline revelation began to do its destructive work, with the result that today Premillenarians, in increasing numbers, are asking whether it is quite certain after all that we will be caught up to be with Christ before the prophesied Tribulation and the outpouring of God's wrath upon the world.

As the atom and hydrogen bombs were added to the long list of weapons of destruction with which the nations threatened each other, one Premillenarian leader after another began wondering: Will the Lord come for us before the Tribulation breaks?—and, not standing squarely on Pauline ground, one after another relinquished the "blessed hope" for the confusion that inevitably results from a failure to recognize the distinctive character of Paul's ministry and message.

Now some are pointing to such passages as Matthew 24:6-9 and 29,30 to prove that the Church *will*

go through the Tribulation. Did not our Lord, in the former passage, say to His own disciples that *after* "the beginning of sorrows, *then* shall they deliver *you* up to be afflicted," etc.? And did He not say in the latter, that *after* those signs in the heavens which *follow* the Great Tribulation, "*then*...they shall see the Son of Man coming in the clouds of heaven..."? And does this not, they ask, indicate that the Lord will come for His own *after* they have gone through the Tribulation? This view is called the "Post-Tribulation" view.

But others still recognize that Paul's teachings concerning the Rapture seem to indicate an *escape from* tribulation (I Thes. 4:16-5:11). On the premise, therefore, that the "*Great* Tribulation," the most fearful part of the Tribulation period (Matt. 24:21) covers only the last three and a half years of that period, these have adopted a "Mid-Tribulation" view, holding that the Church will go through only the first half of the Tribulation, and will be caught away before the fearful outpouring of God's wrath in the "*Great* Tribulation."

Still others hold the so-called "Partial Rapture" view, on the basis of our Lord's exhortation to His disciples:

"Watch ye therefore, and pray always, that ye may be accounted worthy to escape all these things" (Luke 21:36).

According to this view only those "counted worthy" will be caught up in the Rapture. This, it is felt, is further confirmed by a passage in the prophetic letter to the church at Philadelphia, where deliverance from the Tribulation appears to hinge upon faithfulness:

"Because thou hast kept the word of My patience, I also will keep thee from the hour of temptation [trial] which shall

come upon all the world, to try them that dwell upon the earth" (Rev. 3:10).

And thus the glorious prospect that Paul, by inspiration, holds out to the members of Christ's Body as "*that blessed hope,*" is again being lost to growing numbers of sincere believers, simply because they fail to recognize it as distinctly a *Pauline* revelation.

To those who remain blind to this important fact, such passages as Matthew 24 must qualify—if not contradict—I Thessalonians 4, and any attempt to harmonize the Gospel records as to Christ's return with Paul's special revelation as to it, must end in deep and profound confusion.

But we who *do* recognize the distinctive character of Paul's apostleship and revelation have no such problem to vex us. To us "*that blessed hope*" glows, or should glow, brighter as the days grow darker.

I'm waiting for Thee, Lord, Thy beauty to see, Lord,
I'm waiting for Thee—for Thy coming again.
Thou'rt gone over there, Lord, a place to prepare, Lord,
Thy glory I'll share at Thy coming again.

'Mid danger and fear, Lord, I'm oft weary here, Lord,
The day must be near of Thy coming again.
'Tis all sunshine there, Lord, no sighing nor care, Lord,
But glory so fair at Thy coming again.

E'en now let my ways, Lord, be bright with Thy praise, Lord,
For brief are the days ere Thy coming again.
I'm waiting for Thee, Lord, Thy beauty to see, Lord,
No triumph for me like Thy coming again.

—Hannah G. Burlingham

THE AGES TO COME

Now there is one more thing, though, that is connected with this great message of the Apostle Paul

that should be said. I can't take it in, but I can tell you what he says about it.

Ephesians 2:7 goes even farther into the future as Paul declares God's purpose in eternity:

"That in the ages to come He might show the exceeding riches of His grace in His kindness toward us through Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:7).

Now, this distinctive message of Paul's is not only different from the great Prophetic Program, but it is also infinitely more glorious. As the heavens are high above the earth, so high and exalted is this great truth over what we find in prophecy.

Oh, what a wonderful, what a blessed truth. And how kind and loving and gracious is our merciful and great God to His saints:

"To whom God would make known what is the riches of the glory of this Mystery among the Gentiles, which is Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Col. 1:27).

LABORING, STRIVING, AND WORKING

"Whom we preach, warning every man, and teaching every man in all wisdom; that we may present every man perfect [full grown, mature] in Christ Jesus.

***"Whereunto I also labour, striving according to His working, which worketh in me mightily"* (Col. 1:28,29).**

Whether or not Christians understand the great doctrine of "the Mystery," one thing is clear—the Mystery is the *"meat" by* which believers are *"established"* in "this present evil age."

"Now to Him that is of power to STABLISH you according to MY GOSPEL and THE PREACHING OF JESUS CHRIST ACCORDING TO THE REVELATION OF THE MYSTERY…" (Rom. 16:25).

"And I, brethren, when I came unto you, came not with excellency of speech or of wisdom, declaring unto you the testimony ["Mystery" R.V. Margin] of God. For I determined not to know anything among you save Jesus Christ, and Him crucified" (I Cor. 2:1,2).

"HOWBEIT WE SPEAK WISDOM AMONG THEM THAT ARE PERFECT [FULL GROWN], yet not the wisdom of this world…. But we speak the wisdom of God in a MYSTERY,…the hidden…which God ordained before the world unto our glory" (I Cor. 2:6,7).

"I have fed you with milk, and not with MEAT; for hitherto ye were not able to bear it, neither yet now are ye able" (I Cor. 3:2).

In Ephesians, which is so largely taken up with the Mystery, we read that God gave apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors and teachers—"For the perfecting [growth] of the saints…THAT WE HENCEFORTH BE NO MORE CHILDREN…" (Eph. 4:11-14).

In Colossians 1:27,28, speaking of "this Mystery among the Gentiles, which is *Christ* in you the hope of glory," he says, as noted above, "Whom we preach, warning every man and teaching every man in all wisdom THAT WE MAY PRESENT EVERY MAN PERFECT [FULL GROWN] IN CHRIST JESUS."

Note that the long hidden purpose of God, called the "Mystery," here in Colossians 1:27, centers wholly in Christ. **All** is Christ. Verse 27, "This Mystery among the Gentiles; which is CHRIST **in you**, the hope of glory." Verse 28, "WHOM WE PREACH…that we may present every man perfect IN CHRIST." It is no mere coincidence that the very epistles which deal with the Mystery are filled with such expressions as "in Christ," "in Him," "in Whom," "With Christ," "By Christ," "With Him," "By Him." **All** is Christ, and today you are either "Complete in Him" or completely outside of Him.

Any one who reads Colossians 1:27-2:3 with an open mind must agree with what Dr. H. A. Ironside once taught when he said concerning the Mystery: "How earnest was the apostle in seeking to lead Christians into the knowledge of this precious truth." (Studies in Colossians, pg. 59).

Just see the great apostle of grace "warning every man" and "teaching every man" that he "might present every man perfect in Christ Jesus." See him "labor," "striving" according to God's working in him. See "what great conflict" he has for the Colossians, and all that he might present "every man full grown in Christ Jesus" (1:28), and "that their hearts might be comforted, being knit together in love, and unto all riches of the full assurance of understanding, to the acknowledgment of the Mystery of God, and of the Father, and of Christ" (Col. 2:2).

Why are some Christians, even Christian leaders, so afraid of a conflict today? There are many who see the truth of the Mystery but do not preach it because it means conflict. They forget that we are called upon to be good soldiers of Jesus Christ and *sometimes* soldiers must fight. When the apostle speaks of conflict here, he does not mean conflict of mind, as though he had any doubt about the importance or truth of his message; he meant conflict with others. He had to battle with religion and tradition so that their hearts might be knit together, and we do well to remember that there are battles to be fought before the divided Church of today can enjoy "the unity of the Spirit" and "the unity of the faith."

Satan would keep us like the Corinthian babes; he would lull us to sleep, he would make us "dull of hearing" and "slow of heart to believe," "but we are not ignorant of his devices,"—at least we should not be.

We should realize that Satan will never allow the Church to take one step forward without a battle. So let us not seek to escape the conflict. From his prison in Rome, Paul wrote to the Philippians, "For unto you it is given in the behalf of Christ, not only to believe on Him, but also to SUFFER for His sake; HAVING THE SAME CONFLICT which ye saw in me, and now hear to be in me" (Phil. 1:29,30). Timid believers should also read carefully and prayerfully, Ephesians 6:18-20 and II Timothy 1:8-12.

In closing let us notice a significant phrase in this portion of Colossians: "*The full assurance of understanding.*"

It is *wonderful* to have the "full assurance of *faith*" (Heb. 10:22).

It is *more wonderful* to have the "full assurance of *hope*" (Heb. 6:11).

It is *most wonderful* to have the "full assurance of *understanding*" (Col. 2:2).

This goes with "the acknowledgment [Gr. *epignosis, full knowledge*] of the Mystery." When men are established in this truth they are no longer "children, tossed to and fro and carried about with every wind of doctrine." They have an intelligent understanding of "[God's] own purpose and grace which was given us in Christ Jesus before the world began." They have *the full assurance of faith*, which comes with spiritual maturity.

We quote again Colossians 2:2,3:

"That their hearts might be comforted, being knit together in love, and unto all riches of the full assurance of understanding, to the acknowledgment of the Mystery of God, and of the Father, and of Christ; in whom are hid all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge."

The Mystery among the Gentiles is—*Christ*. The Mystery of God is—*Christ*. It is not the world being blessed through Israel, Abraham's seed; but the world being blessed through *Christ*, though Israel had failed.

It is not the message of Acts 2:36-39 and Acts 3:18-26, but the message of Romans 11:25,32 and Ephesians 2:16.

Chapter 6 — Colossians 2:1-7

THE TREASURES OF WISDOM AND KNOWLEDGE

"For I would that ye knew what great conflict I have for you, and for them at Laodicea, and for as many as have not seen my face in the flesh.

"That their hearts might be comforted, being knit together in love, and unto all riches of the full assurance of understanding, to the acknowledgement of the Mystery of God, and of the Father, and of Christ;

"In whom are hid all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Col. 2:1-3).

SPIRITUAL UNDERSTANDING

"The Full Knowledge of the Mystery"

We continue now in the second chapter of Paul's epistle to the Colossians.

Chapter one shows the distinctiveness of Paul's great message over and above that which the twelve apostles had been sent to proclaim on the day of Pentecost.

In this chapter we shall see how the apostle suffered to make this blessed, glorious message known and to keep it pure and undiluted or unadulterated. We want you to see how eager Paul was that believers should have an intelligent understanding of this great message.

How often the apostle, to the Corinthians, and in his Ephesian letter, and elsewhere, begs us not to

continue as babes in Christ, but to grow up, to become not merely children of God, but men of God. Men whom God can use for His own glory and for the good of others.

PAUL'S CONFLICT FOR CHRIST

Is it strange then, that Paul was willing to bear such suffering for Christ and to go through such conflict—physical as well as mental conflict—to make this message known?

In Colossians Two, he says, "Oh, I wish you knew what great conflict I have for you, and for as many as have not seen my face in the flesh." But why does Paul say this? Why does he have such a conflict?

Some supposed that this striving that Paul speaks about was an inner conflict with himself. It was nothing of the kind. Paul was not an ill-adjusted person. He rejoiced in Christ and what God had done for him and had given to him and made of him in Christ. He was well-adjusted. This conflict was not with himself or in himself; this conflict was with those who rejected Christ and opposed the truth, and persecuted him for preaching it. While he for the sake of these Colossians, and that the truth of the gospel might continue with them, speaks of the "great conflict" he had for us all.

"That their hearts might be comforted [encouraged] being knit together in love."

Oh, wouldn't that be wonderful, to see all our Christian churches, all who profess the name of Christ and look to Him alone for salvation; wouldn't it be wonderful, wouldn't it be like a breath of fresh air to see them *encouraged* and "*knit together*" in love? That

would be wonderful, yet that is not enough. He says, I pray that ye "might be encouraged and knit together in love, and knit together unto"—this is the reason for it all, this is the purpose behind it all, this is the ultimate—

"That their hearts might be comforted, being knit together in love, and unto all [the] riches of the full assurance of understanding, to the [full knowledge] of the Mystery of God, and of the Father, and of Christ" (Col. 2:2).

The Apostle Paul is very eager that we should be built up in this truth, "the full knowledge of the Mystery" and "the full assurance of understanding." It is sad indeed that so many are satisfied with what warms their hearts and those passages that are comforting and encouraging, but the rest they'll perhaps give to Israel or take two aspirin tablets, as it were, and try to forget them.

Paul, on the other hand, declares that the "great conflict" that he had, and all that he endured and suffered, was in order that those whom he had not even seen might be encouraged; and that surely includes us.

THE FULL ASSURANCE OF FAITH

Three times in Paul's epistles we read of "full assurance." In Hebrews 10:22 he speaks of the "full assurance of faith." It is wonderful that when the poor sinner simply believes Christ, believes God's message, and trusts Christ as his Savior, God gives him that "full assurance of faith"; at least he may experience that assurance.

Many a simple believer who doesn't understand much yet, has nevertheless felt his need and his guilt

before God, and having trusted Christ is immediately saved and he knows it.

As the poor man, blind from his birth, to whom the Lord had given sight, was pressed by the Pharisees and scribes and chief priests to find fault with Christ, and to deny His Deity, said in effect: "I don't know all about this, but one thing I know, that whereas I was blind, now I can see" (John 9:1-41).

THE FULL ASSURANCE OF HOPE

In Hebrews 6:11, the apostle speaks of "the full assurance of hope." You might say, how can you be so sure of hope? Well, this hope is not the hope we sometimes speak of—a wish. It is the opposite of despair—bright hope. It is the glorious anticipation of wonderful things to come. That is the "hope" of the Bible. In fact, this same chapter in Hebrews says,

"Which hope we have as *an anchor* of the soul, both *sure* and *steadfast*, and which entereth into that within the veil" (Heb. 6:19).

This has to do with the experiential part of the Christian life. A man is saved by faith and then he experiences tests. First he wonders whether he's going to stand—but God helps him stand. Then he goes through more and more and God allows him to be tested again and again by adversity, by those perhaps who make fun of him or oppose him. Ah, but still he goes on and after a while he receives "full assurance." He knows God is not going to let him down. And he knows that having been saved by the finished, accomplished work of Christ on Calvary, he need not fear the future. He has the "full assurance of hope." Now that is wonderful! But there is something even more striking.

THE RICHES OF THE FULL ASSURANCE OF UNDERSTANDING

In my short experience—it isn't that short, I'm not a child anymore—but in my experience as a pastor, and in Bible classes, and with Christians in general through, perhaps, 50 years, I have noticed so often that the strongest Christians, and those to whom others continually go to for help are the ones who have the "full assurance of understanding."

They have studied their Bibles diligently with a view to understanding it, and with a view to rightly dividing it so that they can use it intelligently with others. As a result they have become rocks, fortresses of strength, to others. They have the "full assurance of understanding."

It is our desire that you may have this assurance also. I trust that every believer reading these pages will vow before God, this very moment, never to stop until he receives the "full assurance of understanding," with all the "riches" that accompanies it. The peace and joy and satisfaction and assurance and glory—it is wonderful, "all riches of the full assurance of understanding."

THE ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF THE MYSTERY

"…to the acknowledgment of the Mystery of God…" (Col. 2:2).

Then the apostle adds a little phrase here and qualifies it; it is not just understanding everything. He goes on—understanding this, the *full knowledge*, "the acknowledgment" as translated in the Authorized Version. Really it is the word *epignosis*, the full, the thorough "knowledge of the Mystery." Once more he emphasizes that special message committed to him:

"For this cause I Paul, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles, If ye have heard of the dispensation of the grace of God which is given me to you-ward: How that by revelation He made known unto me the Mystery" (Eph. 3:1-3).

This deals with the glorious all sufficiency of the finished work of Christ: what it has done for us; what it makes of us; how it reconciles us to God in one Body; and baptizes us into Christ and into each other, as it were. For "by one Spirit" has He "baptized" all believers into "one Body." And how it gives us a position in the heavenlies in Christ, there to be blessed with all spiritual blessings. Oh, the apostle exclaims, I pray that you might know this, the great Mystery of God—*Christ*,

"In whom are hid all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Col. 2:3).

STEDFAST FAITH IN CHRIST

"And this I say, lest any man should beguile you with enticing words.

"For though I be absent in the flesh, yet am I with you in the spirit, joying and beholding your order, and the stedfastness of your faith in Christ" (Col. 2:4,5).

Enticing Words

Now it was this great message for which the apostle had to bear such persecution and such sufferings for so long a time. Satan hates this message more than anything else in the whole wide world. If this message is confused, and adulterated, and diluted—watered down; he's pleased. But when it is preached in clarity and power, he is displeased, for again and again we read in Paul's epistles how it is that this shows and spells his utter defeat.

"And this I say, lest any man should beguile you with enticing words" (Col. 2:4).

It is very strange, and sad, that so many Christians can be so naïve, for the Scriptures speak of religious people who, "...by good words and fair speeches deceive the hearts of the simple" (Rom. 16:18). In II Corinthians 11:13 they read of "false apostles [prophets], deceitful workers, transforming themselves into the apostles of Christ." In Galatians 2:4, the apostle writes of "false brethren," *false brethren!* "unawares brought in, who came in privily [privately] to spy out our liberty which we have in Christ Jesus." In Ephesians 4:14, the apostle begs, "That we henceforth be no more [longer] children, tossed to and fro, and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the sleight of men, and cunning craftiness, whereby they lie in wait to deceive." Then again in Ephesians 5:6 he speaks of those who would "deceive you with vain words" and so on.

My resting Christian friend, my Christian friend who wants only peace, but doesn't want to be a good soldier of Jesus Christ, is it possible that human nature has really changed so much for the good since Paul's time? News reports over radio, in our newspapers and on TV certainly do not indicate it is so.

No, human nature has not changed for the better. Human nature is still fallen and *bad*, and needs to be regenerated. That's why men need to be saved by the finished work of our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ. And let us not be so naive as to think that just because a man stands in the pulpit, he must be preaching the truth. This may not be so either, and this is why God would have us be Bereans.

When Paul proclaimed the gospel at Berea, his hearers didn't even take this great apostle's word for granted, but they "searched the Scriptures daily, whether those things were so" (Acts 17:11). For this,

some of our modern clergy would have condemned them and charged them with insubordination. But God called them "*noble*"—the noble Bereans. They were the true spiritual aristocracy of their day. Broad enough to give any man an interested hearing and exacting enough to test every man's word by God's Word, no matter what his ecclesiastical rank.

"And this I say, lest any man should beguile you with enticing words. For though I be absent in the flesh, yet am I with you in the spirit, joying and beholding your order, and the stedfastness of your faith in Christ" (Col. 2:4,5).

This is not merely something emotional. Paul was glad to hear that these Colossians were growing in grace, and in the understanding of the Word of God, and in the knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. This, to him, spoke of order. They were taking the time to examine these things and study them, so that they could be intelligent Christians.

Rooted and Built Up in Christ

"As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in Him:

"Rooted and built up in Him, and stablished in the faith, as ye have been taught, abounding therein with thanksgiving" (Col. 2:6,7).

This is something we all ought to take very special heed to. "As ye have received Christ Jesus the Lord, so *walk* in Him." Now, it is very strange that many people who have seen that the only way of salvation is by grace, the grace of God, and through faith in what Christ has done for them; it's very strange that after they get saved so often they think they must do something. In Galatians, chapter 3 Paul begged them:

"Oh, foolish Galatians, who hath bewitched [charmed] you, that ye should not obey the truth, before whose eyes

Jesus Christ hath been evidently set forth, crucified among you" (Gal. 3:1).

Why is it, he says, that ye come to disobey the truth? He uses that same phrase in Galatians 5:7: "Ye did run well; who did hinder you that ye should not obey the truth?" So you see you can try to obey the Mosaic Law, and disobey the Word of God, because God says that:

"Christ has redeemed us from the curse of the Law, being made a curse for us" (Gal. 3:13).

Just think a minute, my Christian friend, who's now trying to keep saved by doing good. If, when you were a lost sinner, an alien enemy of God—if then, He showed you that the only way you could be saved was by His grace and through faith in what Christ did for you—if then He saved you without requiring of you a single work, a single religious rite; then isn't it most illogical to suppose now that you are His dear child, a member of His own family, indeed, a member of the Body of Christ. Isn't it illogical to think that He saved you by grace through faith alone, that now He requires certain works of you in order that you might keep saved? That would be illogical indeed.

"Are you so foolish? having begun in the Spirit, are ye now made perfect by the flesh?" (Gal. 3:3).

"Are you so foolish? having begun in the Spirit, are ye now made perfect by the flesh," that is by physical deeds and things that you do? You know, the sad thing was that as these Galatians went back under the Law, they lost the joy they had had. He says in Galatians the 4th chapter and the 15th Verse:

"Where is then the blessedness ye spake of? for I bear you record, that, if it had been possible, ye would have plucked out your own eyes, and have given them to me" (Gal. 4:15).

And now, where is all that joy? Oh, and it isn't only by the Law that Satan would rob us of the joy and the blessing of salvation. He'll find some other way. But remember this:

"[Christ] was delivered for our offences, and was raised again for our justification" (Rom. 4:25).

"Therefore being justified *by faith*, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ:

"By whom also we have access by faith *into this grace wherein we stand*, and rejoice in hope of the glory of God" (Rom. 5:1,2).

The simplest believer in the Lord Jesus Christ has a standing before God *in grace*. Let us not forget that. I wonder if you have ever noticed that in the Old Testament you scarcely find the word grace. We find that Noah and Moses found grace in the eyes of the Lord, but beyond that there is almost nothing. When you come to the so-called Gospel records, you find the word grace just a very few times, and only once, in the gospel according to John, is it used in a theological way. The other times it tells how Christ grew in grace and in favor with God and man, and grace is used in other ways, or with other ideas in mind. But when you come to the epistles of Paul, there it is used over 100 times, though in volume Paul's epistles are not even half as large as the four gospel records. But here we read of *grace, grace, grace,* again and again.

"Being justified freely by [God's] *grace* through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus" (Rom. 3:24).

Then in the fifth chapter, he says:

"Moreover the law entered, that the offense might abound. But where sin abounded, *grace* did much more abound" (Rom. 5:20).

And the apostle has a great deal to say about the wonderful grace of God in all his epistles. We could make a long list of Scriptures to show this: II Corinthians 8:9; II Corinthians 9:8; Ephesians 1:7.

And in Galatians, of course, the whole argument is that it is no longer by works of the Law that we are saved, it is now entirely and only by the grace of God. And all of Paul's epistles open, and nearly all of them close, with that wonderful, official declaration from God Himself: "*Grace be to you, and peace.*" Then when we come to the wonderful Ephesian epistle, oh, how wonderful indeed are our blessings in Christ, for he says:

"For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast" (Eph. 2:8,9).

And you can go on and on in that second and third chapter; how much we read about grace. In fact, in Ephesians 2:7 he shows how it is God's great purpose:

"That in the ages to come He might show the exceeding riches of His grace in His kindness toward us through Christ Jesus."

As Ye Have Received Christ

Now, that's why in this letter to the Colossians, he says, "As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in Him" (2:6). Let me ask you, my unsaved friend, How did you receive Christ the Lord? You had to receive Him by grace through faith alone, didn't you?

Now then you certainly know that you had to come to the end of yourself, you had to see that trying and struggling and doing so-called good works and going

through religious rites never saved you. No one who has ever done these things has been sure of salvation for the simple reason that he could never be sure he had done enough, or that he had done it correctly in a way that would please God. No, you had to come to the place where you just said, "Oh, all right Lord Jesus, I quit. I'm through, I know that I can't save myself, I know that I only fail again and again and I've constantly failed in the past. So I'm going to trust Thee, and trust Thee alone for salvation."

Now then, if that's how you were saved, that's how you must go on in the Christian life. *"As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in Him."*

"Rooted and built up *in Him*, and stablished in the faith, as ye have been taught, abounding therein with thanksgiving" (Col. 2:7).

Ah, he wants you to be *rooted*—that's when you were saved—"and built up *in Him*, and stablished in the faith."

It is such a pity to see so many, especially at certain times of the year, trying to afflict their souls and make themselves feel bad for the sins that they have committed. It doesn't help them to do better after that. No indeed!

You hear them talk about the death of Christ, and read in these religious books, "Oh, why was the crown of thorns pressed down upon His head! Oh, I did that! And why did He shed His blood! Oh, I did it! It was because of my sin!"

Now, my friend, that is true, but that is not the great glad message of salvation, the gospel of the grace of God that Paul would now have us emphasize.

Nobody told you it was your fault that Christ died, no. They said that Christ in love had died to pay for your sins. And Paul is first to say of the Lord Jesus Christ:

"Whom God hath set forth to be a propitiation through faith in His blood, to declare His righteousness for the remission of sins that are past, through the forbearance of God;

"To declare, I say, at this time, His righteousness: that He might be just, and the Justifier of him which believeth in Jesus" (Rom. 3:25,26).

The glad news is that Christ died for you because He loved you, and that is the way you must go on in the Christian life.

And when you fail, oh, just say, "I'm so grateful, I'm humbled to think that it has already been taken care of way back there at Calvary."

That, my dear friend, more than anything else in the wide world will encourage you to live for Him. Don't you know, Paul asserts, it is "the goodness of God [that] leadeth thee to repentance" (Rom. 2:4)?

Now take this to heart, my dear Christian friends, and "as you have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in Him."

Chapter 7 — Colossians 2:8-23

BEWARE OF EVIL WORKERS

"Beware lest any man spoil you through philosophy and vain deceit, after the tradition of men, after the rudiments of the world, and not after Christ" (Col. 2:8).

LET NO MAN SPOIL YOU

Now, with this in mind and with this as a background, the apostle enters his treatise to the Colossians in which he makes a three-fold appeal.

Verse 8: "Let no man spoil you."

Verse 16: "Let no man judge you."

Verse 18: "Let no man beguile you."

Let us start with Verse 8:

"Beware lest any man *spoil* you through philosophy and vain deceit, after the tradition of men, after the rudiments of the world, and not after Christ" (Col. 2:8).

This word *"spoil,"* of course, is a good English word, but it was used more than 350 years ago when our Authorized Version of the Bible was translated. Actually, we would sooner say "rob." Let no man *rob* you.

It is not the way Grandma spoils her little grandchild, but it has the idea of making spoil of. You know the phrase: "To the victor belongs the spoil."

Now let's examine this a little further: *"Beware lest any man rob [spoil] you through philosophy"* (Col. 2:8).

PHILOSOPHY AND VAIN DECEIT

You know what philosophy is. Philosophy is not science. Men may be looking for scientific facts in philosophizing, but philosophy is not science. It is the love of wisdom. It is the working of the human mind.

We might say, here are a young husband and wife and the doorbell rings and she goes to the door, and finds that the mailman has arrived. Amongst the letters is one that has a black strip around it, but no return address. The husband says, "Oh, I'll bet that's from your mother. I'll bet you Grandma has died and now your mother wants to come and live with us." The wife answers, "Oh, dear, don't talk that way. I don't think that's so at all because Grandma was very well the last time I was there. I think this is..." and she's got another idea. And they banter it back and forth until finally, the husband exclaims, "Well, open it, open it!" So she finally opens the letter and it is an advertisement from a mortuary.

They had been philosophizing—that wasn't science. That was philosophy. There is a great deal of philosophizing, which is nothing more than a working of men's minds. The mind that God Himself created, for which *He* is not given credit. If their mind works fairly well, they boast about it as though they had created it themselves, as though they had produced it.

Paul warns, "Beware lest any man *rob* you through philosophy"—don't go by what man thinks, go by what God says in His Word:

"Don't let any man rob you through *philosophy* and *vain deceit*."

There is such a thing as "*vain deceit*" even in the pulpit. Don't think that the pulpit is all perfect no

matter where you find it, by no means. Ah no, there is vain or shallow pride and deceit in many a case where the gospel is supposed to be preached. Thus Paul adds, "after the tradition of men."

THE TRADITION OF MEN

I read a little statement just a short while ago by a supposedly great theologian, about the Scofield Reference Bible, which happened to be rather contrary to the teaching of his denomination.

He wrote in this book review, "We must conclude that in view of the creed of our denomination, and the welfare of our church, or the peace of our church, that this Bible is a very dangerous one, this Scofield Reference Bible."

Actually, I would have no objection to what the man thinks about the Scofield Reference Bible. The point is that he was only looking to see whether it was in agreement with the creed of his denomination, and whether it would help to make peace in the denomination or perhaps would disturb the peace of his denomination. The sad fact is that many a theologian so-called, many a great man in the pulpit is thinking, not first of what the truth is, even though it may disturb his church or denomination. Rather he is thinking only of what his denomination or his church teaches and not beyond that because—don't rock the boat, don't let anything spoil the peace that we have now, even if it happens to be *truth* that is spoiling it.

Paul says, Don't let anybody rob you through philosophy or vain deceit, after the *tradition* of men, after the *rudiments* [the principles] of the world, and *not* after Christ.

"For in Him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily. And ye are complete in Him" (Col. 2:9,10).

Now that is very beautiful indeed. He says, don't let anybody rob you or take you away from Christ, whether it be by philosophy and vain deceit, or tradition and the principles of the world.

Thus if it isn't centered in Christ, if it isn't according to Christ, *be careful*; don't let any one spoil you, because all you are or have, my dear Christian friend, is in Him.

THE FULNESS OF THE GODHEAD

"For in Him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily.
"And ye are complete in Him, which is the Head of all principality and power" (Col. 2:9,10).

"For *in Him* dwelleth all the fullness of the Godhead *bodily*" (Col. 2:9).

Apart from Christ there is nothing in this world that is worth anything.

What do you want? Forgiveness of your sins? Justification? Peace with God? Peace of heart and mind? True joy? Assurance for the future? Heaven? A knowledge and understanding of the Word?

You cannot have any of it until you have received Christ for yourself, as your own personal Savior because everything that's worth anything is all in Him.

Now, Paul says in his Epistle to the Ephesians:

"That Christ may dwell in your hearts by faith; that ye, being rooted and grounded in love,
"May be able to comprehend with all the saints…
"And to know the love of Christ, which passeth knowledge, that ye *might be filled* with all the fulness of God" (Eph. 3:17-19).

I pray that "Christ will dwell in your heart by faith," as this verse says, "that ye *might be filled* with all the fulness of God" because the apostle says:

"For it pleased the Father that in Him [Christ] should all fulness dwell" (Col. 1:19).

And in this same Colossians epistle he says believers are "made full" (Col. 2:10) in Him. Don't let anyone rob you of this.

"For in [Christ] dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily."

And when you are saved, you must see that all you have and all you are, you have, and are, *in Him*. As the old hymn went:

All that I need He will always be,
All that I need til His face I see,
All that I need through eternity,
Jesus is all I need.

—Author unknown

He is the Fount of every blessing, the Source of all supply; don't let anybody rob you of Him, or anything that you have in Him rightfully.

COMPLETE IN CHRIST

"For in Him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily.
"And ye are complete in Him, which is the Head of all principality and power" (Col. 2:9,10).

The apostle declares that believers stand before God "in Christ" and in Christ God has pronounced you *"complete."* There is no such thing as being partly saved and partly lost. You and I, dear friends, are "complete in Christ" or we are completely *out* of Christ.

Now the word "complete" is quite adequate as a translation. But it is really two words in the original meaning, "made full." How beautifully it goes with Verse 9:

"For in Him dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily.
"And ye are [made full] in Him, which is the Head of all principality and power" (Col. 2:9,10).

But there are many religious people who say, "Oh, yes, but you can't just be saved by grace through faith alone"—although God says we can. And they say, "You must keep the Law." Or another says, "You must submit to this or that rite." The most popular one, of course, is water baptism. "You have to be baptized with water."

In Acts 13:38,39, do you remember Paul's words there in that synagogue in Antioch of Pisidia? He said:

"Be it known unto you therefore, men and brethren, that through this man is preached unto you the forgiveness of sins; And by Him all that believe are justified from all things, from which ye could not be justified by the law of Moses."

If any one comes to you with any such demands, you tell them, *"I am complete in Christ, God says so."* And furthermore in Ephesians 1:6 He has *accepted* us in Christ:

"To the praise of the glory of His grace, *wherein He hath made us accepted in the Beloved [One]:*
"In whom we have redemption through His blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of His grace" (Eph. 1:6,7).

God has accepted us in Christ, and Colossians 2:10 says:

"And ye are complete in Him, which is the Head of all principality and power" (Col. 2:10).

What more can I hope to have that I do not have in Christ? In myself I have "come short of the glory of God"; but in Him I am complete. This is why Paul thunders, Don't let anybody *rob* you.

Now actually, Colossians 2:10 is just the text of a sermon, for Paul goes on in Verses 11-13 to show the details, just how it is that we are *"complete"* in Christ. So, the Cross work of Christ naturally follows.

THE ALL-SUFFICIENCY OF CHRIST

"In whom also ye are circumcised with the circumcision made without hands, in putting off the body of the sins of the flesh by the circumcision of Christ:

"Buried with Him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with Him, through the faith [or the fidelity] of the operation of God, who hath raised Him from the dead.

"And you, being dead in your sins and the uncircumcision of your flesh, hath he quickened [or given life] together with Him [Christ], having forgiven you all trespasses" (Col. 2:11-13).

Circumcision and the Children of Israel

Now, physical circumcision was the sign which distinguished God's chosen nation from the wicked and licentious Gentiles among whom they lived. But the sad thing was that soon they began boasting in this, as though in itself it made them different from others—it didn't.

We read about Abraham, that it was only a sign, "a seal of the righteousness of the faith which he had" (Rom. 4:11). But his children, in too many cases began to boast in the rite itself, just as many boast in baptism today. We have so many baptized converts—as though baptism did anything at all for anyone.

The Rite of Circumcision is Abolished

The Apostle Paul declares that *in Christ* we have what circumcision was intended to signify. First, he says, we have been circumcised with Christ—the putting off of "the body of the sins of the flesh by the *circumcision* of Christ."

When Christ was "cut off" at Calvary "by wicked hands" (Acts 2:23) "the body of our sins" was "put off" by the *cutting off* of Christ. In other words, we have also been *put to death* in Christ, and that is why God finds no fault with the believer in Christ. It is true that we often fail, but in Christ we are perfect and God, by grace, sees us now *in Christ*. Oh, Paul says, "Don't let anybody rob you of this."

Circumcision or Baptism

But today they are telling us that we have to do things, especially that we must be baptized in water. Strange to say, that in all the confusion about baptism and circumcision, some have taken this "buried with Him in baptism" of Colossians 2:12 to be baptism by immersion. That is even crude. It is not Scriptural, and it is not even sensible.

This cannot be water baptism or otherwise baptism would be a saving ordinance, and the Apostle Paul makes it very clear that in this dispensation we are saved by grace through faith *without* works.

"Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to His mercy He saved us, by the washing of regeneration, and the renewing of the Holy Ghost" (Titus 3:5).

Can you tell me, were men ever buried in water? Only, if by accident, should they die at sea. Men aren't buried in water, and they weren't in Biblical times.

They were buried in the earth, or in the rocks, or sometimes even above the ground, but not in water.

Furthermore, every Fundamental Baptist believer, every Fundamental immersionist would agree that the moment I accept Christ as my Savior, I am crucified with Christ and I am raised to walk in newness of life. I am given new life; He that hath the Son of God hath life. Everyone, every Fundamental immersionist would agree to that.

Church Membership Rolls

Whatever individual churches may require for membership among them, there is only one thing that God requires. That you turn yourself over to the Lord Jesus Christ, that you trust Him as your Savior. The moment you have done that, you belong to God's Church.

THE OPERATION OF GOD

The Apostle Paul does not say here that water baptism takes the place of circumcision. Rather he says, you are *"complete in Christ,"* you are circumcised with Him, and now in Verse 12, you are "buried" and "raised" with Christ:

"Buried with Him in baptism, wherein also *ye are risen with Him* through the faith of the operation of God, who raised Him from the dead" (Col. 2:12).

Another thing that the Apostle does *not* say here that should be clearly understood. He does not say that we are "buried" and "raised" with Christ through the operation of the minister. By no means, rather his exact words are, "*THROUGH THE FAITH OF THE OPERATION OF GOD*, who hath *raised* Him from the dead."

There is a great danger which many yield to, of assuming that whenever Paul speaks of baptism he means water baptism. This is certainly very, very far from the truth. And here, certainly, he is not speaking of physical baptism any more than he was speaking of physical circumcision in Verse 11, for he says in Romans 6:6:

"Knowing this, that our old man is crucified with Him, that the body of sin might be destroyed, that henceforth we should not serve sin."

So, Colossians 2:12 reveals that you were crucified, or put to death, with Christ at Calvary, through "the faith of the operation of God," and thus we are "raised" with Him also.

FAITH IN CHRIST ALONE

Water baptism surely does not take the place of circumcision. The Scripture nowhere says this at all. There is not a single passage in the whole New Testament that says or implies that baptism takes the place of circumcision. There is not a single passage in the whole New Testament that states or implies that babies were baptized, and remember, at the determination of the parents babies were circumcised on the 8th day, according to the Law (Lev. 12:3; Luke 2:21,22). Water baptism, however, was performed only in response to personal repentance, and faith. Then, too, the rite of circumcision was for males only, while water baptism was for both male and female.

During the apostle's early ministry he practiced both circumcision and baptism, but it is clear that by the time he wrote his first epistle, he did not practice either of them (Gal. 5:2-4; 6:15; I Cor. 1:17,18).

It is clearly written in this passage of Colossians that circumcision and baptism are *both* accomplished for the believer *in Christ*. Remember Paul's great argument to the Galatians,

"For in Jesus Christ neither circumcision availeth any thing, nor uncircumcision; but faith which worketh by love" (Gal. 5:6).

Therefore, by their own argument, if baptism has taken the place of circumcision then baptism availeth nothing! It must be *Christ* alone.

How dishonoring then, to the finished work of Christ, must it be to substitute another rite for circumcision and say in effect, it's not circumcision but baptism!

And to this, Paul says, Oh, don't let anybody *rob* you; these rites are not after Christ. It must be Christ, and only Christ. Everything must center in Him. All you have, all you are, you have and are *in Christ*.

OUR BAPTISM INTO CHRIST

Paul goes farther within the preaching of the Cross to show how Christ, by an act of His own will, died not only for us, but as us. He *identified* Himself with mankind in yet another act—the Cross, in order that He might represent us by bearing the penalty for our sins and so setting us gloriously free.

Now then, the next great truth we must learn about the Mystery is that the believer, by an act of *his* will, is baptized into Christ, and is eternally, and inseparably, *identified* with Him in the death, burial, and resurrection of Christ. How and when does this take place?

"Buried with Him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with Him through the faith of the operation of God who hath raised Him from the dead" (Col. 2:12).

Or as I Corinthians 12:13 says, "For by one Spirit are we all baptized into one Body, whether we be Jews or Gentiles."

It is *by* the operation of God, but then we must learn that it is when we believe.

When I go to Calvary by faith, see Christ dying there on that Cross, and I say, How is this? Why is He dying? He had no death to die. "The wages of sin is death." "The soul that sinneth, it shall die." "Sin, when it is finished, bringeth forth death." But Christ did not sin. Why then is He dying?

The only conclusion for the death of Christ, the conclusion of faith must be, that He is dying *my* death—and He was. As He was baptized into humanity at His birth, so He was baptized into *our* death at Calvary. That is what He meant when He said to the apostles in Luke 12:50:

"But I have a baptism to be baptized with; and how am I straitened till it be accomplished."

He had already been baptized at Jordan, but He said, "I have a baptism to be baptized with, and how am I straitened [s-t-r-a-i-t, straitened] What a strait, what a spot I'm in until that is accomplished." Thank God He met death, He did accomplish it. He died our death, and that is why Romans 6:3 says,

"Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into His death."

That happened at Calvary. The Cross is the only meeting place between God and the sinner. It is only as we come to Calvary and see that it is *our* death

He is dying and acknowledge it and accept it as the gift, as the wonderful expression of His grace. It is then that we are made *one* with Christ, baptized *into* Christ, and baptized into the Body of Christ. Ah, what a wonderful truth is this great revelation of the Mystery!

SEATED WITH CHRIST

Since this is so, we must now also be seated with Christ "in the heavenlies" as Ephesians 2 very clearly says we are. Notice here the wonderful good news of the wonderful grace of our wonderful God. He says in Verses 2 and 3 that we were "the children of disobedience" and therefore "by nature the children of wrath, even as others":

"But God, who is rich in mercy, for His great love wherewith He loved us,

"Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us [given us life] together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved;)

"And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:4-6).

If I have become one with Christ at Calvary, it naturally follows that I am one with Him now. If "I have been crucified with Christ" as Paul says in Galatians 2:20, then I must also be "buried with him" as he says in Colossians 2:9-12; and therefore I have been "raised" with Him to "walk in newness of life" as he says in Romans 6:4.

And I have ascended with Him, beloved, and now God no longer sees us in our poor selves, for He sees us *in Christ*. The simplest, poorest of believers, He sees us no longer in our poor selves. It is already done, the transaction is finished, it is complete. He sees us in heaven, *in Christ*. We are seated with Him

in the heavenlies at God's right hand, the place of favor and privilege and honor and glory.

***"And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus"* (Eph. 2:6).**

It naturally follows too, that Christ's blessings and His joy and perfect peace, and His glory in heaven are ours. That's why we also read in Ephesians of that blessed doxology of Paul:

***"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ"* (Eph. 1:3).**

Ah, how glorious this is. He has promised us nothing for this earth. He has promised us no more than our needs. He has not promised to make us rich if we live for Him. Not at all, but He has promised us and given us *all spiritual blessings in the heavenlies*. And how these can lift us above this poor, sad, miserable world.

There is Paul, in that jail at Rome, but he writes to the Philippians, "I don't want you to mourn for me because these things have turned out to the furtherance of the gospel. Therefore, rejoice in the Lord, and again I say, rejoice."

In fact, it was from prison that he wrote in the Ephesian epistle about sitting—not in a dungeon, but "in the heavenlies" in Christ.

My dear Christian friend and my dear unsaved friend, God wants you to know the joy and peace and satisfaction and glory of our oneness with Christ.

It was not His death He died. It was my death and yours that He died at Calvary, and we become one with Him and are blessed with the blessings that are His in heaven.

"For *in Him* dwelleth all the fulness of the Godhead bodily.
"And ye are complete in Christ, which is the Head of all principality and power" (Col. 2:9,10).

OUR STANDING BEFORE GOD

As Christ took our place and died in our stead at Calvary, so we stand now before God in Christ, not in ourselves but in His beloved Son. And that's why he says, Don't let anybody rob you of enjoying and appreciating and appropriating this great fact of how the believer has a standing before God in Christ. God sees him now in Christ. And the apostle even goes into the details of the standing that believers have in Christ:

"In whom also ye are circumcised with the circumcision made without hands, in putting off the body of the sins of the flesh by the circumcision of Christ:
"Buried with Him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with Him through the faith of the operation of God, who hath raised Him from the dead.
"And you, being dead in your sins and the uncircumcision of your flesh, hath He quickened together with Him, having forgiven you all trespasses" (Col. 2:11-13).

So God sees you now no longer as a poor sinner on earth. He sees you in His Son. He looks upon you as He looks upon Christ, His beloved Son, at His right hand. How appropriate this message is today, when we are being told on every hand that we must do certain things or go through certain religious performances in order to be fully accepted of God.

THE GLORY OF THE CROSS

Now I want you to look at those two passages in which Paul does shed the light of the Cross on circumcision and baptism—Galatians 5:11 and Galatians 6:14:

"And I, brethren, if I yet preach circumcision, why do I yet suffer persecution? Then is *the offense of the Cross* ceased" (Gal. 5:11).

"But God forbid that I should glory [boast], save in *the Cross of our Lord Jesus Christ*, by whom the world is crucified unto me, and I unto the world" (Gal. 6:14).

Now as to water baptism, if water baptism is specifically for *our* obedience today, why was Paul *"not"* sent "to baptize"? *We* should be obedient but he was *not*! Even our Baptist friends must see the inconsistency here of the contentions of their so-called Great Commission. Everybody quotes I Corinthians 1:18, but how many quote the 17th verse too:

"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel: not with wisdom of words, lest *the Cross of Christ* should be made of none effect.

"For *the preaching of the Cross* is to them that perish foolishness, but unto us which are saved it is the power of God" (I Cor. 1:17,18).

Ah, my dear friend, if you have been confused and divided over this baptism question, I beg of you, be willing, at least, to look into it. Water baptism, like circumcision, has no more place in this dispensation of Grace than do the sacrifices.

Now, *Christ* alone is ever the touchstone. God does not say, There's a Baptist, there's a Methodist, there's a Presbyterian. God says, Have you trusted Christ as your Savior? If not, I beg of you, do it today.

THE TRIUMPH OF THE CROSS

"Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and took it out of the way, nailing it to His Cross;

"And having spoiled principalities and powers, He made a shew of them openly, triumphing over them in it.

"Let no man therefore judge you in meat, or in drink, or in respect of an holy day, or of the new moon, or of the Sabbath days:

"Which are a shadow of things to come, but the body is of Christ" (Col. 2:14-17).

The Finished Work of Christ

How grateful we should be for the opportunities God gives us to make known the wonderful, powerful gospel of the Grace of God. The same message that the Apostle Paul proclaimed all over the known world, so that men said, even of his companions, "*These that have turned the world upside down are come hither also*" (Acts 17:6). How we pray that this blessed message might "have free course, and be glorified" (II Thes. 3:1) in our generation and that many will accept it, and realize, appreciate, and experience its tremendous power and blessing.

Nailing the Law to His Cross

The Apostle Paul makes it clear that Christ died on Calvary's Cross to abolish for us all the demands of the Law, of legalism—essentially of course, the Law of Moses—but also anything that might demand of us certain things to make us acceptable with God. That is because when Christ died at Calvary, He "blotted out the handwriting of ordinances" that was against us, those things that God had once ordained that must be done for acceptance with Him. Things that God had said, This you must do if you are to be accepted by Me.

You remember when God told Cain and Abel to bring a blood sacrifice for acceptance with Him. Abel did and was accepted. Cain thought he knew a better way and was rejected. All down through the

Scriptures it was the obedience of faith that saved. When God required things, faith would do what God required, and come God's way.

"Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and took it out of the way, nailing it to His Cross" (Col. 2:14).

All these laws and all these demands would, of course, only condemn us. Even if we could do them, we could never be sure that we had done them in the right way or in the right spirit, or in the right frame of mind. So they would only condemn us.

But thank the Lord, His death blotted out "the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and [He] took it out of the way, nailing it to His Cross" (Col. 2:14).

LEAVING BAPTISM AND THE LORD'S SUPPER

Years ago a clergyman quoted Colossians 2:14 this way: "Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, leaving two—baptism and the Lord's Supper."

Now, you can see in a moment how contrary that is to what this verse and this passage teaches. First of all there is a great difference between water baptism and the Lord's Supper.

The Lord's Supper

The Lord's Supper is not an ordinance, it never was. Neither God nor Christ ever commanded that men should observe the Lord's Supper for acceptance with God. Never!

On the contrary, it is a blessed memorial of what Christ has done for us, of sins forgiven, and redemption through His shed blood on Calvary. That is

why the Apostle Paul delivered to us Gentiles in the flesh, this blessed celebration of the *finished* work of Christ:

"For as often as ye eat this bread, and drink this cup, ye do show the Lord's death till He come" (I Cor. 11:26).

We rightfully gather in communion at the Lord's table and continue to do so *until* our Lord comes for us.

Water Baptism

But water baptism stands in a very different category. Water baptism has nothing to do with the finished work of Christ. It has rather to do with an *unfinished* work. It *was* an ordinance. This was something that God *required* for the remission of sins as Mark 1:4; 16:16; and Acts 2:38 clearly teach.

So there is a vast difference between the Lord's Supper and water baptism. The same apostle who delivered the celebration of the Lord's death is the same apostle who also declares:

"For Christ sent me not to baptize, but to preach the gospel: not with wisdom of words, lest the Cross of Christ should be made of none effect.

"For the preaching of the Cross is to them that perish foolishness; but unto us which are saved it is the power of God" (I Cor. 1:17,18).

TWO IMPORTANT QUESTIONS

Oh, but you say, Just a minute Mr. Stam. Baptism was practiced after the Cross and we read here in Colossians 2:14 that these ordinances were done away by the Cross. Now that is very true. All these things ordained for acceptance with God, including water baptism, were done away by the Cross, but we

must always ask two questions about these great dispensational matters. We must ask *how* and *when*. Now we know, for example, that the Law was done away *by* the Cross. It was done away, as we read here in Colossians 2, by Christ's "*nailing it to His Cross.*" But, *when* was this revealed? When was this made known? Ah, not for some time after the Cross.

Peter at Pentecost did not say that the Law had been put away. He did not even tell the people that Christ died for their sins. His exact words were: "...Ye have taken [Christ], and by wicked hands have crucified and slain [Him]" (Acts 2:23; 3:14,15). Peter declared that Christ had died on account of their sins. And when they said, "What shall we do?" he replied, "Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins" (Acts 2:38).

He surely did not understand the finished, glorious, all-sufficient work of Christ or he would, and should, have proclaimed it. No, it is not until Paul, the chief of sinners, saved by grace, is raised up of God, that anyone ever said:

"But now the righteousness of God *without the law* is manifested, being witnessed by the law and the prophets" (Rom. 3:21).

Not until Paul do we read:

"For sin shall not have dominion over you: for ye are not under the law, but under grace" (Rom. 6:14).

So the Law was done away by the Cross indeed, but this was not revealed immediately, so that historically it was not done away until the Apostle Paul was raised up to proclaim "the gospel of the grace of God" and to usher in "the dispensation of the grace of God."

This explains why those Jewish believers at Jerusalem still practiced the Law. In fact, as late as Acts 21, we read that *they* were "all *zealous* of the Law." While Paul, the Apostle of the Gentiles, was already beginning to tell the Gentiles, and was even making known to them, that Christ had abolished the Law at Calvary.

Of course, we know that the Law itself was never done away, but the Law as a Covenant,[1] the Mosaic Covenant, that Covenant of the Law, was done away at Calvary.

ANOTHER IMPORTANT QUESTION

Now, we can ask in the same way, when did the dispensation of the grace of God begin?

We sing, "Grace flows from Calvary." And that is true indeed. We are the recipients of the boundless, matchless grace of God because Christ died to pay for our sins on Calvary's Cross. But I say again, was this immediately proclaimed? Did men know it?

No, indeed! A dispensation begins with a revelation, and so the dispensation of the grace of God begins with the revelation of the grace of God through the Apostle Paul. It is *Paul* and no one until *Paul*, who says:

"But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might finish my course with joy, *and the ministry, WHICH I HAVE RECEIVED OF THE LORD JESUS, to testify the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24).

In Ephesians 3:1-3, he declares:

"For this cause I Paul, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles,

"IF YE HAVE HEARD OF THE DISPENSATION OF THE GRACE OF GOD WHICH IS GIVEN ME TO YOU-WARD:

"How that by revelation He made known unto me the Mystery."

So God, after the world had been given up to judgment, revealed this wondrous sacred secret to the Apostle Paul. This glorious, all-sufficient work of the Lord Jesus Christ and all that it includes for us: the reconciling of believing Jews and Gentiles in one Body; our position in the heavenlies at God's right hand in Christ; our baptism into Christ; the imputation of God's righteousness to us; and all spiritual blessings in the heavenlies.

THE BODY OF CHRIST

Now then, we might ask the same question about our reconciliation into one Body. Ephesians 2:16 says that we are "reconciled…in one Body"—how? "By the Cross." So the Body of Christ was brought into being by the Cross—that's *how*. But again we must ask *when*.

The Body of Christ surely did *not* begin at Pentecost. That was no joint Body there, for it was a Jewish program (Acts 2:5). Pentecost had always been 50 days after Passover (Lev. 23:5,16) but that particular Day of Pentecost was a special fulfillment of prophecy to the nation Israel (Acts 2:1-4). Every bit of it was foretold in the Old Testament prophecies by the Old Testament prophets (Joel 2:28-31; Acts 2:17-21; 3:18-25). But the Body of Christ is something that had never been predicted by the prophets. The formation of the Body of Christ from sinners and enemies, who are baptized into Christ and so become one with each other, was brought into being *by the Cross*, but *not* at that time.[2]

"PRINCIPALITIES AND POWERS DEFEATED BY HIS CROSS"

"Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and took it out of the way, nailing it to His Cross.

"And having spoiled *principalities* and *powers*, He made a show of them openly, *TRIUMPHING OVER THEM IN [THE CROSS]"* (Col. 2:14,15).

Now Christ, by the Cross, not only put away the Law which was against us, but He also overcame the principalities and powers in the heavenlies—Satan and all his hosts, who were against us—triumphing over them in the Cross.

CHRIST IS THE VICTOR

This is particularly Pauline. The Apostle Paul *never* shows Christ as the Victim while Peter, at Pentecost, did show Christ as the Victim.[3]

Paul always shows Him as the *Victor*, not merely over death, or after death, but the Victor *in death*. His Cross is shown as a great victory, a victory by which He put away all the claims of the Law that was against us, and He overcame all the principalities and powers who were against us. We have it again in Hebrews 2:14,15:

"Forasmuch then as the children [of Adam] are partakers of flesh and blood, He also Himself likewise took part of the same; that through death He might destroy him that had the power of death, that is, the devil;

"And deliver them who through fear of death were all their lifetime subject to bondage."

We think of death as the limit of man's weakness. Not so with the Lord Jesus Christ. In one way it was, physically only. But morally and spiritually and in

every other way it is the great victory of Christ over all His enemies. Never in Paul's writings do you find Christ being offered in sacrifice as the Victim, He is always portrayed as the Victor.

Christ meets death and grapples with it and overcomes it, and finally pushes death back through death itself, and comes forth to say:

"[I] have the keys of hell [hades] and of death" (Rev. 1:18).

In Hebrews 1:3, we read, "…when He had by Himself purged our sins, [*He*] sat down on the right hand of the Majesty on high."

They are not doing anything to Him here; *He* is doing something. And when He has completed it, He sits down because the work is done:

"And every [Old Testament] priest standeth daily ministering and offering oftentimes the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins:
***"BUT THIS MAN, AFTER HE HAD OFFERED ONE SACRIFICE FOR SINS FOR EVER, SAT DOWN ON THE RIGHT HAND OF GOD"* (Heb. 10:11,12).**

"For by one offering He hath perfected for ever them that are sanctified" (10:14).

How beautiful this is. Once again, they're not doing anything to Him here. He's doing something. He is offering the sacrifice, Himself to be sure; the *greatest* Being offering the *greatest* Sacrifice with the *greatest* results. Oh, thank God for that one glorious all-sufficient sacrifice of Christ at Calvary.

THE DEVIL IS A DEFEATED FOE

"And having spoiled *principalities* and *powers*, He made a show of them openly, *TRIUMPHING OVER THEM IN IT [THE CROSS]"* (Col. 2:15).

When the devil would discourage us and make us think that we are lost after we've trusted Christ as our blessed Savior, we need only to point to Calvary where Christ nailed the Law to His Cross, taking away all its power to condemn us, and set us free.

We were condemned. All of us would be condemned by the holy Law of God, for we have all broken it. Ah, but Christ died like the criminal. Christ died for the broken Law—though He had never broken it Himself. He died for you and for me. Oh, thank God, He overcame our adversary and all his hosts, so that you, my dear friend, may be saved by simple faith alone in His Word.

At Calvary "that *old* serpent" was defeated, and this is why, in II Corinthians 4:4, Paul calls his great message *the gospel of the glory of Christ*, because Satan is a defeated foe.

"LET NO MAN JUDGE YOU"

"Let no man therefore judge you in meat, or in drink, or in respect of an holyday, or of the new moon, or of the Sabbath days" (Col. 2:16).

These physical rites do not save, and they do not keep you saved. Don't let anyone tell you that you must do this or you may not do that to be accepted with God. Don't let anyone *rob* you, don't let anyone *judge* you, because, he says, *"ye are complete in [Christ]"* by faith alone. Don't let anyone tell you that you have to be baptized or you have to be this or that. While those physical things once were required for salvation, they were only "*shadows*" while "the substance," the reality, is Christ (Ver. 17). You have a standing before God *in Christ* and now you can live for Him out of sheer gratitude.

MARTIN LUTHER ON COLOSSIANS 2:14-16

The story is told of the time when it seemed to Martin Luther that Satan himself was attacking him, and Satan said to him, You are a great, great sinner, Martin Luther. Luther responded with I Timothy 1:15, Yes, but "Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners." Oh, the devil would undo us, but he can't undo us, because he is a defeated foe.

If we have trusted in the Lord Jesus Christ as our Savior, he has nothing against us, and he can have nothing against us, for Christ paid for all our sins. The accuser of the brethren, as we read in Revelation, will someday be cast down and cast out of heaven (Rev. 12:9,10; 20:10).

Christ has blotted out all these requirements, these decrees, these things that were once required for acceptance with God; not only the Mosaic Law, but every ordinance including water baptism.

"Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and took it out of the way, nailing it to His Cross;

"And having spoiled principalities and powers, He made a shew of them openly, triumphing over them in it" (Col. 2:14,15).

"Therefore," he says, "let no man judge you."

"LET NO MAN BEGUILE YOU"

Satanic Devices

Finally we come to the last of Paul's three-fold appeal found in the Second Chapter of Colossians.

Verse 8: "Let no man rob you."

Verse 16: "Let no man judge you."

Verse 18: "Let no man beguile you."

And now, in Verse 18, he goes on still farther, with the exhortation:

"LET NO MAN BEGUILE YOU OF YOUR *REWARD*...."

God has been so gracious to us. This word "reward" has sometimes been translated *prize*. That thing which should be so dear to you; all you have and all you are in Christ; that heavenly position; that position in glory and honor and power and favor at God's right hand, of this Paul says:

"Let no man beguile you of your reward in a voluntary humility and worshipping of angels, intruding into those things which he hath not seen, vainly puffed up by his fleshly mind,

"And not holding the Head, from which all the Body by joints and bands having nourishment ministered, and knit together, increaseth with the increase of God" (Col. 2:18,19).

Now here he condemns mysticism. Notice this phrase, "voluntary humility." This is a humility that God *has not* asked for, it was not commanded by God, so it is *not* humility.

A good illustration is found at Galatia. The Galatians, remember, also practiced a voluntary humility. They could have said to Paul, Well, why are you rebuking us so? We're doing more than God asks. All we want to do is go back under the Law, we want to obey the Law. There couldn't be anything wrong with that. Ah, yet he says in Galatians 3:1:

"O foolish [silly] Galatians, who has bewitched [charmed] you, that ye should not obey the truth, before whose eyes Jesus Christ hath been evidently [so plainly] set forth, crucified among you."

And in Galatians 5:7:

"Ye did run well; who did hinder you that ye should not obey the truth?"

So in trying to obey these rites and ceremonies of Moses' Law, they were *disobeying* the truth, because God had raised up Paul to say:

"But now the righteousness of God without the Law is manifested, being witnessed by the law and the prophets" (Rom. 3:21).

And in Romans 4:5:

"But to him that worketh not, but believeth on Him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness" (Rom. 4:5).

It is very interesting that in Colossians 2:8, we find those words "philosophy and vain deceit." Don't let anybody rob you by philosophy and vain deceit. Here in Verse 18, is the parallel—"puffed up by his fleshly mind." *"Puffed up," "fleshly mind,"* do you get it? *"Philosophy,"* and *"vain deceit."*

They had disobeyed the truth. Not by legalism in this case, but they thought they'd be a little more religious, these Gnostics. They had gone somewhat into the doctrine of the angels and had added a lot that the Scriptures say nothing about and that God had not revealed. They began "*intruding* into those things which they had not seen, *vainly puffed* up by their *fleshly minds*," with the result that they began *worshipping angels*.

"Worshipping of Angels"

That is not strange because men are worshipping saints and angels today. God has never said one word in the Bible, never in any single case in the Word of God do we find any warrant for worshipping any but God—God the Father, God the Son, and God the Holy Spirit.

And we are not to bow down to them, nor worship them, nor pray to them, whether they be men that have gone on before, saints or angels.

We are told to worship *only* God.

Do you remember how the devil wanted Christ to worship him? Now remember Satan was the highest archangel, he is still "the prince of the power of the air" (Eph. 2:2). And remember that "Michael the archangel...durst not bring against him a railing accusation, but said, The Lord rebuke thee" (Jude 9), simply because Satan is the *prince* of the power of the air. Do you remember how in the temptations when he tried to get Christ to bow down to him, the Lord quoted from the book of Deuteronomy, and said, "it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and Him only shalt thou serve" (Luke 4:8).

Now, some Christians in Colosse, at least professing Christians, were being carried away with this terrible heresy, and in doing this they were "not holding the Head" or holding fast to the Head. They claimed to be members of the Body, but *they* wanted to be the Head. They wanted to find out these things for themselves. They wanted to depend on what they *think* instead of what God says, on *human reasoning* instead of *divine revelation*. And in this, they are *not holding to the Head*.

Ah, any believer in the Lord Jesus Christ knows, or should know, that he is a member of the Body of Christ, that the Lord Jesus Christ is *the Head*, not the king, but the *Head* of the Church which is His Body. Just as the body naturally and normally obeys the head, so should we naturally obey Him, and so will we, if we are normal Christians, led by Him and by His Holy Spirit.

THIS WORLD SYSTEM

"Wherefore if ye be dead with Christ from the rudiments [elements] of the world, why, as though living in the world, are ye subject to ordinances?" (Col. 2:20).

Isn't it a strange thing, beloved, that the Church has made so much of ordinances when God through the Apostle Paul again and again tells us that they have been abolished, have been done away, and that we should not be subject to them?

If you are dead with Christ, if you have died with Christ from these physical, earthly things, God sees you in Christ. If you are dead from these physical things, you are not offering sacrifices anymore, not going through these oblations and you know you have your position in Christ because you died with Him and rose again: "Why," as though belonging to this world system, "are you subject to ordinances?"

The Galatians desired to be under the Law of Moses. Well, there are many professing Christians who still desire to be under the Law. You tell them they're not under the Law and they think you're the most terrible heretic, no matter if you can show them a dozen clear passages from Paul's epistles that make this plain. They still want to be under the Law. And there are others who realize that we are no longer under Moses' Law, that even the moral Law is not any covenant that can condemn us. But they make laws of their own, laws of their own fabrication. Some of the various churches have certain rites, which they make necessary for acceptance with God. Or, next to that, they say, Oh, you shouldn't do that at this time. And the apostle goes on here:

"Why, as though living in the world, are ye subject to ordinances,

"(Touch not; taste not; handle not;
"Which all are to perish with the using;) after the commandments and doctrines of men?" (Col. 2:20-22).

Why do you make yourselves subject to these physical things, these laws that can't do you any good, which all are to perish with the using? It's something like the Galatians again, and Paul had to say, "I'm afraid of you, lest I have bestowed on you labor in vain." "You observe days, and times and seasons." Why do you do that?

Now, in this very way, many have put themselves under laws of their own making, because they seem to think it will do them some good. It doesn't do them any good, it doesn't really make their lives any different, this "touch not, taste not, handle not." On certain days ye can't eat certain things, on certain days ye must eat certain things, and there are certain seasons of the year when ye must abstain from the things that you might enjoy most.

Tell me this; I want to ask a very simple question along this line. If a piece of candy is good for me, what is the difference whether I eat it at one season of the year or another? Why should it be more displeasing to God to eat it at one time than at another? And if, we'll say, a cigarette is bad for me, why is it better to smoke a cigarette at one time than it is at another? Why must I deprive myself of certain things just because it happens to be a certain day of the week, or a certain season of the year?

Ah, the apostle says, "Why," if you have died with Christ and have been buried to all that old existence, and now you have a new life in Christ at God's right hand,

"Wherefore if ye be dead with Christ from the rudiments of the world, why, as though [belonging to this world system] are ye subject to ordinances, (Touch not; taste not; handle not; which all are to perish with the using;) after the commandments and doctrines of men? Which things have indeed a shew of wisdom in will worship, and humility, and neglecting of the body; not in any honour to the satisfying the flesh" (Col. 2:20-23).

Evidently that 23rd verse was not easy to translate in our English King James Version of the Bible. But the idea is something like this: "These rules, they have an appearance of wisdom, but they really do not satisfy in overcoming the flesh."

People think, Well, you are certainly going to do better to put yourself under the law, if you legislate yourself a little bit, than if you don't. I don't know whether that is so clear though. I don't know whether that is agreed. We've tried, and tried again, to legislate certain things in this country of ours, and it hasn't worked, not at all.

These rules, he says, have an appearance of wisdom. They are self-imposed worship and affected humility and severity to the body, that is all done again and again in religious practice even today. There is certainly self-imposed worship in many a so-called Christian's life—even in many a true Christian's life. He thinks he's following a form: Now I've got to pray so many times a day; I've got to pray such hours a day; and so on. And his life is not very natural or very real. He knows he should pray the first thing when he gets up in the morning and before he goes to bed at night so he gets down on his knees even though he may not just feel in the particular mood to pray. He may not just feel burdened about anything—but it's time to pray. So, he prays.

True, there's something to be said for regularity, but often this becomes a law, and self-imposed worship. Then when the man feels like praying, well, he doesn't feel very free to because it's not the time to pray, you see.

Paul says that these rules do have the appearance of wisdom. There is self-imposed worship and a sort of an affected humility and severity to the body, but, as Weymouth puts it, "Not one of them is of any value in combating the indulgence of the flesh, or of our lower nature." There's not one of them that has any ability to overcome the flesh.

THE VICTORIOUS CHRISTIAN LIFE

How then do we overcome the flesh? How do we Christians live, how can we live an overcoming victorious life? There is only one way. I know of nothing that will cause the Christian to live for God and to live for the Lord Jesus Christ, like an appreciation of what He has done for us and what we are *in Him*. The fact that God has taken me, a poor, undeserving sinner, and given me a position in Christ at His own right hand, because Christ came to Calvary's Cross and took my place. The fact that now God sees me in Christ and says, You are no longer a child, and I'm not putting you under the Law; you are my full-grown son in Christ.

"For God hath not given us the spirit of fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound mind" (II Tim. 1:7).

"For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear; but ye have received the Spirit of adoption,[4] whereby we cry, Abba, Father" (Rom. 8:15).

God declares that we are His full-grown sons with all the rights and privileges of sonship. And God wants us to see that we are His full-grown sons in Christ.

Don't let anyone *rob* you, he says. You are complete in Christ.

Don't let anyone *judge* you and tell you what you have to do in order to please God and serve Him aright. The apostle says, these religious, physical matters of food and drink and holy days and new moons and Sabbath days were shadows, but the substance is Christ.

And don't let anyone *beguile* you of these wonderful truths and our position before God in Christ.

Instead thank God that these requirements have now been blotted out. They were blotted out *by the Cross*, and this great message of grace was made known some years later, when God saved the chief of sinners and sent him forth with what is properly called "the preaching of the Cross" and "the gospel of the grace of God."

Chapter 8 — Colossians 3:1-17

"RISEN WITH CHRIST"

"If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth on the right hand of God.

"Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth.

"For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God.

"When Christ, who is our life, shall appear, then shall ye also appear with Him in glory" (Col. 3:1-4).

Now the first thing we want to notice here is that every believer has been raised from spiritual death with Christ. And more than that, even the physical enters into it. We were "dead in trespasses and sins" spiritually (Eph. 2:1), and "death worketh in us" physically (II Cor. 4:12), says the Apostle Paul.

But thank God, every believer has been raised to "newness of life" with the Lord Jesus Christ. Now this is not something theoretical or ethereal or mystical or unreal, *indeed not*. It is something *very* real, and every believer should understand this.

Let me ask you a few simple questions to demonstrate this fact: Was Christ's death real? Of course it was. As we see Him portrayed for us in Scripture; tried like a criminal, crowned with thorns, beaten with rods, and then scourged, and smitten over the head. They pulled His hair and His beard. They spat in His face. They made Him carry His Cross till He fell beneath it, and then they did what you would not do to your dog—they nailed Him, hands and feet to that Cross.

Now, that certainly was very real. He bore real stripes from real scorpions, real whips. He bore real pain as they pressed that crown of thorns down upon His head. He bore shame and disgrace as they spat in His face and laughed at Him and mocked Him and said, "He saved others; Himself He cannot save" (Matt. 27:42). I say, He bore real shame and disgrace.

Oh, indeed His death was real. But let me ask this question again. Was it His death He was dying? Well you say, of course; what kind of a question is that? Oh no, wait a minute, "the wages of sin is death," says the Bible. "Sin, when it is finished, bringeth forth death" (Rom. 6:23; Jas. 1:15). God said to our first parents "in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die [or dying, thou shalt die]" (Gen. 2:17). Paul says about this:

"Wherefore, as by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin; and so death passed upon all men, for that all have sinned" (Rom. 5:12).

The prophet Ezekiel stated this truth in unmistakable terms with regards to Israel's repentance. "The soul that sinneth, it shall die" (Eze. 18:4,20). And there are many Scriptures along that line. Death is the direct result of sin. Was Christ then a sinner? Ah, no, the Scriptures unite with one voice to say "*NO.*" He is the *spotless* Lamb of God (John 15:25; 19:4,6; Rom. 1:4; 8:3; I Cor. 6:11; Col. 1:22; Heb. 4:15; 7:26; 9:14; I Pet. 1:19). He is the only One who can truthfully say, "*Which of you convinceth Me of sin?*" (John 8:46). Even secular history joins the Bible to state that He was at least a good, the very best, of men. Oh no, He did not sin. Well, then, why did He die, if death is the result of sin? Ah, it was *not* His death He was dying. It was *your* death and *mine*.

Christ was baptized into the human race, my friend. He became one with us, yes one of us. "He took upon Him the form of man." Then He went a step farther and in His baptism in water He was numbered with the transgressors, for this was the baptism of repentance for the remission of sins. But He had no sins. Ah, He came there as you and me, to be "numbered with the transgressors" (Mark 15:28). And that was not enough. He had to go still farther, for in Luke 12:50, He said to His apostles:

"But I have a baptism to be baptized with; and how am I straitened [what a strait I'm in, what a spot I'm in] till it be accomplished."

He referred, of course, to His baptism into our death. There is where He became most fully, there is where He became completely one with us sinners, when He even died *our* death. Now, that doesn't save us. The fact that Christ died our death alone is not enough to save a man. As He, by an act of His own will, went to Calvary's Cross and died our death, so we, by an act of our own will, by an act of faith, must stand at Calvary, as it were, and acknowledge, "This is not His death, this is my death." And we must *will* it so. We must wish it so. We must be willing to accept the fact that there at Calvary *He* died *our* death. We must come down from our pride, we must come down from our self-conceit and acknowledge that we were the ones who deserved to be there. And thank God we were there, *in Christ*, as Paul says in Romans 6:3:

"Know ye not, that so many of us as were *baptized* into Jesus Christ were *baptized* into His death."

How is a man baptized *into* Christ? How does he become one with Christ, a member of His Body? How? By acknowledging Christ's death to be his death. It

is not until he is baptized into the death of Christ and says, "Yes, this is my death that He is dying, and not His." Not until, by an act of faith, he acknowledges that death to be rightfully *his*, that he is then baptized into Christ. The blessed Cross, beloved, is always the meeting place. And so now the believer can say with the Apostle Paul:

"I am [have been] crucified with Christ:" But he goes farther, "nevertheless I live;" What does he mean? "nevertheless I live"? Ah, if we are baptized into Christ at Calvary when we accept His death as ours, then we are one with Him. Don't you know, as many of us as were baptized into Christ were baptized into His death? And being baptized into His death, we are made one with Him. And we are made one with Him, therefore, in His burial and in His resurrection. Many fail to understand this. They think that after they've been crucified with Christ *by faith*, and raised with Him to walk in newness of life *by faith*, at that same moment, they think that then they must get the minister to bury them with Christ in baptism. They think Colossians Two refers to water baptism. There is not one drop of water in this baptism. This is the same baptism by which the Holy Spirit puts us into, or fuses us into, Christ and His Body.

Now I say, this is a spiritual matter, but it is no less real. It is a real fact. As Ephesians Two so beautifully puts it, in the background of our being "the children of disobedience" and therefore "by nature the children of wrath" we read:

"*But God*, who is rich in mercy, for His great love wherewith He loved us,

"Even when we were dead in sins, hath quickened us [given us life] together with Christ, (by grace ye are saved;)

"And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus" (Eph. 2:4-6).

And if our death in Christ is real, so is our *burial*, and *resurrection*, and *ascension* in Christ. God sees us now *in Christ*, and surely *He* is not merely drawing some likeness and certainly *He* is making no mistake. The simplest believer has been crucified, buried, and raised with Christ.

But why then the "*if*" in Colossians 3:1? "*If* ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above." There are some who feel that this is a mistake, and they have "improved" the translation. They've "*improved*" this and they say this means, "Since ye have been risen with Christ, seek those things which are above." Oh, indeed not, that is not correct.

Remember he writes this by way of challenge. And this is not the only place where God's Word challenges us. There are many places as in the chapter we just finished, Colossians 2. There Paul challenged the Colossians with regards to the rites and ceremonies and ordinances of the Law.

"Wherefore *if* ye be dead with Christ from the rudiments of the world, why, as though living in the world, are ye subject to ordinances,

"(Touch not; taste not; handle not;

"Which all are to perish with the using;) after the commandments and doctrines of men?" (Col. 2:20-22).

If you have died with Christ, why are you subject to these things? Don't you know that a woman is bound by the Law to her husband so long as he liveth, but if he be dead, she may be married to another?

Now you are no longer tied to these ceremonial rites. Not at all. You don't go for the shadows anymore. You're not bound to the shadows, you have

the substance, *Christ*. If ye be dead with Christ, why are you subject to ordinances?

Now then Paul uses this same phraseology in Chapter 3:

"If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth on the right hand of God.

"Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth.

"For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God" (Col. 3:1-3).

Are you beginning to understand this? Do you see the sense of it? The idea is that while those people believed theoretically that they had been crucified, buried and raised with Christ, their lives did not show it. They were paying more attention to the things of this earth and of time.

Why is it that believers are so prone to seek those things which are on earth, instead of those things which are above? Why is it that we constantly renew our affection for things down here, temporal things—instead of the eternal things, which are ours in Christ? Do you know why? Because we have believed these things merely as dogma. We haven't believed them in the sense that we *be-live* them. We haven't made them our own. Now, the apostle begs us to make them our own. "If ye then be risen with Christ," if it's true that you died in Christ and have been buried, and raised with Him, and are now seated at God's right hand with Him [or in Him], then why don't you "set your affections on things above"?

Do you know why? Because you don't really believe that the blessings—the spiritual blessings of the heavenlies—are more to be desired than the physical and temporal things of earth, that's why.

The only remedy for this is to prayerfully spend more time with this blessed Book, so that we get to understand God's plan and purpose for us, and what it is He has for us, what He has made of us and what we have in Him.

"If ye then be risen with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ sitteth at the right hand of God" (Col. 3:1).

How often we read in the New Testament Scriptures, that the Son went to heaven to sit at the Father's right hand. We read it even in the Psalms and it is a very significant passage. In Psalm 110:1, you find the Father saying to the Son:

"The Lord said unto my Lord, Sit Thou at My right hand, until I make Thine enemies Thy footstool."

Why, the prediction is so clear. The significance of the passage is plain in the light of what has happened since. Christ had enemies on earth. They did not want Him. They said, "Away with this man" and "crucify Him," and they sent Him away from His own world as a Royal Exile, and said in effect, "We will not have this man to reign over us" (Luke 19:14). But the Father said, "Don't they want you there? Come and sit at My right hand until I make Thine enemies Thy footstool."

Now the position at the right hand is always, in Scripture, the place of favor and privilege and honor. The place of the honored guest is always at the host's right hand. Now Christ is God's beloved Son, the Son of His love. How often we read that in Scripture. You see this in John 3:35,36. Everybody quotes 36, but especially note Verse 35 also:

"The Father *loveth* the Son, and hath *given all things* into His hand.

"He that believeth on the Son hath everlasting life: and he that believeth not the Son shall not see life; but the wrath of God abideth on him" (John 3:35,36).

That immediately indicates that God loves and honors the Son and He cares what you do about His Son.

Now, that being so, is it not a wonderful truth that should gladden our hearts to think that we have been given a position at the right hand of God in Christ? What could be better than that? The Lord of all the universe bestowing upon us all His favor and honor and glory and blessing.

Ah, how marvelous that truth is, and that being so, Paul asks, Oh, do you really believe it? Are you really raised with Christ? Are you really sitting in Christ at God's right hand in the heavens? Then seek those things, which are there above. "Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth."

It is for us, beloved, to *decide* and to *act*. That is what the meaning of this phrase, "set your affection," indicates. It must be an act of your will, an act of faith.

Now in Verses 3 and 4, the apostle shows us that there is no question that they had truly been crucified and raised with Christ. For he goes on to say in Verse 3,

"For ye are dead, and your life is hid with Christ in God."

YOUR LIFE IS HID WITH CHRIST IN GOD

That is where your life is. You don't have any life on earth. You know that this body is going to die. And the soul, ah, "the soul that sinneth, it shall die." And the second death of which Revelation speaks is worst than the first. But thank God we do have life—in Christ. He is the One that died our death and

overcame death and carried us through from death to resurrection life.

Thank God, ye are dead, he says, "For ye have died and your life is hid with Christ in God."

The great mass of people think that Christ is dead. Oh, on Easter, they say, "He lives, He lives, He lives, by the teachings He left behind. We can still feel His influence about us" and so forth. But they don't believe that He actually rose physically from the grave and ascended into heaven to sit at the Father's right hand. The Bible says that this is exactly what He did and if He didn't, none of us have any hope of life to come. He is the first-fruits of our resurrection, and by His resurrection, we live. *He is the resurrection, and the life.* Ah, but the world doesn't know it. His life is now hid—hid in God.

"When Christ, who is our life, shall appear, then shall ye also appear with Him in glory" (Col. 3:4).

The word, "appear," perhaps, is not quite strong enough. The idea is that our life, like His, is hid. The world looks at us and they say, Well, he's getting older, he's sixty now, and later they'll say sixty-five, seventy, seventy-five—not going to be with us too long, and maybe at eighty-two he dies and they say, Well, he died, and they think his life is gone. Ah, no indeed. This was just the ushering in to a fuller life for the believer. Now his life is hid, but, "when Christ, who is our life, shall be *manifested*, then shall we also be manifested with Him in glory."

A LACKADAISICAL CHRISTIAN LIFE

There has been many a Christian who for long years lived a sort of careless, lackadaisical life. Such a Christian is saved, and he's glad he's saved. He

knows that he understands the plan of salvation, he's trusted Christ as His Savior, he goes to church, he sings these glad hymns, and he says, "Oh, how wonderful it is that I'm saved!" But Sunday is past and on Monday he is just heels over head in work. While it is perfectly right that he should work for a living, he can't stop after that day's work is done. He's bound by it, as if by chains. In the evening, when he comes home, he can hardly have fellowship with his wife and children. Until the moment that he goes to bed, he's all wrapped up in his business, just to make a few dollars—the things of this world.

Well, if he can't even have fellowship with his wife and children, he certainly can't enjoy fellowship with God in Christ at God's right hand. And in many such a case, a man has come to recognize this and he says, Now here, this is foolish; even from a worldly standpoint, I'm not even living. I'm just a machine to make money and I'm not getting anything out of life. But as a Christian, how much more I should have. Such individuals in many cases have come to a point in their lives where they have made the decision and a change took place. They began to give more time to prayer and the study of the Word and the things of God, and their lives were infinitely happier for it. Now that is exactly the idea in this phrase, "set your affection on things above." Don't just love them, but make it your business to show greater interest in them.

"Set your affection on things above, not on things on the earth" (Col. 3:2).

THE BELIEVER'S POSITION IN CHRIST

"Mortify therefore your members which are upon the earth; fornication, uncleanness, inordinate affection, evil concupiscence, and covetousness, which is idolatry:

"For which things' sake the wrath of God cometh upon the children of disobedience;

"In the which also ye walked some time, when ye lived in them.

"But now ye also put off all these; anger, wrath, malice, blasphemy, filthy communication out of your mouth.

"Lie not one to another, seeing that ye have put off the old man with his deeds" (Col. 3:5-9).

PUT OFF, PUT ON, AND PUT TO DEATH

Now it is with our position in Christ at God's right hand in view that Paul begins to go into detail.

First he says, "mortify" or *put to death*, that which is earthly in you: immorality, uncleanness, passion, evil concupiscence, and covetousness, which he says is "idolatry."

"For which things' sake the wrath of God cometh upon the children of disobedience" (Col. 3:6).

Notice the beauty of this verse, "the wrath of God" does not come upon you, but upon *them*, as he says in Ephesians 2:3: "[ye] *were* the children of wrath," but God has done something with you. He has given you life in Christ, you've been crucified with Christ, the old man is dead and you are "raised to walk in newness of life."

Now that does not mean that the believer cannot fall into sin; or that the believer cannot fail; for he often fails. For this reason the apostle says that it is our responsibility as believers to constantly be "*putting to death*" that which is earthly in us, that old nature that would lead us back into sin again. And he says we should do it because of "these things [for which] the wrath of God cometh upon the children of disobedience." The unsaved, the lost, will be

punished for these things. Surely you ought not to practice them, just because you have been delivered from sin.

We have the same idea in the Ephesian epistle again, where in one breath the apostle makes two amazing statements:

"And *grieve* not the Holy Spirit of God, whereby ye are *sealed* unto the day of redemption" (Eph. 4:30).

Isn't that beautiful? Do not grieve the Spirit that seals you and keeps you safe until the day of redemption, that is, "the redemption of our body." Now that is amazing; so many people are afraid that if you tell people that they are saved, once and for all, when they trust Christ as Savior, they'll begin living any kind of life. Ah, Paul says, that's not so. Don't you know, he says, "that the goodness of God leadeth thee to repentance" (Rom. 2:4)? And so he tells you the Spirit has *sealed* you and He is going to *keep* you until the day of redemption. Do not grieve Him. And in Ephesians again, he goes through a terrible list of sins, and says, "Let no man deceive you with vain words," as though God does not care about these things, "for because of these things cometh the wrath of God upon the children of disobedience" (Eph. 5:6).

This "wrath" does not come upon you, if you fall into these sins, but upon those that are the children of disobedience, who have not yet become the children of God.

"BE NOT YE *THEREFORE* PARTAKERS WITH THEM" (Eph. 5:7).

So notice that in both Ephesians as well as this passage in Colossians, we are presented with the glorious eternal security of the believer in Christ. It

is because we have a position now in Christ, that we should be careful not to do those things that displease Him.

"In the which also ye walked some time [once], when ye lived in them."

"PUT OFF ALL THESE ALSO"

"But now ye also put off all these; anger, wrath, malice, blasphemy, filthy communication out of your mouth.
"Lie not one to another, seeing that ye have put off the old man with his deeds" (Col. 3:8,9).

Do you get that? The Adamic nature, the old man, *has been* put off. He was put off at Calvary when you and Christ, as it were, had a meeting there. And, seeing ye have put off the old man with his deeds, now, experientially, put off all these also. And therefore Paul can say, and so can we:

"I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave Himself for me" (Gal. 2:20).

Now, I say that though you've put off the old man positionally, in a sense, that old man is very much alive. Every believer has a contest, as Galatians says, with two natures within him. And since these are contrary the one to the other, there is a constant warfare between them. The old nature that positionally died with Christ at Calvary can still be very active. He can show anger and unkindness and malice and blasphemy and impurity, and dishonesty. But the apostle says, Listen now. God has given you a position in Christ. As far as He is concerned—and that's what counts—you have been already raised with Christ in newness of life, and you have been seated

together with Him in the heavenlies. Now, get *interested* in those things which are above, where you belong. *Occupy* that position which He has given you. Occupy it *experientially*.

OUR POSITION IN CHRIST

Suppose I were to be elected the president of a bank. That is now the position that I have been given by the board of directors. They have an office for me, and a desk and a chair for me to occupy. But what good will it do if I do not experientially occupy that position? Then suppose I say, but I don't think I can live up to it. Ah, why would they have elected me to be the president of the bank and given me that position if they didn't expect me to occupy that position? But supposing someone else wants to occupy the position and the first morning of my duties as president, I find someone else there occupying the desk and the chair. Do I not have a right to say to him, *Get out*. This is *my* position. This office is for *me* to occupy.

Now, so it is with the position that God has given us in Christ. This is not something unreal, it is spiritual, but nonetheless real. The stripes that were laid to Christ's back, the death that He died at Calvary was *very* real, and that was *my* death. He had no death to die; He died *my death* at Calvary, and He took me through to resurrection life and I was raised with Him and exalted to sit with Him in the heavenlies. That is my position now, my spiritual right, I should occupy it. But I can only occupy it as I reckon that old Adamic nature, the old man, to be dead unto sin.

"Likewise reckon ye also yourselves to be *dead indeed unto sin*, but *alive unto God* through Jesus Christ our Lord" (Rom. 6:11).

"AND PUT THE OLD MAN AWAY"

So what do you do with something or someone that has died indeed? Why, you bury him, you put him away. You can't allow him to lie in the coffin in the house or within your presence forever. He must be put away. And so it is with the old man, and the deeds of the old man. Put off all these, everything that is earthly in you: anger, wrath, malice, blasphemy, filthy communication out of your mouth, dishonesty. It is sad that there are so many Christians that rejoice in their position, but never seek to occupy it by faith. They feel it is too much of God to ask them to put off anger, or filthy communication perhaps, or some little lies that they have been telling. Remember you can never enjoy and experience your position in the heavenlies, you can never appropriate your blessings there experientially until you obey Him in what He says here. You have put off the old man, now put off the old man experientially. Mortify all that is earthly in you, and put off these sins that are to be associated only with the old man and not with the new.

"AND PUT ON THE NEW MAN"

"And have put on the new man, which is renewed in knowledge after the image of Him that created him" (Col. 3:10).

Paul continues with an introversion here. *Put off* the old man with his deeds and, now the introversion, *"put on"* the new man. Put off, therefore, and put on—you see.

All this is very beautiful. When a man has been saved by the grace of God, when he has come to trust in Christ as his own personal Redeemer and Savior, he looks at things in an entirely different light. The world looks at the Bible in the light of things; we look

at things in the light of the Bible. Our knowledge has been renewed, "after the image of Him that created [us]," the Lord Jesus Christ.

The believer knows that as Christ is the *living* Word, this Book, this Bible is the *written* Word of God, and it is true. He knows, and this Bible tells us that the only thing we need to be afraid of, beloved, is *sin*. When we are, as believers, in a position or in circumstances and in a place where we are pleasing God and doing that which honors Him, we have nothing to be afraid of. Neither infirmity, nor sickness nor death; neither persecution, nor opposition need we be afraid of. We need *fear* only *sin*, for it is then that we get out of the mold, if you please, for which God has made us. The mold in which alone we really fit and find that we are happy and peaceful and blessed. It is only when we sin that we do not conform to that mold, to *the image of Christ*, and that is why he says: "And have put on the new man, which is renewed in knowledge after the image of Him that created him" (Col. 3:10).

He sees things differently now.

The Bible has a great deal to say about that, and especially the epistles of Saint Paul:

"This I say therefore, and testify in the Lord, that ye henceforth walk not as other Gentiles walk, in the vanity [shallowness] of their mind,

"Having [their] understanding darkened, being alienated from the life of God through the ignorance that is in them, because of the blindness of their hearts" (Eph. 4:17,18).

THE FOOLISHNESS OF THIS WORLD

Oh, the men of this world can imagine that they are so far above believers, as far as the intellect is concerned. But the Word of God says that this is

just the opposite of the truth. In the first chapter of I Corinthians, Paul says:

"Where is the wise? Where is the scribe? Where is the disputer of this world? Hath not God made foolish the wisdom of this world?

"For after that in the wisdom of God the world by wisdom knew not [never got to know] God, it pleased God by the foolishness of [the] preaching [of the Cross of Christ] to save them that believe" (I Cor. 1:20,21).

The world can never get to know God by its wisdom because it considers the finished work of Christ to be foolishness. Paul says that to preach "Christ crucified" is a "stumblingblock" to some and "foolishness" to others:

"But we preach Christ crucified, unto the Jews a stumblingblock, and unto the Greeks foolishness;

"But unto them which are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ [is] the power of God, and the wisdom of God.

***"Because the foolishness of God is wiser than men; and the weakness of God is stronger than men"* (I Cor. 1:23-25).**

Then again in I Corinthians 3:19 he says, "the wisdom of this world is *foolishness* with God." So you see, the believer is not so foolish after all. The man who just goes on and on and never even stops to think, Where will I finally end? What will finally become of me? that man is the foolish man. No matter how wisely he thinks he can speak on every subject, including religion, he has not even learned the *a-b-c's* of the most important thing that he should be considering, the salvation of his own precious soul from sin and its results.

"SIN IS NO JOKE"

So, we have learned that sin is not something to have fun with and to try and enjoy. It is not wise to

say, Let's throw care to the winds and have fun. Ah, no, *joy* is far more to be desired than fun, and God gives it only to those who know Christ as their Savior, and do see what a serious thing sin is.

So "put off" these things, the Apostle says, since you have "put off the old man with his deeds," and "put on the new man, which is renewed in knowledge after the image of Him that created [us]" (Col. 3:10).

"THE BOND OF PERFECTNESS"

"Put on therefore, as the elect of God, holy and beloved, bowels of mercies, kindness, humbleness of mind, meekness, longsuffering;

"Forbearing one another, and forgiving one another, if any man have a quarrel against any: even as Christ forgave you, so also do ye.

"And above all these things put on charity [love], which is the bond of perfectness" (Col. 3:12-14).

How different are the apostle's instructions from the instructions that many a father gives to his son in this world.

How often men say to each other and to their children: Don't be pushed around. Get what's coming to you, because if you don't, somebody else will take it from you.

How different, how very opposite, are the instructions that the Apostle Paul by the Holy Spirit gives to those who have come to know Christ as their Savior.

Since you have put on this new man which has come to see things so differently, *put on*, as the elect of God, inner feelings of mercy, kindness, humbleness of mind, meekness, longsuffering; forbearing one another, and forgiving one another—understanding that all of us still, as far as our experience is concerned,

carry that old nature within us. We must realize that others have the same struggles we do, and we must forebear one another and forgive one another, "if any man has a quarrel against any," and he adds, "even as Christ forgave you, so also do ye."

How much did Christ forgive us? Ah, He forgave us everything. In infinite love, He forgave us all our sins and paid for them Himself. How often we believers are unwilling to bear the sufferings that others cause us. We say, "Why should I bear that? Why should I take that from him? It is he that's doing wrong." Supposing *Christ* had said that, none of us would ever have been saved. That's why we read in Ephesians:

"And be kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you" (Eph. 4:32).[1]

And so we have it again here in Colossians 3:13:

"Forbearing one another, and forgiving one another, if any man have a quarrel against any: even as Christ forgave you, so also do ye."

And do this from the heart, because he says in Verse 14, "and above all these things put on [love], which is the bond of perfectness."

"And let the peace of God rule your hearts, to the which also ye are called in one Body; and be ye thankful" (Col. 3:15).

This of course takes us back to Verse 11 and the "new creation" in Christ:

"Where there is neither Greek nor Jew, circumcision nor uncircumcision, Barbarian, Scythian, bond nor free: but Christ is all, and in all" (Col. 3:11).

Oh, may God help us, beloved Christian friends, to live the kind of a life that will honor and glorify

our blessed Lord and Savior, who died for our sins in order that we might be accepted before God *in Him*, and have a position at God's right hand *in Him*.

GOD'S GRACE IN AN UNGODLY WORLD

"And let the peace of God rule in your hearts, to the which also ye are called in one Body; and be ye thankful.

"Let the Word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom; teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord.

"And whatsoever ye do in word or deed, do all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God and the Father by Him" (Col. 3:15-17).

THE PEACE OF GOD RULING THE HEART

It is one of the inexorable, unchangeable rules of true Christianity, that it is only sin that robs us of peace.

Now, peace is one of the greatest blessings the human heart can contain. It is the very opposite of the tension and fear and uncertainty that so upsets and unnerves many in our day. But these tensions and this uncertainty so often comes from sin, and that is why the Apostle Paul tells believers not to do the very things for which the ungodly will someday be cast out of God's presence and be punished. Don't do those very things for which Christ died. Do what is right. *Put off* all that is earthly in you and all that is of the old nature, and *put on* these virtues that honor God, and "the peace of God will rule your hearts."

"PEACE WITH GOD"

We cannot truly enjoy "the peace *of* God," until we have experienced "peace *with* God." This is what the death of Christ accomplished for believers:

"[Christ] was delivered for our offences, and was raised again for our justification" (Rom. 4:25).

"Therefore being justified by faith, we have peace *with* God through our Lord Jesus Christ" (Rom. 5:1).

Now that's a wonderful truth. Those without Christ cannot have peace with God. Remember, God cares what you do about Christ. It was in infinite love that He gave the Lord Jesus Christ, and that Christ gave Himself to die in shame and disgrace on a cruel Cross for sins He had never committed, for your sins and mine. And because of this, you cannot have "peace with God" until you have placed your faith in Christ.

Now there are many that continue with their drinking and pursuing pleasures and dancing and revelry. They don't care that Christ died. They don't believe He died for their sins. Well, God cares. Especially since He has made this fact so widely known, as it has been preached over the radio and in churches and open-air meetings and through literature, all over the world.

Now then, if you do not know the Lord Jesus Christ as your Savior, you are not at peace with God. But you can be at peace with Him. You can be justified by faith.

"But to him that worketh not, but believeth on Him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness" (Rom. 4:5).

Why don't you trust in the Lord Jesus Christ as your own Savior, and you will know the joy of "peace *with* God."

After you have come to experience "peace with God" through faith in our Lord Jesus Christ, after the *barrier* of sin has been taken away because you have accepted God's Word, that Christ died for your

sins, after that, you may then enjoy *"the peace of God."* Oh, that is a wonderful portion for any believer to possess, though many do not.

HEAVEN IS GOD'S THRONE

Just think. There is nothing that disturbs God in His heaven. God is on the throne and this whole universe runs according to His plan. We read in Ephesians 1:11 that God "worketh all things after the counsel of His own will." Again and again in that first chapter of Ephesians we read those phrases, "according to the good pleasure of His will" (ver. 5), and "according to His good pleasure" (ver. 9), and "according to the purpose of Him" (ver. 11), according to "His will" and so on. So, God is serene, above all the troubles and sorrows of this world. Not that He is not concerned about them. Not that He doesn't want to help you in all your troubles. But *He* is not in any trouble.

"THE PEACE OF GOD"

Now, the apostle shows that the only thing that really disturbs the believer is when he indulges in the very sins for which Christ died, when he indulges in those very sins that he knows are going to cost the unsaved a great deal as they are punished at the bar of God. So the apostle says, "Put off" those sins, and "put off" all these things too: anger, wrath, malice, blasphemy, filthy communication out of your mouth, dishonesty. Lie not one to another, and so on. And *"put on"* mercies and kindness and humbleness of mind and meekness and longsuffering and forgiveness and love.

Now it is as we believers seek by His grace to put off those sins that once cursed us, and to live the

kind of life that honors Him, that we enjoy the peace of God.

"And let the peace of God rule in your hearts to the which also ye are called in one Body, and be ye thankful" (Col. 3:15).

But I can almost hear someone say, Ah, but Mr. Stam, how can that be, because entirely apart from sin, there are many difficulties and adversities and sorrows and troubles that beset—not only the unbeliever—but beset believers in Christ. How then may they have this "peace of God" ruling in their hearts, if they seek to please Him? The fourth chapter of Philippians deals with the adversities and difficulties we face:

"Be careful [anxious] for nothing; but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God.

"And *the peace of God*, which passeth all understanding, shall keep [guard] your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus" (Phil. 4:6,7).[2]

Now beloved, in this dispensation of Grace, faith and grace both are raised to their very highest level. And that is why Philippians 4 says to us, "Don't be anxious about anything, but in everything, by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known unto God," and—and He'll do *whatever* you ask?—No, no.

"And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus."

So there you are, if you please, a double recipe for enjoying the peace of God. First of all, as far as your behavior, your conduct is concerned, by His grace through faith, live a life that honors your blessed Lord and Savior, who died for you. And, as to the circumstances that may surround, even beset you,

leave them all with Him. He will work them out for your good.

"And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to His purpose" (Rom. 8:28).

THE WORD OF CHRIST

But as wonderful as it is to experience the peace of God, peace is a passive thing, and turning to the active, the apostle says:

"Let the Word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom; teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord" (Col. 3:16).

Now we're going to stop with just that exhortation. "Let the Word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom." How grossly that phrase has been misunderstood. It is on the basis of this very verse that people have thought of compiling red letter New Testaments. And they alleged that all the words of the Lord Jesus Christ are printed in red in these red letter New Testaments. Don't you ever believe it, my dear friends, for those red letter New Testaments omit the very red letter words of the Lord Jesus and print them in black instead of red. What are His "red letter" words? Ah, those which He revealed from His glory in heaven as He ushered in "the dispensation of the grace of God" through the Apostle Paul. The "red letter" words of Christ, His greatest message of all time, are found in the Pauline epistles. How often Paul states this, and how clearly, and in what varied phraseology:

"But I certify you, brethren, that *the gospel* which was preached of me is not after man.

"For I neither received it of man, neither was I taught it, *BUT BY THE REVELATION OF JESUS CHRIST"* (Gal. 1:11,12).

Then, how often he uses simpler phraseology:

"For this we say unto you by *THE WORD OF THE LORD*..." (I Thes. 4:15).

"For *I HAVE RECEIVED OF THE LORD* that which also I delivered unto you..." (I Cor. 11:23).

"For I delivered unto you first of all *THAT WHICH I ALSO RECEIVED*..." (I Cor. 15:3).

And consistently, throughout his epistles, Paul makes it clear that *his writings* are a revelation from the glorified Lord in heaven. These are the words of the Lord Jesus Christ, speaking to the world again through the chief of sinners, saved by grace.

Ah, but somebody says then, He didn't write them. Of course not, He didn't write any part of the Bible. That is, as Jesus Christ the Son, He didn't. The Four Gospels are the records of His earthly ministry, and you find there in the records of Matthew, Mark, Luke and John some of the things that He said. But He didn't write them Himself. What is the difference whether Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, or Paul, writes them down? If they are the accurate and exact words of the Lord Jesus, they are certainly of paramount importance to us. And the epistles of Paul are of the greater importance, because they supersede what He said when He was on earth. When He was on earth, He was under the Law, and He taught others to be under the Law. He went to the Jewish synagogue *every* Sabbath, "as His custom was." And He proclaimed the gospel of the kingdom. But when that gospel and that kingdom were rejected, when Christ was rejected as an Exile in heaven, He reached down from His glory at the Father's right hand and revealed

to the very leader of the rebellion, the wonderful, wonderful message of His grace.

This is what the apostle means when he says, *"Let the Word of Christ"—this* Word of Christ, this *Word* that he has been proclaiming, this great and glorious *message* that had been entrusted to him.

"Let the Word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom" (Col. 3:16).

He wrote to the Corinthians, and said, "if I come again, I will not spare:"

"Since *YE SEEK A PROOF OF CHRIST SPEAKING IN ME*, which to you-ward is not weak, but is mighty in you" (II Cor. 13:2,3).

That is what he is talking about, these very epistles that bear the name of Paul the Apostle. *"Let the Word of Christ dwell in you richly."* Now, you must do something about that, my Christian friend. You must take the time to study the Epistles of Paul, for it is Paul, and no other writer of the Bible, who says:

***"For I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as I am the Apostle of the Gentiles, I magnify mine office"* (Rom. 11:13).**

This does not exclude the Jew. For you see, first God had only one nation on earth, as again He will have when He resumes His Kingdom Program (His Prophetic Program). But during this dispensation of Grace, the gospel goes to *all nations* and that is what the word Gentiles simply means, the nations, and Israel is simply *"one"* of those nations today. And Paul says, "I am the apostle to the nations, I magnify mine office." Now he goes on in Colossians 3:16,

"Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom; teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and hymns

and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord."

How beautiful! In this dispensation of Grace, God would have His people to be cheerful, happy people, because of what He has done for them. And because of the fact that it is His purpose:

***"THAT IN THE AGES TO COME HE MIGHT SHOW THE EXCEEDING RICHES OF HIS GRACE IN HIS KINDNESS TOWARD US THROUGH CHRIST JESUS"* (Eph. 2:7).**

We have the same idea in the Ephesian epistle as in Colossians Three:

"Wherefore be ye not unwise, but understanding what the will [purpose] of the Lord is."

"Speaking to yourselves [each other] in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody in your heart to the Lord;

"Giving thanks always for all things unto God and the Father in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ" (Eph. 5:17,19,20).

God would have us be happy in the grace that He has given to us, rejoicing constantly in the exceeding riches of His grace.

GIVING THANKS TO GOD IS APPROPRIATE EVERYDAY

Now to draw your attention to one more verse, because it goes with "the peace of God" in your hearts, and "the Word of Christ dwelling in you richly," and "singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord," the passage before us says:

"And whatsoever ye do in word or deed, do all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God and the Father by Him" (Col. 3:17).

People are so often asking us, writing letters, is this wrong or is that wrong? Let this be the touchstone.

Whatever you can do to the glory of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the glory of God with thanksgiving, that is right to do. If you cannot do it to His glory, it is wrong. You say, Well, what about such natural, daily things, such as the food I eat, and the coffee and the milk that I drink. He covers that too.

"Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or *whatsoever* ye do, do all to the glory of God" (I Cor. 10:31).

This is the great lesson that Paul would teach us in this passage here. Believers are saved by grace in order that they in turn might prove a spiritual blessing to others. And the only way in which we can do this is to truly live as the representatives of the Lord Jesus Christ he has called us to be.

Chapter 9 — Colossians 3:18-4:18

THE BOOK ON HUMAN RELATIONS

Grace can take the vilest sinner and give him a place at God's right hand in the heavenlies in Christ; declare him to be "accepted in the Beloved [One]," make him "complete in Christ," and proclaim him to be "blessed with all spiritual blessings" in Christ. Such grace that stoops down here to earth to help us in our daily lives is deserving of our full attention.

It is an amazing demonstration of the grace of God to see the Lord of glory, who revealed all the exalted truths of Colossians, condescend to step right down into our lives, our homes, our businesses, and our other social relationships to tell us how to conduct them.

Much is written about human relations these days, but nothing that begins to compare with this in its sublime wisdom, and certainly nothing that would begin to work so well, or bring such blessed results.

In the Bible we find very different instructions from those which we read in the world's books on human relations, even most religious books on human relations. In the world, the cry is constantly, "Give me, give me my rights." And they *think* that if they get their rights, they'll be happier for it. God says to believers, you just make sure you do what *is* right, and you will be happy.

In the world, the cry is constantly, "My rights, my rights." In the Word, the word is "righteousness," and its fruit, "peace" and true "joy."

Now, in this wonderful passage, the apostle—really the Holy Spirit through the apostle—speaks to wives and husbands, to children and fathers, to servants and masters. And please notice that he always speaks to the weaker first, then to the stronger. First the wife, then the husband. First the child, then the father. First the servant, then the master.

THE WIFE

"Wives, submit yourselves unto your own husbands, as it is fit in the Lord" (Col. 3:18).

Now in my own little experience, and from what I have observed, it seems to me that it is natural for women to want to be subject to their husbands. Most wives want to please their husbands and want their husbands to direct them and give the orders, so to speak. Now this comes from the law of creation. In Genesis 2:18, the Lord says:

"It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him an help meet [fit, proper, appropriate] for him."

It is not good that he's alone, I'll make him an help appropriate for him. And the average woman, unless she is taught or brought up otherwise, wants to be a help to her husband. She wants to help him, and when she stays in that position and holds that attitude, she is by far the happiest.

Sad to say, we are living in a day in which women are being taught to overcome this quality of nature, and to assert their alleged equality. While in fact, beloved, all this talk about everybody being equal is simply not so. Nobody is equal.

Yet, women are being taught to overcome this quality of nature and to assert an alleged equality. And

generally, that gets to be superiority, until you find a wife flinging the door to a restaurant open and her husband meekly walks eight or ten feet behind to see which table she's going to choose, and then he comes and meekly sits down with her.

This is all contrary to the Word of God and no true Christian wife will want to act so. The true believer will want to obey God and will want to be subject to her husband.

The objection has been raised that in many cases wives are more capable than their husbands, and that is very true. But in many cases children are also more capable than their parents, and citizens are more capable than the policemen who would direct the traffic. Does that mean that it would be all right for a man to speed just because he's smarter than the policeman and knows more than he does and knows when it's safe or isn't? Does that mean we should give the running of the household over to the children, just because these children might be more intelligent or more capable than their parents? Ah, no. Order is one of the chief ingredients of true peace and happiness in any society, and especially in the Church of God and in the Christian home. And so God says:

"Wives, submit yourselves unto your own husbands, as it is fit [meet, as it is proper] in the Lord" (Col. 3:18).

THE HUSBAND

But now notice, having said this to the wife, he now goes over to the husband in Verse 19, and he says, "I didn't say this to the wife so that you can beat her down and demand that your lordship should be obeyed in every detail." No, not at all, he says:

"Husbands, love your wives, and be not bitter against them" (Col. 3:19).

I don't think the idea is that husbands are naturally bitter against their wives, though many are today, of course. But that's not what is meant here. The thought here is that the wife naturally being ruled more by the heart than the head, may sometimes say and do things that just don't make sense to the husband. Then sometimes the husband will get impatient and say and do things to his wife that are not becoming. So he says, "Husbands, *love* your wives, and be not bitter against them." This same apostle puts it so very beautifully in Ephesians 5:25:

"Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the Church, and gave Himself for it."

Acknowledge that the wife gives herself to the husband because she loves him, and the husband gives himself for the wife, because he loves her. And here in Ephesians 5, he says, "Love your wives, even as Christ also loved the Church, and gave Himself for it." Why? Because He wanted to glorify her,

"That He might sanctify and cleanse [her] with the washing of water by the Word,
"That He might present [her] to Himself a glorious Church, not having spot, or wrinkle, or any such thing; but that [she] should be holy and without blemish" (Eph. 5:26,27).

So Christ loved the Church, and so the Holy Spirit through Paul says that husbands should love their wives.

THE CHILDREN

Now, having dealt with the wife and with the husband, he goes over to the child, and says:

"Children, obey your parents in all things: for this is well pleasing unto the Lord" (Col. 3:20).

Now this is a very difficult subject, and I should first point out that the word children here does not refer merely to babes or very little children. Not at all. This is evidently written to people intelligent enough to understand. He speaks not to the parents, but to the children. And the word is not *nepios*, little children, but *teknon*. A teknon could be a man full-grown, but the point here is, it's the offspring that are not yet of age.

"Children, obey your parents in all things, for this is well pleasing unto the Lord."

Now to all our dear Christian young people, I have a very earnest and loving word for you. I urge you to understand that this passage here comes to us from a very impartial and just Judge, the Lord Jesus Christ Himself, for these are the words of our exalted Lord. They are the Word of God the Son, to us.

Now, it is granted, that it may sometimes be very difficult for you to see the wisdom of the rules laid down and the things insisted upon by your parents. But I beg of you to believe that generally speaking, these rules are for your good, and specifically speaking, it is always for your good to obey them, except of course, should any parent ask the child to do something that is morally wrong or disobedient to God. Then, of course, the higher authority must take the precedence. But under God, he says, "Obey your parents," and he adds, "in all things."

Mark Twain once said, "When I was 14 years old, my father was so ignorant I was ashamed of the old man. But by the time I got to be 21, I was surprised at how much he had learned in 7 years."

Well, that's very true, you know. All of us, when we get older, see that our parents had something that we didn't have when we were young, and that was experience.

I was once talking to the proprietor of a hardware store right near my office about some of the terrible things that were happening in our nation among teenagers. And this man said, "Oh, my parents, God bless them, they were disciplinarians. We had to be in at a certain time at night and if we weren't, we caught it. And they didn't let us just run around. They saw to it that we obeyed, and we didn't just yell out at the table. We spoke when we were spoken to...," and so on.

I want you to notice the way he said it, "My parents, God bless them." He had learned that they were right. They had brought up a man that now could look back and say, "Oh, I'm so glad they did it. What terrible dangers and perils they saved me from."

So, my dear young friend, even when your parents seem to be too strict, remember, order must be preserved, and any family, like any business or any government, is happiest when there is order, and you are happiest when you submit to the order. But if you don't do it for your parent's sake, if you feel that they're very wrong and arbitrary and unkind and don't understand you, then do it for the Lord's sake, because it is just good for you to *obey*.

I remember that many years ago General Eisenhower said, "No man can ever learn to command who hasn't first learned to obey." Such sayings are found in the book of Proverbs again and again.

Many people today think that this is wrong. They maintain that the child should express himself or he'll be inhibited. Nonsense! I was paddled many a

time. And my father was a disciplinarian if there ever was one and I thank God for it. I'm sure that that is where leadership comes from. And leaders do not come from homes where the children can do anything they want to, but from homes where they had learned to obey, so that later, they learn how to give commands justly.

In II Timothy the 3rd chapter, we read about the day that, very evidently, we are living in. It is a day when people don't even try to bring up their children anymore. They don't try to train them, they just let them express themselves, and let them go their way, and don't do anything to try to bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord. And do you know the Apostle Paul predicted this? Listen to what he said in II Timothy 3 the first few verses:

"This know also, [this understand also,] that in the last days perilous times shall come.

"For men shall be lovers of their own selves, covetous, boasters, proud, blasphemers, *disobedient* to parents, unthankful, unholy,

"Without natural affection, trucebreakers, false accusers, incontinent, fierce, despisers of those that are good,

"Traitors, heady, highminded, lovers of pleasures more than lovers of God;

"Having a form of godliness, but denying the power thereof..." (II Tim. 3:1-5).

Now beloved, do you want to be in the middle of a list like that? I surely do not, but that is one of the indications that we are living *in the last days* of this dispensation of Grace. The disobedience of children to their parents, I say, is one of these indications. So, if not for your parent's sake, at least for your own sake and for the Lord's sake, "Children, obey your parents in all things, for this is well pleasing unto the Lord."

And, my dear friends, if it should seem that I'm speaking longer to children than I do to any other category here, please believe that I'm not trying to preach to you, not at all. I'm doing this only because I realize how difficult it was for *me* to learn that my parents were actually looking out for my good. When they were angry and spanked me, I thought they were just angry and spanked me. Ah, no. Part of their anger arose from the fear that I might go off in the wrong direction and become the kind of a son that would make them bow their heads in shame.

There is a saying, it's been repeated many, many times: Far better that the children should cry than the parents. The children just cry because for a time something is denied to them or they're punished for something. Ah, but when the parents cry, that is far more serious—it means that something very wrong has taken place, something very unfortunate, some catastrophe. So, children, "obey your parents in all things, for this is well pleasing unto the Lord."

AND YOU FATHERS

Now, having dealt with the children to obey their parents in everything, he goes now to the parents—how reasonable, how fair, how just—and says,

"Fathers, provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged" (Col. 3:21).

As the children can become exasperated with their parents and say, They don't understand me, just so the parents can become very exasperated with their children, don't forget that. And sometimes they begin to do things, oh, just because they're angry with that child, or exasperated with him. But God says, don't do it. Don't provoke your children to anger,

and don't say and do things that will cause them to be discouraged. Sometimes they can talk so big, but they're really not big. They're still tender plants, easily hurt and easily discouraged. So "fathers, provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged." The true father, the good father will train and discipline his children, but will not needlessly irritate and aggravate and certainly not discourage them.

My dear dad, as I said, was a disciplinarian if there ever was one. He ruled our household of eight children with a firm hand. Oh, I thank God for it. But he loved us, too, and every one of us knew it. He would take us on his knee when we were really too old to be sitting there, and say things to encourage us and so on. We had a wonderful dad and a wonderful mother. And I thank God for them, and I know this, that when a child is trained and disciplined in the right way, he won't hate you parents for it. Not at all.

When my brother had come home from Africa some years ago, he had to go out on deputation work with his wife and we were to take care of two of the children, their two boys. Before my brother and his wife left, they said to me, "Listen, please do us a favor. When they need a spanking, give it to them. Don't spoil them, we'll be happier if you keep them under control." We said we would, but those dear kids, they hardly ever needed even a reprimand. They were such willing and helpful little young men, we just loved them. But, a little period came there, I suppose it must have been rainy weather or some thing, and one of them just for a few days was just ornery, as we say. He was most aggravating, he did everything backwards and everything just seemingly to annoy us. He just was not happy, that's all, and we just couldn't find out what was wrong. This one occasion, I had

told him three times not to do a certain thing, and he did it anyway. I said to him, Paul, didn't I tell you three times not to do that? He said, Yes. I said, Come here. And I took him to another room and I made the necessary arrangement to warm his bottom well, and then I buttoned him up again and sent him his way. And do you know what he did? He went right over to my wife, the tears still running down his face, and he said, "Auntie, Uncle Neal is a nice man, isn't he?" You know, we have never forgotten that. He knew I didn't hate him, because he knew what he had been doing those last few days, and it finally had brought him to the place where he was willing to be obedient again, and he was the happier for it. Thus,

"Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it" (Prov. 22:6).

"Children, obey your parents....

"Fathers, provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged" (Col. 3:20,21).

THE WORK PLACE

And now the apostle deals with servants and masters.

"Servants, obey in all things your masters according to the flesh; not with eyeservice, as menpleasers; but in singleness of heart, fearing God.

"And whatsoever ye do, do it heartily, as to the Lord, and not unto men" (Col. 3:22,23).

Now this passage becomes the more significant to us today when we realize that this word "servant," used 125 times in the New Testament, has to do not with a paid servant, but with a bondslave. There was slavery in those days, and some of it was legitimate.

When a man went bankrupt, the laws were not as easy on him as they are today. He had to sell himself

out as a slave so that his master could pay off his debt, and there were other ways in which slaves were acquired. Sometimes masters were very careful and considerate of their slaves as, for example, Onesimus and his master. They got along very well until finally something happened and Onesimus ran away. Some masters were very thoughtful and gracious. Others, of course, were unreasonable.

But first, Paul speaks to the slave. What does he say? Assert your rights, rise up and rebel?—nothing of the kind. No, he says obey your master in all things, whether he is just or unjust. Remember this, God is behind it and for some wise and good reason, He allowed you to become the slave of this man; and render him obedience, not with eyeservice (you know, looking to see if the boss is around or not!), but with singleness of heart, fearing God, and obey him. Whatever ye do, do it heartily, because remember, you are doing it truly not for the boss, but for the Lord,

"Knowing that of the Lord ye shall receive the reward of the inheritance, for ye serve the Lord Christ.

"But he that doeth wrong shall receive for the wrong which he hath done: and there is no respect of persons [with God]" (Col. 3:24,25).

There is no master and servant with God. So obey your master and God will richly reward you. Oh, what a paymaster He is! What a great, wonderful Person to work for He is!

IN TODAY'S WORLD

Now this certainly would apply with greater significance to our day, when practically everybody is paid. He says, "obey your master," remember there is to be *obedience*, there is rank in the order of God.

Obey your employer, do what he tells you to do, do it heartily as unto the Lord, because you are really working for God, and He'll take care of the offenders.

This, of course, speaks to us all of Christian relationships. If you're not a Christian, you need to be saved, because then you are in a bad way. But Paul tells us how to have an ideal relationship in the work place, and he walks over to the master, and says:

"Masters, give unto your servants that which is just and equal; knowing that ye also have a Master in heaven" (Col. 4:1).

Pay your servants that which is just and equal for one good reason. You have a Master in heaven. How would you like Him to pay you for the Christian service that you've rendered to Him?

What a passage! Surely the regenerated wife and husband, child and parent, servant and master will see how high above the wisdom of the world this sacred exhortation is. God has stepped in and told us the true way to happiness in human relations.

CLOSING EXHORTATIONS

We have come to the closing exhortations of Paul's great Epistle to the Colossians. And I do not know of a passage in the Pauline epistles where the importance of his particular message is demonstrated with greater clarity and force than it is in this brief passage:

"Continue in prayer, and watch in the same with thanksgiving;
"Withal praying also for us, that God would open unto us a door of utterance, to speak the mystery of Christ, for which I am also in bonds:
"That I may make it manifest, as I ought to speak.

"Walk in wisdom toward them that are without, redeeming the time.

"Let your speech be alway with grace, seasoned with salt, that ye may know how ye ought to answer every man" (Col. 4:2-6).

CONTINUE IN PRAYER

The Apostle Paul begins this closing exhortation with the phrase, "Continue in prayer." I am glad we find this translated just this way, for it explains another expression which the apostle uses in other places in his epistles, which has been greatly misunderstood and has caused sincere Christians to become discouraged.

We find this expression elsewhere in I Thessalonians 5:17, where Paul writes to believers and tells them to "Pray without ceasing." Now I have read in commentaries, and I have heard preachers say how this means that we should always be praying, and if we cannot do that, at least be always in the attitude of prayer.

Frankly, I think it is very impossible to be always praying, or even to be always in the attitude of prayer. There are times when a bookkeeper has to be occupied with his figures, or the workman at his lathe has to be paying attention to what he is doing. He cannot always be praying nor be in the attitude of prayer. And this is not wrong, for God tells us that whatever we do we should do it *heartily* as unto the Lord. We should give our full attention to our daily work when we are doing it, so we cannot always even be in the attitude of prayer. Granted, we should be, when we *can be*, but we cannot always be. For one thing, we cannot pray without ceasing because every one of us has to get ready for bed and close our eyes and

give up, as it were, once every day, for seven or eight hours and be fast asleep. We cannot always be in the attitude of prayer.

Ah, no, when the apostle says, "Pray without ceasing," he means, never stop the *practice* of prayer, never quit praying, you see. Never give up praying, and that's the idea here, of course. "Continue in prayer." Continue in the practice of prayer.

Now this is a very important exhortation for all who know Christ as their Savior, and God as their Father. We are so prone to pray only when we are in trouble, or when we are ill, or when we find some obstacle or difficulty facing us—then we pray. Otherwise, we are so prone to forget to pray. And that is why the apostle says, "pray without ceasing," never stop praying, and continue in the practice of prayer. There is so much to pray for, so much we ought to pray for. We ought—just without ceasing—to ask God to keep us in the center of His will; to help us to understand His Word so that we can be used effectively in His service; to keep us from sin in thought and word and deed. We ought to be praying for others who need us, who need our prayers. This is a very earnest exhortation from the apostle's heart and pen, and a very important one for every believer to take to heart. "*Continue in prayer.*" Pray, and never quit praying.

Now Paul goes on to say, "...and watch in the same." Now that word *watch* is an old English word which, when this Bible was translated 400 years ago, simply meant to *be awake*. Watch and pray, be awake, and pray. We should be awake and alert even in our prayers. He says, watch in the same, watch in your prayers. We should pray intelligently, we should pray thoughtfully, we should give our attention to praying,

and, as it were, realize that we are addressing God in the name and through the merits of our Lord Jesus Christ. This is a great privilege, and we should give our attention to it when we do it.

This exhortation is a rebuke to the monotonous recitation of prayers which thousands take part in, but never really come to enjoy as the believer can enjoy simple, sincere, forthright, prayer to God. Also this repetition of prayers is so contrary to the whole teaching of Scripture on prayer. We don't *say* prayers; as believers, we *pray*.

"Let us therefore come boldly unto the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy, and to find grace to help in time of need" (Heb. 4:16).

Why should I go to God in time of sickness and say, "Give us this day our daily bread," and things of that kind, when I have a box full of bread and the refrigerator is full of good things to eat. Ah, no, I come to Him with my need at that time. And even if I am not in special need, I still continue in prayer, for all of us have great spiritual needs: to be drawn closer to God; to know the Lord Jesus Christ better; and to glorify Him as we should. So let us do away with this foolish recitation of prayers and come to God *in prayer* as He teaches it.

"Continue in prayer, and *watch* in the same *with thanksgiving"* (Col. 4:2).

Now then, there is one more detail about this injunction to pray. We should never pray without giving thanks. God has already been so kind and gracious to us. God has done so much for us in Christ as Paul has declared in this Colossian epistle. Our sins and the burden of guilt would have sunk us into the lake of fire. We have much indeed for which to

thank God through Jesus Christ our Lord. He blesses us every day with beautiful sunrises and sunsets, and flowers, and fresh air to breathe; and good water to drink, and most of us have all the food we need to eat, and all the riches of His grace besides.

We should never pray without also *giving thanks* for His kindness toward us through Christ Jesus.

"Be careful [anxious] for nothing; but in everything by prayer and supplication *with thanksgiving* let your requests be made known unto God.

"And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus" (Phil. 4:6,7).

OUR RELATIONSHIP TO THE SAVED

But now we come to an amazing little passage. This great apostle, so mightily used of God, asked them also to pray for him. He has a two-fold request to make. First of all, he is God's "ambassador in bonds." Now, you could not find a greater demonstration of the grace of God, for instead of declaring war on a Christ-rejecting world, God lets them imprison His great ambassador, Paul, and leaves him in bonds and does not punish those who committed such terrible crimes against him.

"A Door of Utterance"

So the apostle himself asks for prayer. He prays that his ministry may be widened, that the prison door might open and that he might step forth and begin his travels again, founding new churches and establishing those in the faith who had already come to meet together as churches. He prays that God would open the door of utterance and says, Won't you join me in this prayer?

An Open Mouth of Utterance

"Withal praying also for us, that God would open unto us a door of utterance, *TO SPEAK THE MYSTERY OF CHRIST, FOR WHICH I AM ALSO IN BONDS:*

***"THAT I MAY MAKE IT MANIFEST AS I OUGHT TO SPEAK"* (Col. 4:3,4).**

There is something more remarkable about this prayer, there's another part of it. Paul desires that *an open door* may be set before him, but also that as *I* have this open door set before me, *I* may preach that message for which Christ has saved me.

In other words, that he might be given the *courage* and the *boldness* to make this message known. You thought that Paul was the fearless one who went from one riot into another, who was almost killed again and again and still went forth preaching this great message. Now he is in prison and begins to write about it to the various churches and to individuals. You thought he was fearless? Ah, no. Listen to what he writes the Corinthians:

"And I was with you in weakness, and in fear, and in much trembling" (I Cor. 2:3).

After trouble had started at Corinth, God had to encourage him by a special vision:

"Then spake the Lord to Paul in the night by a vision, Be not afraid, but speak, and hold not thy peace:

"For I am with thee, and no man shall set on thee to hurt thee: for I have much people in this city.

"And he continued there for a year and six months, teaching the Word of God among them" (Acts 18:9-11).

So the Apostle continued his ministry at Corinth for a year and a half with very outstanding results.

In Ephesians, he also shows the importance of prayer by such phrases as "praying always," and "for

all saints" (Ver. 18), and again asks specifically for himself:

"And for me, that utterance may be given unto me, that I may open my mouth boldly, to make known the mystery of the gospel,

"For which I am an ambassador in bonds: that therein I may speak boldly, as I ought to speak" (Eph. 6:19,20).

OPEN DOORS, OPEN MOUTHS, AND OPEN HEARTS

It is a very amazing fact that this apostle had to ask for prayer for boldness. He was not naturally bold, he was naturally very sensitive and timid and had to pray constantly for boldness. Should this not encourage us, dear Christian friends? We ought to speak boldly too, but so often we do not. Our adversary, the devil, uses our natural timidity and fear, especially about the things of God, to shut our mouths. Should we not pray for one another and for ourselves, that God will grant us boldness, that we may open our mouths to make known this message boldly, as we ought to make it known? Actually, there were three prayers in the prison epistles of Paul. One for an *open door* (Col. 4:3) to make the message known. Another for an *open mouth* (Eph. 6:19) to proclaim it boldly. And a third for *open hearts*, that men who hear it might receive it (Phil. 1:9,10).

There is a special reason why the apostle prayed these three prayers so earnestly. It is because this message, which he calls the "*Mystery,*" is roundly and deeply hated by Satan, "the prince of the power of the air" (Eph. 2:2).

"Even the Mystery which hath been *hid from ages and from generations*, but now is made manifest to His saints" (Col. 1:26).

This *Mystery*, "hid from ages and from generations" (Col. 1:26), "hid in God" (Eph. 3:9), "in other ages...not made known" (Eph. 3:5); "kept secret since the world began" (Rom. 16:25), but "now" is "made manifest" (Rom. 16:26) is the message God wants proclaimed today.

So Paul multiplies phrases to show that this plan, this purpose of God, was *kept secret* until he was raised up of God, and sent forth to proclaim it.

***"And to make all men see what is the fellowship of the Mystery, which from the beginning of the world hath been hid in God, who created all things by Jesus Christ"* (Eph. 3:9).**

Since Satan hates this message, and is the great perverter of the truth of God, we must pray for boldness to make it known also.

OUR RELATIONSHIP TO THE LOST

It is with this truth in mind, this grand, wonderful message that had been committed to Paul, and with that as a background, that the apostle closes his exhortation to these believers in Christ, by saying:

"Walk in wisdom toward them that are without, redeeming the time" (Col. 4:5).

He is speaking here of our relation to the unsaved, and he says, Oh, be careful to walk intelligently. You should understand God's program and know that these are evil days, and who knows how long this age of Grace will be prolonged. It could end within ten minutes, by Christ calling away His own to Himself, and the age of judgment begin.

"See then that ye walk circumspectly [carefully], not as fools, but as wise,
"Redeeming [buying up] the time, because the days are evil.

"Wherefore, be ye not unwise, but understanding what the will of the Lord is" (Eph. 5:15-17).

You should understand, you should be intelligent about God's purpose and plan for today so as to reach the lost and untaught with the Word *rightly divided*. And if you are, you know that He never gave us one sign with which this dispensation will close. Christ could come at any moment. He has not promised one additional heartbeat, nor another breath of fresh air.

***"BEHOLD, NOW IS THE ACCEPTED TIME; BEHOLD, NOW IS THE DAY OF SALVATION"* (II Cor. 6:2).**

To the Thessalonians, Paul wrote, "And to *wait* for His Son from heaven" (I Thes. 1:10); and to the Philippians, "from whence also we *look* for the Savior" (3:20,21). The Ephesians were also looking for the coming of the Lord Jesus to change us to be with Himself. Now then, he says, Oh, walk in wisdom, walk intelligently, specially with regard to those who are still outside of Christ. How careless Christians can be, while the world is dying. Often they can joke and have fun with the unsaved—good fellows, you know—but they never have a serious talk with them about their future. They never warn them of the wrath of God to come and of the wonderful way of salvation that He has provided in Christ. Oh, may God help us! In the last verse of this passage, he exhorts, that you may know how to discuss these matters intelligently, and thoughtfully.

"Let your speech be always with grace, seasoned with salt, that ye may know how ye ought to answer every man" (Col. 4:6).

May God help us, Christian friends, to be better testimonies than we are.

THE CLOSING SALUTATIONS

The fact that no less than ten individual persons are mentioned by name in these closing salutations indicate something of the character of this great man, Paul the Apostle. He had often addressed great multitudes, and wherever he went, he had a great deal on his mind. Sometimes he had several aides and servants and secretaries with him, and he sent people back and forth constantly to carry letters and to make known the gospel in other places. And yet, with all this on his mind, he was interested and often concerned about single individuals. So great a heart did he have for all men.

Now it might seem at first glance that these verses just carry farewell greetings, and salutations from one to another, which might be rather dry. But this is very far from dry, for these passages are filled with many interesting facts, and we gain much valuable insight as we study it.

"TYCHICUS"

"All my state shall Tychicus declare unto you, who is a beloved brother and a faithful minister and fellowservant in the Lord,

"Whom I have sent unto you for the same purpose, that he might know your estate, and comfort your hearts" (Col. 4:7,8).

Tychicus, evidently, was the bearer of this Colossian epistle and also of that encyclical letter to the Ephesians, and of another to a man by the name of Philemon.

Tychicus had traveled all the way from Paul's prison in Rome to Colosse in order to bear these letters and these greetings to the saints. It is wonderful

that Paul could call him a *beloved* brother, a faithful *servant*, and a *bondslave* in Christ. Like Paul, this dear man had no will of his own. He had sold out completely to Christ and wanted to do His will alone, and evidently was doing very well as a Christian. Hence Paul says, He will tell you all about me, and how I'm doing, and I've sent him, too, that I might learn of how you're doing, so that he might learn your conditions and let me know about it, and of course, encourage your hearts.

"ONESIMUS"

"With Onesimus, a faithful and beloved brother, who is one of you. They shall make known unto you all things which are done here" (Col. 4:9).

Now the second one whom Paul mentions is Onesimus, and he says that he too is "a faithful and beloved brother," and "one of you." *"One of you!"* for he, too, was a Colossian, you see, and his account is very interesting.

The story of this runaway slave is told to us in Paul's letter to Philemon. Onesimus had run away from Philemon, and had evidently stolen some of Philemon's goods, perhaps his back pay. After he had stolen it he had come to Rome. Whether he had looked Paul up or "accidentally" came into contact with him, we don't know. But we do know that right there in prison, Paul led him to faith in the Lord Jesus Christ. As soon as he had accepted Christ as his Savior, the first thing Paul said to Onesimus was, Now go back to Philemon and straighten these things out, and I'll send a letter with you to make it easier. So, we turn to the letter that Paul wrote to Philemon, and find that it is a very, very beautiful letter indeed.

PAUL'S EPISTLE TO "PHILEMON"

Philemon was one of the Christians at Colosse. The letter Paul wrote him was a personal letter about Onesimus. It was sent along with Colossians to the church at Colosse. Paul entreats Philemon:

"I beseech thee for *my son Onesimus*, whom I have begotten in my bonds: Which in time past was to thee unprofitable, but now profitable to thee and to me: Whom I have sent again: thou therefore receive him" (Phile. 10,11).

Onesimus was much more than a slave now. He is a brother beloved, the apostle says, and "specially to me." Now that he is saved, he writes Philemon, "how much more unto thee, both in the flesh and in the Lord" (Ver. 16).

"For perhaps he therefore departed for a season, that thou shouldest receive him forever; Not now as a servant [slave], but above a servant, a brother beloved, specially to me, but how much more unto thee, both in the flesh, and in the Lord? If thou count me therefore a partner, receive [Onesimus] as myself. If he hath wronged thee, or oweth thee ought, put that on mine account; I Paul have written it with my own hand, I will repay it" (Phile. 15-19).

Paul was very anxious that he might keep Onesimus there, or that Philemon might send him back, for he was apparently a great help to his ministry:

"Whom I would have retained with me, that in thy stead he might have ministered [served] unto me in the bonds of the gospel: But without thy mind would I do nothing, that thy benefit should not be, as it were, of necessity, but willingly" (Phile. 13,14).

How beautiful this is and how wonderful that he could assure, not only Philemon, but also all the Colossians that this former slave, this runaway from Philemon, was now a faithful and beloved brother.

How very beautiful! I can imagine Onesimus going back first to Philemon and Philemon receives him with all his heart and then they go together to the church at Colosse. How very different their relationship is now. How very different!

PAUL'S COMPANIONS IN TRAVEL

"Aristarchus my fellowprisoner saluteth you, and Marcus, sister's son to Barnabas, (touching whom ye received commandments: if he come unto you, receive him)" (Col. 4:10).

Now then, we come to the third person mentioned here, and this is Aristarchus. "Aristarchus my fellowprisoner saluteth you."

In Acts 19:29, we learn that he was *Paul's companion in travel*, and twice after that in the Book of Acts we find him still traveling with Paul, and evidently he continued, he stuck right with Paul until they got to Rome. And there, he was imprisoned with Paul. Whether he was charged with some crime with Paul or whether he just begged that he might be able to stay with Paul and was therefore imprisoned with him, we are not sure, but it would seem that the latter is the case. If he had been separately charged, he might have been separately imprisoned. Regardless here we find him in prison with Paul, "my fellowprisoner." So it would seem that Aristarchus was just that faithful a Christian and a helper to the great apostle that when Paul was imprisoned, Aristarchus chose and asked to be imprisoned with him that he might serve him and wait on him and help him. What a wonderful example of faithful Christian service and sacrifice.

And in this same verse Paul mentions another individual named *Marcus*, whom he says was the

sister's son to Barnabas. In other words, he was a nephew to Barnabas; Barnabas was his uncle. Notice the unusual way in which he phrases this:

"Touching [concerning] whom ye received commandments: if he come unto you, receive him" (Ver. 10).

Evidently Paul had already written to these people that in the event Marcus comes, or some word had already been sent in some other way, perhaps by word of mouth he had given some commandments, at any rate if Marcus should come, they were now to receive him.

Marcus was the one who wrote the record of our Lord's earthly ministry called, The Gospel According to St. Mark. Now this is quite significant. Mark had been an unfaithful servant to Paul and to Christ. He had once failed. But the remarkable thing is that his restoration produced this record about the Perfect Servant. Mark presents Christ as the Perfect Servant in his Gospel narrative.

In Acts 4:36,37, we first read about his Uncle Barnabas, who evidently was a wealthy man. He had houses and lands, but he gave up everything for Messiah, as they all lived out of one purse, if you please, in Jerusalem, in prospect of the coming of Christ to set up His kingdom. You may also recall that the kingdom was rejected by the leaders at Jerusalem, and was therefore not set up, indeed has not yet been set up.

Marcus himself came from a large home in Jerusalem. In Acts 12:12, it is implied, at least, that his home was of considerable size. Some feel that it must have been a small inn or a hotel.

Perhaps, through his uncle's instrumentality, Marcus was chosen to go with Paul and Barnabas as

their servant on their first apostolic journey. Probably that worked out fine at first, but in the 13th chapter of Acts we find that when they got to Cyprus and got among the heathen, Mark evidently became afraid. At any rate, he turned back, and, if you please, ran home to Mamma, in Jerusalem. Then later, when Barnabas again suggested that he and Paul take Mark with them on their second apostolic journey, Paul said, "Nothing doing. He's not going to go with us, he was unfaithful, he turned back on his last journey." And Barnabas insisted that Mark should go along and Paul insisted that he most certainly would not. Consequently, we read in Acts 15 that the contention between them was so great, that that great man of God, Barnabas, separated from that other even greater man, Paul. Sadly, we never read of Barnabas again, except in this epistle, and only just to learn the fact that he was uncle to Mark.

In the meantime, something happened with Mark. After Paul had refused to take him along, Mark had evidently shown signs that he had learned his lesson and had become very faithful in the Lord's service. In Philemon, Verse 24, Paul calls him, "my fellowlaborer." In Colossians 4:10, he writes, "if he come unto you, receive him." And in II Timothy, Paul's very last letter, he says, "Take Mark, and bring him with thee: for he is profitable to me for the ministry" (II Tim. 4:11). So Mark was wonderfully restored to service for Christ, and although he had once been so unfaithful, now he is called a faithful helper.

HIS FELLOW WORKERS

"And Jesus, which is called Justus, who are of the circumcision. These only are my fellowworkers unto the kingdom of God, which have been a comfort unto me" (Col. 4:11).

Now then, we come to the next name, "*Jesus, which is called Justus.*" He says Mark and this man, Justus, were of "the circumcision." They were his kinsmen after the flesh, they were Hebrews, they were Israelites, and he says, these only are my fellow workers unto the kingdom of God, that is, among the people of Israel, among his kinsmen. They have proved a very great comfort to me. I'm sure they must have. Marcus and Justus, his own kinsmen in the flesh, with him there to encourage and to help him in his sorrows and troubles and difficulties and all the opposition that faced him.

Next, he mentions Epaphras who also was a Colossian.

"Epaphras, who is one of you, a servant of Christ, saluteth you, always labouring fervently for you in prayers, that ye may stand perfect and complete in all the will of God.

"For I bear him record, that he hath a great zeal for you, and them that are in Laodicea, and them in [of] Hierapolis" (Col. 4:12,13).

Now Tychicus was a Colossian. Onesimus was a Colossian. And together they were going back to Colosse to bear this letter written by Paul in Rome. Epaphras was also a Colossian, but he evidently felt he should not return to Colosse with the other two. He concluded that Paul needed the help too greatly, whatever help Epaphras could give. And so Paul hastens to assure these Colossians, I bear him record, he has a great zeal—really a great love—for you, and for those in your general vicinity. Paul had a particular reason for writing this: "[He] labors fervently for you in prayer, that ye might stand perfect and complete in all the will of God." In all the will of God, not merely for their lives but His will in general, His purpose and His plan for the age in which they and

we live. In essence, he says, Epaphras is very eager that ye might surely understand this great message and God's great plan, and that ye might stand full-grown and mature in it, that ye might be well able to explain it to others and to build them up in the faith.

Then, finally, we come to Verse 14:

"LUKE, THE BELOVED PHYSICIAN, AND DEMAS, GREET YOU."

Luke, "the beloved physician," oh, how much is implied here. There is no one of whom we read more consistently in the latter part of Paul's life, that he is with Paul. Evidently Paul needed him for physical reasons. I can hardly see another reason why he should call him *the beloved physician*; it certainly indicates that physicians were in order at this time in Paul's ministry.

Some are telling us that we should go back to Pentecost. They tell us it is a sign of unbelief and failure in our Christian spiritual lives if we are not well in body. We haven't claimed, they say, all that we might claim. And yet we find Paul progressively in his epistles, explaining that we are going to suffer in the flesh, that these great miraculous demonstrations, these healing signs of Pentecost were to be done away. We find him prescribing medicine for Timothy and his "often infirmities." We find him leaving Trophimus "at Miletum sick." We find that even Paul is poor in health himself, often failing in his physical body. He says, "but though our outward man perish, yet [thank God] the inward man is renewed day by day" (II Cor. 4:16). "We that are in this tabernacle," he says, "groan," and not only the world, but us, we "groan," waiting for the redemption of our bodies (II Cor. 5:4; Rom. 8:23).

Now then, I say, it's very significant that he has Luke with him here and calls him *the beloved physician*. In fact, Luke was with him to the very end, for in Paul's last letter, just before he was beheaded by Nero, others had left him and some had even forsaken him, but he says, "Only Luke is with me" (II Tim. 4:11). What a great comfort Luke must have been to the Apostle Paul as he ministered to his physical infirmities, and helped him with such remedies as he could to give him relief in his pain and his bodily affliction.

On the other hand it was different with Demas, who is mentioned in the same verse. He simply says, "Demas, greets you." Demas is the only one concerning whom Paul has nothing to say by way of commendation, not one word. I wonder if it indicates that at that time already, Demas showed signs of wavering spiritually. In Paul's last letter in II Timothy 4:10, he had to say:

"For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world [evil age], and is departed unto Thessalonica."

"Demas hath forsaken me." It would appear that something was already wrong here when Paul wrote to the Colossians, for Paul was always so ready to compliment and to praise those who lived faithfully for the Lord Jesus Christ or had done him personally some kindness. But there is no word about Demas, excepting, perhaps, some word to encourage Demas. He probably said to Demas, I'm going to send your greetings to the Colossians. Demas greets you.

THE HOME BIBLE STUDY

"Salute the brethren which are in Laodicea, and Nymphas, and the church which is in his house.

"And when this epistle is read among you, cause that it be read also in the church of the Laodiceans; and that ye likewise read the epistle from Laodicea" (Col. 4:15,16).

Now, in Verse 15, we find still another mentioned. He says, "Salute the brethren which are in Laodicea," a town not far away, "and Nymphas, and the church which is in his house." How many churches have started in this way? How many Bible classes have been held in homes? Little groups have met together to worship the Lord Jesus and to learn more about Him in the Bible. This is how many larger church organizations have begun, and it is to Nymphas' credit, the man from Laodicea, that he was willing to have this Bible study service in his home. Paul calls it, "the church which is in his house." And in connection with this Laodicean group, he says, "And when this letter is read among you [at Colosse], cause that it be read also in the church at Laodicea too, and that ye likewise read the letter that I've written to them."

"And say to Archippus, Take heed to the ministry which thou hast received in the Lord, that thou fulfil it" (Col. 4:17).

Now some have said that Archippus was Nymphas' son. That may very well be, but he was a teacher, probably at this house church in Laodicea. Yes he could have been in Colosse, but it would seem that it was in connection with this other church at Laodicea. Nevertheless Paul exhorts: "Say to Archippus, Take heed to the ministry which thou hast received in the Lord, that thou fulfill it." Perhaps Archippus was getting a little careless and had become too accustomed to his ministry. Paul had to write Timothy, "*stir up the gift of God, which is in thee,*" so we must constantly be on our guard, dear Christian friends. It is not easy and natural just to stand and speak out for Christ. We must "*stir up*" that gift and by His grace see that

that gift is improved and that we do it more and better as the days go by.

A FINAL WORD

"The salutation by the hand of me Paul. Remember my bonds. Grace be with you. Amen" (Col. 4:18).

To the Thessalonians he says, "The salutation of Paul with mine own hand, which is the token in every epistle: so I write" (II Thes. 3:17). That was his custom, to sign every letter with his own name, or rather, to write the closing salutation in his own hand.

Then he adds, "remember my bonds," and "grace be with you." Isn't it wonderful that every single one of Paul's letters, even that to the Hebrews, which is anonymous, closes with a word of grace!

"Salute all them that have the rule over you, and all the saints. They of Italy salute you. Grace be with you all. Amen" (Heb. 13:24,25).

"Grace be to you" are his opening and closing words in every one of his epistles. "Grace be unto you, and peace," that great declaration of "grace" and "peace," which, my dear friends, is the *theme* of all his letters, and that is our theme also. Grace to save, grace to keep, and grace to help us to be the kind of Christians we should.

A FINAL WORD TO THE UNSAVED

Oh, I should say a word here to any who may be still strangers to the wonderful grace of God. It was *in grace* that the Lord Jesus Christ came to Calvary, my dear friend, to bear all the penalty for your sins so that you might be free, justified before God, *accepted in the Beloved One* and pronounced *complete in Christ*.

Don't you want that, don't you long for it? Oh, you may have it by simply believing Christ.

"Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ and thou shalt be saved" (Acts 16:31).

"For by grace are ye saved through faith, and that not of yourselves, it is the gift of God, Not of works, lest any man should boast" (Eph. 2:8,9).

So if you'd like to be saved, just receive salvation as the gift of God through Christ. Trust Christ as your Savior and do let us know about it, so that we may pray for you, and send you some Bible study literature that will help you grow in your Christian faith.

Wouldn't you like to be as those mentioned in these closing salutations, whose lives counted for God, who contributed something worthwhile to their generation, who were not merely sitting there in the church. Wouldn't you rather desire to be used of God and have the high honor of being the bondslave of the Lord Jesus Christ, giving your life in service for Him? You may.

"The salutation by the hand of me Paul. Remember my bonds. Grace be with you. Amen."

Appendix 1

THE ONE TRUE CHURCH AND HOW TO JOIN IT

Many people have been saved and have truly come to know Christ after having been sincere, religious "church members" for years. Though faithful supporters of some earthly church organization, they had never experienced the truth of II Corinthians 5:7: *"If any man be in Christ he is a new creation."* It is possible to be a member in good standing of a church organization, yet be outside the one true Church of which the Bible speaks.

This is because the true Bible Church is not an organization, much less a political state. It is a living *organism,* a spiritual Body, with a living Head and living members. Again and again St. Paul, by divine inspiration, calls the Church the Body of Christ. He says: *"We, being many, are one Body in Christ"* (Rom. 12:5). *"Ye are the Body of Christ, and members in particular"* (I Cor. 12:27). *"We are members of His Body"* (Eph. 5:30).

It should be observed too, that the true Bible Church has one Head—not a man on earth, but the glorified Christ in heaven. Many times the Word of God declares that Christ is the one Head of the Church: *"[God] gave Him to be the Head over all things to the Church"* (Eph. 1:22). *"Christ is the Head of the Church"* (Eph. 5:23). *"He is the Head of the Body"* (Col. 1:18). Nowhere in Scripture do we read that any man is to act as His earthly representative as Head of the Body.

From all this it has already been made clear that God recognizes only one Church, the Body of Christ, as St. Paul declares in Ephesians 4:4,5: "*There* is one *Body*...one *Lord*, one *faith*."

How, then, do we become members of this one true Bible Church, the Body of Christ? First, we must acknowledge ourselves to be sinners in God's sight, for Ephesians 2 relates how Christ died for sinful men "*that He might* RECONCILE *both* [*Jew and Gentile*] unto God *in* one *Body by the Cross, having slain the enmity thereby*" (Ver. 16). Thus, when believing sinners are RECONCILED to God by faith in Christ, they are REGENERATED, given a new life, by the Spirit, and *by* the *Spirit* are BAPTIZED into the Church, the Body of Christ.

Titus 3:5: ***"Not by works of righteousness which we have* done, *but according* to *His mercy He saved us, by the washing of REGENERATION, and renewing of the Holy Ghost."***

I Corinthians 12:13: ***"For BY ONE SPIRIT ARE WE ALL BAPTIZED INTO ONE BODY."***

Every one of us should ask himself: "Have I been baptized by the Spirit into the Body of Christ?" Those who have not, do not belong to the one Church which God recognizes. But membership in the true Church is still open. Simply, but sincerely, trust Christ as your Savior. He is the Head of the Church. "*Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved*" (Acts 16:31). Then associate yourself with some local assembly where Christ is honored and the Bible taught, rightly divided. We will be glad to suggest such a place of worship.

For a **FREE packet** of **Bible study** literature, write to: BEREAN BIBLE SOCIETY, PO Box 756, Germantown, WI 53022.

Appendix 2

SALVATION BY BLOOD

A MATTER FOR PRAISE

Years ago a missionary family went to Alaska to make Christ known to the Eskimos. They rented a second-floor meeting place above a store, on the main street of a small Alaskan town. Here they planned to hold evangelistic services each week, but to their disappointment no one would attend. All the Eskimos were suspicious of these strange people who had come to live among them.

One of the leading Eskimos was determined to find out just what these foreigners were doing among them, so one Sunday morning, after the little band had gathered, he quietly entered the door at the bottom of the stairway and sat down to listen.

To the Eskimo's great consternation, the strangers were *singing* about *blood!* Appalled, he hurried out to spread the news among his neighbors and friends: "Beware of these people," he said; "they are up to no good, and they are dangerous. I heard them with my own ears, actually *singing* about *blood!*"

The poor Eskimo did not yet know the glad story these strangers had come to tell them; he did not know the vital and blessed truths that fill the hearts of believers as they sing about the blood of Christ, our blessed Redeemer; as they join in songs of praise such as Isaac Watts'

When I survey the wondrous Cross,
On which the Prince of glory died,
My richest gain I count but loss,
And pour contempt on all my pride.

Were the whole realm of nature mine,
That were a present far too small.
Love so amazing, so divine,
Demands my soul, my life, my all.

Or Edward Mote's great hymn:

My hope is built on nothing less
Than Jesus' blood and righteousness.
I dare not trust the sweetest frame,
But wholly lean on Jesus' name.

Or Charlotte Elliott's song of decision:

Just as I am, without one plea,
But that Thy blood was shed for me,
And that Thou bidst me come to Thee,
O, Lamb of God, I come.

Or P. P. Bliss' glad refrain:

Hallelujah, 'tis done!
I believe on the Son.
I am saved by the blood of the crucified One!

PAUL AND THE BLOOD OF CHRIST

Few people realize that the Apostle Paul has more, far more, to say about the blood, the death, the Cross of Christ, than any other Bible writer. They do not realize that his "preaching of the Cross" is God's good news about what really happened at Calvary. Yes, the shed blood of Christ is the *sole basis* for Paul's whole grand message of grace, and never *before Paul* was this message proclaimed.

But did not our Lord, just before the Cross, say to His disciples: "*this is My blood..., which is shed for many, for the remission of sins*"? Ah, yes, but read the whole passage:

"For this is My blood of the New Testament [*Covenant*], which is shed for many for the remission of sins" (Matt. 26:28).

Speaking as the Hebrew Messiah to Hebrews, He made it clear that the shedding of His blood concerned the New Covenant, to be made "*with the house of Israel, and with the house of Judah*" (Jer. 31:31). Not until later did God raise up the Apostle Paul to proclaim "*the preaching of the Cross,*" the good news that Christ died for *all* (I Cor. 1:18-25).[1] Not until later did God, through Paul, invite us, Gentiles in the flesh, to partake of "the Lord's supper," in remembrance of His death for *our* sins.

Yes, the blood, the death, and the Cross of Christ are the sole basis for Paul's whole grand "*gospel of the grace of God*": justification by grace through faith alone, our baptism into Christ and His Body, the Church, our position in Christ at God's right hand and our "all spiritual blessings" there. All this, and much more, is based upon the blood of Christ, shed for us.

The death of Christ as the Mediator of the New Covenant was no mystery. The types prefigured it, the prophets predicted it and our Lord Himself kept telling His disciples that He would be put to death. Ah, but the death of Christ *as Paul proclaimed it* was indeed a mystery never before hinted at. It was a message of *grace*, pure *grace* to *all*, not based on *any* covenant or promise.

UNBELIEVERS AND THE BLOOD

Many people are ready and pleased to believe that God forgives sinners "according to the riches of His grace," but few accept the basic and underlying fact that:

"We have redemption *through His [Christ's] blood*," and that it is *on this basis alone* that God bestows on believing sinners "the forgiveness of sins according to the riches of His grace" (Eph. 1:7).

Man by nature is very self-righteous and is apt to resent being told that salvation was purchased for him by the shedding of Christ's blood. "Am I so bad," he protests, "that someone had to *die* to save me from paying for my sins?" The shedding of the blood of Christ in payment of his debt of sin is deeply offensive to him. This attitude is what Paul calls *"the offence of the Cross"* (Gal. 5:11).

This is the attitude of many clergymen too. Some time ago a liberal preacher declared: "The doctrine of salvation through the shed blood of Christ is loathsome to the finer senses." Yet it is one of the basic truths of the Word of God, one of the fundamentals of the Christian faith, that *"without [the] shedding of blood [there] is no remission"* (Heb. 9:22).

But, dear friend, if the thought of blood shed for sin is repugnant to you, let us hasten to assure you that it is repugnant to us too—and to God. But so is *sin* repugnant to God, and the fact that as Supreme Judge of all He *must condemn* and *punish* sin.

Let us then go back and consider the validity and importance of the Bible doctrine of salvation through the shed blood of Christ.

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF THE BLOOD

How significant is the blood to those of noble birth! How careful they are about whom they marry, for their children too must be high-born! How much is made of the brave men whose blood was shed, let's say, in the Revolutionary War; who gave their lives for us! How men boast if they are the descendants of these brave men, or if their ancestors came to this country on the Mayflower! How they boast who have the blood of great men flowing through their veins!

Indeed, how proud the most common parents are of their own children, their own "flesh and blood"! Within the family there may be many a quarrel, but let an outsider interfere, and they will all band together against him. There is no human tie so strong as the blood tie.

THE BIBLE AND THE BLOOD

As we search the Scriptures we find all this equally true. The children of Israel were forbidden to marry those of other nations, and to mingle their blood with that of pagan idolaters. The children of Abraham, Isaac and Israel were fiercely proud of their heritage. Moreover the blood line was particularly important in Old Testament times because Messiah had to be a blood descendant of David and of Abraham. But the greatest importance of the blood, Scripturally, lay in a truth declared in Leviticus 17:11, where God informed His people that "*the life of the flesh is in the blood*." The shedding of blood in vengeance or in malice or hatred, therefore, has always been considered a heinous crime.

Even apart from crime, the shedding of blood is "loathsome to the finer senses." This writer knew a

gifted surgeon, years ago, who retired at a comparatively early age. His reason? He said, "I've been a surgeon now for a considerable number of years, but somehow I just can't get used to 'that red stuff.'" Thus too, God views the shedding of human blood with abhorrence, and the shedding of blood in murder is declared to be a capital crime.

After Cain, the first murderer, had slain his brother, God called him to account and said,

"What hast thou done? the voice of thy brother's blood crieth unto Me from the ground" (Gen. 4:10).

Abel's blood cried to God for vengeance, as it were, and for his wickedness Cain was driven from the presence of God, a fugitive and a vagabond, wailing, "*My punishment is greater than I can bear*" (Gen. 4:13). Thus did God judge history's first murderer.

HUMAN GOVERNMENT AND BLOODSHED

This leads us to another important passage on the sacredness of the blood to God. Instituting the dispensation of Human Government, He said in Genesis 9:5,6:

"At the hand of every man's brother will I require the life of man. Whoso sheddeth man's blood, by man shall his blood be shed, for in the image of God made He man."

Man was, and still is, held accountable to carry out this directive. For fifteen hundred years God even incorporated this command into Israel's civil law. Six times in Numbers 35 alone God says, "*The murderer shall surely be put to death,*" and warns that bloodshed "*defileth the land, and the land cannot be cleansed of the blood that is shed therein, but by the blood of him that shed it*" (Ver. 33). Again and again,

in varied phraseology He warns, *Let not thine eye pity the murderer, lest your land be filled with blood.*

Modern man, of course, especially here in America, knows a better way! Instead of sufficiently pitying the victim and his bereaved loved ones, and taking appropriate steps to protect others whom the murderer might next attack, our courts are forever pitying the murderer, and as a result our land is indeed being "filled with blood," for the media in America report more news about murder and bloodshed than about any other one thing. One can hardly listen to a news broadcast or read a newspaper without learning about bloodshed—sometimes several cases of bloodshed—and think of the many, many cases that go unreported!

You say, "But this is the dispensation of Grace"? True, but the dispensation of Human Government also is still in force. The murderer, condemned to death, may find forgiveness and salvation because *"Christ died for our sins,"* but he must still answer to the government for his crime.

But if a murderer does not suffer capital punishment, he certainly suffers a condemning conscience to the end of his days on earth—and after that. Many murderers who have temporarily escaped judgment have been so conscience-stricken that they have voluntarily confessed their crimes and "given themselves up" to the authorities.

When our Lord was tried, His accusers cried out, *"Let him be crucified!" "His blood be on us and on our children"* (Matt. 27:22,25). But only a few months later they betrayed the guilt of their consciences as they complained to the apostles, *"ye...intend to bring this man's blood upon us"* (Acts 5:28). *Now* they were

not so eager to take the responsibility for the crucifixion of Christ and, as for Judas, His betrayer, his conscience drove him to return to the chief priests and throw his ill-gotten money down at their feet, confessing, *"I have betrayed the innocent blood"* (Matt. 27:3,4), after which he *"departed, and went and hanged himself"* (Ver. 5).

The liberal theologian who said that "the doctrine of salvation through the shed blood of Christ is loathsome to the finer senses" forgot or ignored the fact that sin too is loathsome, especially to a holy God, and that guilt and the fear of His just judgment upon sin is also a dreadful thing.

THE SHED BLOOD AND SALVATION FROM SIN

As a minister of the gospel who has, for many years, had much contact with people, this writer is sure that, even apart from murder, Hebrews 2:15 is true when it says that *"through fear of death"* the unsaved are *"all their lifetime subject to bondage."* One can talk freely to most men about any legitimate subject, but talk to the unsaved man about death, *his* death, and he "freezes." He consistently avoids talking or even thinking seriously about death. He is so afraid of it that he even avoids making preparations for it and acts as though death will never overtake *him*, fearing all the while, however, that it will! Then he departs this life unprepared and doomed to the judgment he has brought upon himself.

How regrettable this is in the light of the fact that the drastic remedy which man's dreadful malady calls for has already been provided by God in the death of Christ at Calvary.

Of all the long line of Old Testament passages dealing with atoning blood, Leviticus 17:11 is the foremost. Here God says:

"The *life* of the flesh is *in the blood,* and I have given it to you upon the altar to make an atonement for your souls."

The shedding of animal blood in Old Testament times was, of course, symbolic and typical, for Hebrews 10:4 rightly points out that the blood of bulls and of goats *cannot* take away sins. Animal sacrifices, however, taught their lesson. Imagine the impact of the first animal sacrifice upon Adam and Eve. We can almost see them, as the first quivering, dying animals were sacrificed to provide coverings for their nakedness—we can almost see them wringing their hands and saying: "What have we done! Oh, what have we done!" What conviction of sin this incident must have wrought in their hearts!

Graciously, however, God had planned, and has since revealed to us, that *Christ's* blood was to be shed for our sins and for the "sins that are past" (Rom. 3:25, i.e., the sins committed by those of former ages).

As to believers of past dispensations, it was because they *did what God told them to do,* in faith offering their animal sacrifices, that God accepted them, applying to them Christ's future payment for sin.

Thus it is that we read in Romans 5:8 that "while we were *yet* sinners Christ died for us." He speaks historically here of the human race, for Christ died for *us* long before we were born, even before some of the Roman believers were born. In eternity past, He saw us all in our sin and determined to pay the price of our redemption.

Here let us cite a few of the many passages in which Paul declares that we have *"the forgiveness of sins according to the riches of His grace,"* on the basis of the shed blood of Christ.

Romans 3:24: "Being justified freely, by His grace, *through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."*

Ephesians 2:13: "Ye who sometimes [once] were far off are made nigh by *the blood of Christ."*

Ephesians 2:16: "That He might reconcile both unto God in one Body by *the* Cross, having slain the enmity thereby."

Colossians 1:20: "Having made peace *through the blood of His* Cross."

Colossians 1:21,22: "And you, that were sometime [once] alienated and enemies in your mind by wicked works, yet now hath He reconciled. *In the body of His flesh, through death,* to present you holy and unblameable and unreproveable in His sight."

Mark well, these passages all speak of the *shedding* of Christ's blood, the *pouring out* of His life at Calvary. It was not because He had royal blood flowing through His veins that He could save us; it was because He *shed* His blood and *died* for us, paying in our stead the just penalty for our sins (See Romans 6:23).

In the light of the above, is it strange that believers should sing about the blood of Christ, shed in their behalf? Is it strange that they should rejoice in the truth of Hebrews 2:14,15:

"Forasmuch then as the children [of Adam] are partakers of flesh and blood, He [Christ] also Himself likewise took part of the same, *that through death He might destroy him that hath the power of death, that is, the devil;*

"And deliver them who through fear of death were all their lifetime subject to bondage."

What music to the convicted sinner's ears! Well does this writer remember how dreadfully afraid he was of death, but thank God this is no longer so. And, beloved Christian friend, if through physical infirmity or lack of faith you or I should be afraid when the time comes for us to leave this body, the fact remains that we *need not* fear death, for to us "to depart and to be with Christ...is *far better*," says the Apostle Paul in Philippians 1:23—far better not only than earth's troubles and sorrows, but far better, even, than its dearest treasures and joys.

THE BLOOD APPLIED

Here, however, we must emphasize a further important truth.

In I Peter 1:2 we read of salvation through "*obedience and sprinkling of the blood of Jesus Christ.*" Here the apostle, of course, uses Old Testament symbolism to bring out an important point to the sojourners of the Jewish dispersion.

When the Passover lamb was slain, *that* was not enough to save the Hebrew family from death. It was only when the blood had been sprinkled upon the upper lintel and doorposts of their houses that the families inside escaped death. The blood *must* be applied.

Similarly, the fact that Christ died and shed His blood to save sinners is *not* enough to save *you*, unsaved friend. You must *apply* the blood to *yourself*, to *your* case, as it were, saying in faith: "He died for *me*. I will trust *Him* for salvation, resting in His death as the full payment for *my* sins." Then comes the *joy* of salvation through the shed blood of Christ, the joy that caused the little missionary family in Alaska to *sing* about *blood!*

NO OTHER WAY

Cain was evidently a religious man. He was the first to suggest bringing a sacrifice to God. However, rather than bringing the blood sacrifice that God required, he arranged a beautiful offering of his own devising, the fruit of his toil, the fruit of the ground (which God had cursed). No doubt it was a lovely creation of greens, with some red tomatoes, some yellow carrots, some golden corn, etc. But what saith the Scripture?

"And the Lord had respect unto Abel and to his offering; but unto Cain and to his offering He had not respect" (Gen. 4:4,5).

And in Hebrews 11:4 we find this commentary:

"By faith Abel offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain, by which he obtained witness that he was righteous, God testifying of his gifts."

The words "by faith" in this passage indicate that God had instructed these brothers to bring a blood sacrifice, for *"faith cometh by hearing"* (Rom. 10:17). We believe—or do not believe—what we hear, and *hear* what has been *said*. Abel's sacrifice was "more excellent" than Cain's because it was brought *in faith*. He offered the sacrifice God had *told* him to bring, while Cain offered a sacrifice he thought was better, a sacrifice that expressed his self-will and self-righteousness rather than submission to God and faith in Him. Any such offering God refuses to accept.

When God thus rejected Cain's offering, we read that *"Cain was very wroth, and his countenance fell"* (Gen. 4:5).

"And the Lord said unto Cain, Why art thou wroth? And why is thy countenance fallen?

"If thou doest well, shalt thou not be accepted? And if thou doest not well, a sin offering[2] lieth at the door. And unto thee shall be his desire, and thou shalt rule over him" (Vers. 6,7).

Cain, like Abel, could have brought a blood sacrifice to God. Had he practiced "the obedience of faith," he would have done so. Indeed, even now, God gave him a chance, remonstrating with him for his attitude, and pleading with him, "If you do well, will I not accept you? And even if you do not well, that is, if you have sinned, you too can bring a sin offering."

The lesson is: There is only one way to God, and that is the way of the Cross. None of us has any intrinsic right to heaven or to acceptance with God. Heaven is God's, not ours. It is for Him to say whether or not we may enter. And since sin can never enter heaven, God has been more than gracious in paying the penalty for our sins Himself, so that we might be *"justified freely, by His grace, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus"* (Rom. 3:24).

Perhaps you have long gone your self-righteous way, thinking that your personal righteousness or your "good" deeds will obtain for you an entrance into the presence of God. If so, you had better change your thinking now, before it is too late. Listen to God's word to Cain and learn the lesson. If you were perfect, would not God accept you? But since you are not perfect, indeed far from perfect, there is only one way to find salvation and forgiveness—His *way*. Approach God acknowledging your sin and your desperate need. Come to Him with the sole plea that Christ shed His blood and died for you at Calvary. Come as you are, with all your sin, come in your desperation and your need and He will graciously accept you, but come pleading your own "goodness" and He will

surely turn you away. He will have no boasters in heaven (Eph. 2:8,9).

As this writer pointed out in a gospel tract, written many years ago:

"If you want to be saved from the just penalty of sin, remember this. There is one thing that God, the Judge of all, expects from you. He expects you to stop saying things in your own defense. It is not sin that keeps men out of heaven, it's their attitude. God, in His love, has made full provision for sin, paying the penalty Himself. But He has made no provision for a self-righteous attitude.

"Sometimes, you know, the defendant comes to the place where his attorney says to him, 'It will be to your advantage to plead guilty and throw yourself upon the mercy of the court.'

"This is exactly our position. How can we talk about our law-keeping when we are all so guilty of law-breaking? Keep defending yourself and God will *never* save you, for He will have no boasting in heaven—especially *false* boasting. But confess your guilt and throw yourself upon the mercy of God and He will graciously forgive you and justify you through Christ and His finished work of redemption."

This is why St. Paul exclaimed to one of his audiences:

"Be it known unto you therefore, men and brethren, that through this man [Christ] is preached unto you THE FORGIVENESS OF SINS; and by Him all that believe are JUSTIFIED FROM ALL THINGS, from which ye could not be justified by the Law of Moses" (Acts 13:38,39).

Don't continue on in "the way of Cain," for interestingly enough, while he was too cultured, too refined

to slay a lamb for sacrifice, he was *not* too refined to bludgeon his own brother to death in a fit of jealousy. This incident has its counterpart among the liberals of our day who have proclaimed salvation by good works as a better way than salvation by the blood. The results with them too have served only to point out the error of their doctrine, for they are largely responsible for the wickedness and immorality that have gripped the world of our day.

Unsaved reader, put away your self-righteousness, renounce "the way of Cain" and with humble heart acknowledge yourself to be the sinner for whom Christ died, trusting Him as your Lord and Savior. "*Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved*" (Acts 16:31).

Appendix 3

THE GLORIOUS SECURITY OF THE BELIEVER

1. Chosen in Christ before the foundation of the world—(Eph. 1:4; II Thes. 2:13).
2. Born (begotten) of God—(John 1:12,13; 3:6,7; Titus 3:5; I Pet. 1:23; I John 5:1).
3. God's workmanship, created in Christ—(II Cor. 5:16,17; Eph. 2:10).
4. Saved by grace, through faith, entirely apart from works—(Rom. 4:4,5; Eph. 2:8,9; Titus 3:5).
5. Made accepted in the Beloved One—(Eph. 1:6,7).
6. Justified by the finished work of Christ—(Acts 13:38,39; Rom. 3:24; 5:8,9; 8:33,34).
7. God's inheritance—(Eph. 1:18).
8. Sealed by the Spirit unto the day of redemption—(II Cor. 1:20-22; Eph. 1:13; 4:30).
9. Kept by the power of God —(Rom. 8:29-31; I Pet. 1:5; Jude 1,24).
10. Never can be separated from the love of Christ and of God—(John 13:1; Rom. 8:34-39).
11. Has received everlasting life—(John 3:36; 6:47; Rom. 6:23).
12. Shall never perish—(John 3:16; 6:37; 10:28).

13. Has a standing before God in grace—(Rom. 5:1,2; 6:14).
14. Has a standing before God in Christ—(II Cor. 5:16,17; Eph. 1:6; 2:10).
15. "Perfected forever" by "one offering"—(Heb. 10:10,14).
16. Already seated in the heavenlies in Christ—(Eph. 1:3; 2:6; Col. 3:1,2).
17. A member of the Body of Christ—(Rom. 12:5; I Cor. 12:12,27; Eph. 1:22,23; 5:30-32; Col. 1:18).
18. Built into the temple of God—(I Cor. 3:16; Eph. 2:19-22).

Introduction

1. See the writer's book: *The Dispensational Position of the Writings of John*.

Chapter 2

1. See Appendix 2 for a more comprehensive study on the blood of Christ.

Chapter 3

1. Although he is never called the firstborn, Joseph received the firstborn's inheritance (Gen. 48; 49:22-26).

2. Here, the author refers to the book entitled: "*The Secret of the Universe.*"

3. See Appendix 1.

Chapter 4

1. See Appendix 2.

2. See the author's booklet, "Ambassadors For Christ," with such sub-titles as: The Believer's Position On Earth; An Ambassador is an Official Representative of a Ruler or State; 2nd, An Ambassador is Always Sent to Another Nation, Never His Own; 3rd, An Exchange of Ambassadors Denotes a State of Peace; 4th, Ambassadors Are Withdrawn When War Is Declared; and finally, How Man Declared War on God. God has not yet declared war on this world, but has left us, believers, here as ambassadors on enemy territory.

3. A baptism of repentance that everybody went to, confessing their sins.

4. See Appendix 3, a list of 18 reasons for the glorious security of the believer in Christ.

Chapter 5

1. "Possessions"—real estate; "goods"—personal property.

2. The last two expressions in this sentence are found only in this passage. The idea is, that they be generous *contributors.*

3. The "whatsoever" promises are found only in one small portion of the Bible—that which records our Lord's earthly ministry, and the promise: "the prayer of faith shall save the sick" is addressed by *James* to "the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad" (Jas. 1:1). See the author's booklet: *Unanswered Prayer*.

Chapter 7

1. These words, "Now therefore, if ye will obey My voice indeed, and keep *My Covenant*, then ye shall be a peculiar treasure unto Me above all people: for all the earth is Mine" (Ex. 19:5), are found just before the giving of the Law in Exodus 19. While God gave the Law in Exodus and Leviticus, its conclusion is not seen until the final warnings in Deuteronomy.

2. We have a booklet entitled, *Paul the Masterbuilder*, which we highly recommend for those who have not yet seen the distinctive character of Paul's apostleship and ministry. Many people have been helped and blessed through the literature ministry of *Berean Bible Society*. Be a missionary and help us get the message of grace out to others.

3. In the words: "Him…Ye have taken, and by wicked hands have crucified and slain" (Acts 2:23).

4. We have a booklet here, at *Berean Bible Society*, entitled *"Sonship"* which goes into this subject of Bible "adoption," and shows what the believer's position is *"in Christ,"* what his rights and privileges are in Christ. Many have found it to be a real blessing, be sure to write for it.

Chapter 8

1. Oh how beautiful is the grace of God! And how very different from what we read in the so-called Lord's prayer, which was conditional—"if you forgive, I'll forgive" God said—but under grace, *forgive*, because you've been forgiven! See the author's booklet, "The Lord's Prayer and the Lord's People Today."

2. I'm afraid that we as believers don't leave everything to Him enough. I talked with a lady that Mrs. Stam and I had

met once in a restaurant down South. This young waitress got talking with us, and wanted to know where we were from, and soon we were talking about the Lord, and about her own spiritual welfare; was she truly a born-again Christian, was she trusting Christ as her Savior? "Oh, indeed I am" she replied, adding, "Do you know the Lord taught me something so wonderful just recently?"

And then she told us about her seven month old little baby, and how when that baby was two months old that she had contracted a very serious disease for a little child of that age. The doctors told her, "She can't live for two more weeks, so don't be too disappointed. Your baby's going to die." And how she had cried and prayed and claimed deliverance for that baby, and said how the Lord had promised to answer prayer and so on. And she said the time went by. One week was gone and the baby was much worse. And the doctors said, "She may go in just a few days. Prepare yourself." And then she said, "I realized that I wasn't praying in the right way. And I went to my knees that night and I said, Lord, now, I know perfectly well that You'll do what's best for me. I know You love me, You've said it in Your Word, and I believe it. And whatever You do, I know it's for the best, so just help me to understand that somehow. Help me to understand that You're working things out for my good." And she said, "I just left it with the Lord that way and I felt much better and what do you think? The next day when I came to the hospital, they greeted me with smiles and said, 'It looks like your baby's going to pull through.' And soon, she was completely over her illness, and now she's a child of seven months old." She said, "Oh, was I a happy girl. Was I glad that I had just left it with the Lord."

Appendix 2

1. As to John 3:14-16, see the writer's brochure on *John 3:16*. Also, remember that our Lord Himself and His twelve apostles were sent *only* to "the lost sheep of *the house of Israel*" (Matt. 15:24; 10:6). They did not proclaim the truth of John 3:16 to the Gentiles.

2. The word for sin and sin offering are the same in Hebrew.

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